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TMC(M) exits NDA after executive committee meet

CHENNAI
The Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) on Sunday decided to exit the National Democratic Alliance. Party leader G.K. Vasan made the announcement after chairing its executive committee meeting in Chennai. » PAGE 4

'AIADMK chief suppressing dissent in party'

VILLUPURAM
AIADMK rebel leader C. Ve. Shanmugam on Sunday accused party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami of suppressing dissent in the party. » PAGE 4

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Modi, Macron bilateral talk stresses economic security

India, France adopt 'Innovation Roadmap 2030', establish 'Economic Security Dialogue' as the two leaders meet in French city of Nice; meet calls for fast adoption of India-EU FTA, AI cooperation

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

India and France adopted an 'Innovation Roadmap 2030' and established a Dialogue on Economic Security during bilateral talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron held in Nice on Sunday.

A press release from the government outlined a number of themes – including calling for the fast adoption of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement (FTA).

Earlier this year, the two countries had renamed their partnership a 'Special Global Strategic Partnership' to reflect an enhanced level of cooperation.

No traditional 'joint statement' had emerged from the meeting as of this writing.

"Recognising the key role of innovation and technology in the bilateral relationship, both sides adopted an 'Innovation Roadmap 2030' to give the partnership a long-term direction," the press release said, with the two leaders agreeing to create a Joint India-France AI Working Group to expand cooperation in AI. They also noted the signing of 19 agreements between entities in the innovation ecosystems of the two countries.

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Eyeing the sky: PM Narendra Modi takes in the sea with French President Emmanuel Macron ahead of talks in Nice on Sunday. AP

Modi, Macron open Bharat Innovates 2026

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron on Sunday co-inaugurated the Bharat Innovates 2026 in Nice where the leaders focused on trust and cooperation in technology. Mr. Modi invited investors to "design and develop in India" to "create solutions for the world", while Mr. Macron said India brings the reliability that the world seeks at moments of upheaval in geopolitics.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 10

Iran questions U.S. push for truce after Israel hits Beirut

Associated Press
Reuters
DUBAI/WASHINGTON

Iran's top negotiator on Sunday questioned the U.S.'s commitment to peace efforts after Israel carried out new attacks on Lebanon, dimming prospects of Tehran and Washington signing a framework agreement on ending their war during the day as claimed by U.S. President Donald Trump.

Qatari negotiators flew to Tehran on Sunday morning as part of an effort to finalise the agreement, according to sources. But Iranian negotiator and Parliament Speaker Mohammad-Bagher Ghalibaf said on Sunday that Israel's attack showed the U.S. lacked the will or ability to fulfil its commitments.

"If you lack the will and ability to fulfil your commitments, speaking of continuing the path is not possible," Mr. Ghalibaf wrote on X, in an apparent reference to peace moves.

Following Israel's attack, Mr. Trump on Sunday said the strikes on Lebanese capital, Beirut, "should not have happened" as he vowed a peace deal was at hand, though he did not confirm his earlier claim it would be signed during the day.

Mr. Trump, who, in a phone call to the Axios news outlet, said the deal was still on track to be signed within hours, fumed at Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu over the attack on Beirut, saying, "it is so bad – I couldn't believe it. An hour before we are supposed to sign the deal."

In a sign that a diplomatic off-ramp was still available, Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Sunday that the country's highest security body supported negotiations despite criticism from hardliners.

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THREE KILLED IN BEIRUT
» PAGE 14

Israel's latest strikes showed U.S. lacked the will or ability to fulfil its commitments, the Iranian Speaker said on Sunday. AFP

Indian-flagged sailing vessel sinks off Oman; crew rescued

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

All 14 crew members of an Indian-flagged mechanised sailing vessel, *MSV Virat 1,* were rescued on Sunday after it experienced engine failure and sank off the coast of Oman.

The crew members are "safe and in good health", the Indian Embassy in Oman said in a post on X, adding that they were moved to a vessel which is heading to Mumbai. The Mumbai-bound vessel, *MV Jabal Ali*, is learnt to be a cargo ship.

"Rescue operation involving Indian-flagged *MSV Virat 1* has been successfully completed. All 14 crew members have been rescued and are presently onboard *Jabal Ali 9* heading to Mumbai," the mission said. The incident comes amid heightened tensions in the region where three Indian seafarers were killed last week amid repeated U.S. attacks on vessels with Indian links.

Often based in Mumbai and Mandvi, Indian mechanised sailing vessels are smaller crafts that carry limited supplies, typically perishable food items, to the Persian Gulf countries.

The *MSV Virat 1,* reported to be 50 metres in length and 12 metres in breadth, was sailing off the coast of Oman when its engine failed, prompting the crew members to transfer to a life-raft before being rescued.

(With PTI inputs)

A photo shared by the Indian Embassy in Oman on X on Sunday shows the crew members rescued off Oman. X/@INDEMB_MUSCAT

Seven held over lynching of Kerala man in West Bengal

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Five people were arrested and two minors detained at Kultali in South 24 Parganas district of West Bengal on Sunday after a 30-year-old man from Kerala was allegedly lynched on suspicion of being a thief on June 9. *"Prima facie,* the villagers have beaten him to death over suspicion of being a thief. However, some villagers alleged that he had harassed a pregnant woman that enraged the local people," a senior police officer from Baruipur sub-division said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

HC rejects plea against Fujitsu General in $19-million air-conditioner sales dispute

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has refused to dismiss a civil suit filed by Fujitsu General (Thailand) Company Limited, represented by its director Noriaki Terashima, seeking a direction to the Chennai-based ETA (Emirates Trading Agency) General Private Limited to pay $19 million with interest at the rate of 6% per annum from April 6, 2022, till the date of realisation.

A Division Bench of Justices P. Velmurugan and K. Govindarajan Thilakavadi dismissed an original side appeal preferred by ETA General in 2024 against a single judge's 2023 order rejecting the company's application to dismiss the suit for recovery of money and instead refer the financial dispute for arbitration.

The Bench confirmed Justice P.T. Asha's September 29, 2023 order that the purchase orders of air-conditioners placed by ETA General and the invoices raised by Fujitsu General (Thailand) in 2019 were independent of the agreements that ETA General had entered into with the parent company, Fujitsu General Limited (FGL) of Japan, and hence the matter need not be referred for arbitration.

Opposing the suit before the single judge, ETA General had said FGL and its subsidiary Fujistu General (Asia) Pte Limited, based in Singapore, had entered into a Master Technical Licence and Distribution Agreement with the Chennai-based company on December 22, 1999. Pursuant to this agreement, ETA General had been manufacturing and marketing the General brand of air conditioners in India.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 4

Argument upheld: Fujitsu General had sought a direction to the Chennai-based ETA General Private Limited to pay $19 million with 6% interest per annum from April 6, 2022. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

INDIA ON TOP

THREE GALGOTIANS. ONE GLOBAL STAGE.
A PROUD MOMENT FOR GALGOTIAS UNIVERSITY.
AN EVEN PROUDER MOMENT FOR INDIA.

Winning the Top Prize at EDVentures 2026
Student Entrepreneurship and Ideation Challenge

Hong Kong

Defeating 19 Teams from 10 Nations

PROUD GALGOTIANS

Shristi Mandoliya (2nd from left)
Second-Year B. Tech CSE
(Data Science)
Class of 2028

Gaurang Pant (3rd from left)
Third-Year B. Tech CSE
Class of 2027

Kavya Singh (1st from right)
Third-Year BBA
(Financial Investment and Analysis)
Class of 2026

Top Prize Winner EDVentures 2026, Hong Kong	AWS Championship Prize Winner	Total Prize Money & Support: USD 7,000

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INBRIEF

Rotary club presents awards for various achievements

The Rotary Club of Kilpauk presented awards to recognise outstanding achievers in three categories. Justice P.N. Prakash, former Madras High Court judge, presented the Vocational Excellence Award to eminent cardiologist Dr. G. Sengottuvelu, the Sake of Honour Award to Chinny Krishna, founder of Blue Cross, and the Young Achiever Award to teen sailor Shreya Krishna. Rotary Club secretary P.C.R. Suresh said that more than 18 persons had been recognised for various achievements in the last 10 years. Club president Karthik Surendran highlighted key projects for hearing impaired children and free dialysis centres in Saidapet and Anna Nagar.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (June 15, Monday), the following articles are available:

- Can India protect its seafarers in the Gulf? **newsth.live/attackonships**
- Deaths in Brazil raise concerns about India's dengue vaccine, DengiAll **newsth.live/denguevaccine**

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

New syllabus for Classes 1-3 rolls out accessible textbooks and interactive worksheets

The new textbooks for children with disabilities have been simplified, with more pictures, white space, and repetition. These have been curated specifically for Tamil, English, and Mathematics

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

In a bid to make textbooks accessible for children with disabilities, the new curriculum for Classes 1-3, designed by the State Council of Educational Research and Training, has adapted textbooks to their needs.

From children with specific learning disability to neurodivergent children, the new textbooks are designed to ensure that their learning outcomes are also met.

The inclusive textbooks have been simplified for children with disabilities, with more pictures, white space, and repetition.

"We prioritised accessibility over sheer volume so as to avoid sensory overload, which can be the case with a standard textbook," an official from the School Education Department said.

The department used the Pictorial-Abstract-Concrete approach, where the child transitions from tangible objects to visual representations, and finally to abstract symbols, to anchor their basic literacy and numeracy. It uses simple language and exercises, tailored to their learning needs.

Inclusive initiative: The children can access the audio lessons and worksheets from the QR codes printed in the textbooks. FILE PHOTO

"The streamlined textbook and worksheets feature a spacious layout with generous writing spaces and significantly larger fonts. These textbooks have been curated specifically for Tamil, English, and Mathematics," the official said.

Sign language videos

"The child can access the adapted and audio versions of the textbooks from the QR code printed in the textbooks, and there are sign language videos for deaf children on Kalvi TV," the official added.

Along these lines, the department, in a first, has come out with interactive worksheets. They comprise games based on the lessons taken in class. These will help the child grasp the concept more effectively, the official adds.

The difficulty level of the game increases in line with the concepts taught in Classes 1-5, but the base remains the same. "In counting, which begins from Class 1, they [students] will have to arrange the numbers in the ascending and descending order, and then comes addition, and so forth," the official said.

These have been designed for Classes 1-3 for English and Mathematics, and will soon be designed for Tamil too. In the textbooks, QR codes to the exercises are given after the lessons, he said.

"Parents might find it difficult to keep up with their child's learning. These would pave the way for the child and the parent to understand what happens in class and where their child stands in learning," the official added.

Dignitaries at the 2nd Annual Congress WOC India – Chennai Sports Injury Conclave 2026 held in Chennai on Sunday. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

Experts at conclave discuss advances in sports injury care

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The India Chapter of the World Orthopaedic Concern (WOC), in association with Apollo Hospitals, conducted the 2nd Annual Congress WOC India - Chennai Sports Injury Conclave 2026 here on Sunday.

The academic conference brought together over 250 orthopaedic surgeons, sports medicine specialists, clinicians, and healthcare professionals from across the country to discuss the latest developments in sports injury prevention, diagnosis, treatment, and rehabilitation.

At a press conference, Organising Chairman Navaladi Shankar, Senior Consultant Orthopaedic Surgeon at Apollo Hospitals, Chennai, said many injuries occur due to inadequate training, improper techniques, and overuse, and stressed the need for awareness on injury prevention and management as more people participate in fitness activities.

Arindam Banerjee, president of WOC International and WOC India, said, "We serve as a bridge between countries that possess advanced orthopaedic resources and those that lack adequate healthcare infrastructure. In the past, India itself benefited greatly from WOC's support. Today, I am proud to say that India has become a net contributor rather than a recipient."

S. Saseendar, vice-president of WOC India; Samundeeswari S., Joint Secretary of WOC India; and Alberto Gregori, consultant orthopedic surgeon from the U.K., were present.

Villivakkam Lake and link pond set for year-round water supply

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Villivakkam Lake, and an 8.5-acre pond being developed adjacent to it, are set to receive five million litres of water daily from a sewage treatment plant to ensure that both the waterbodies retain water throughout the year, the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) said.

A press release said the pond is being constructed at a cost of ₹7.90 crore, in compliance with the directions of the National Green Tribunal. It is linked to the lake through pipelines.

The project also includes a 900-metre-long walkway, landscaped green spaces covering 11,400 sq.m., and lake bund strengthening works using geotextile and geo-grid technologies.

In the second phase of the project, the lake will get facilities such as a musical fountain, boating, fishing decks and theatres

The Villivakkam Lake, spread across 27.5 acres of land handed over by the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board (CMWSSB), has seen an increase in its water-holding capacity after desilting and restoration measures carried out under the Smart City Mission.

First phase of the project

The first phase of the project included the formation of lake bunds, walkways, seating areas, drinking water facilities, an administrative block, and a stormwater drain to channel rainwater into the lake. A glass suspension bridge was also constructed.

The second phase, proposed under a public-private partnership model, will include facilities such as a musical fountain, boating, fishing decks, water slides, a bird park, an aquarium, play areas, fitness facilities, restaurants, a skating rink, theatres, and parking infrastructure.

According to the release, the arrangement is expected to generate an annual revenue of about ₹1 crore for the GCC. The maintenance costs will be borne by the private operator.

GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran inspected the works on Sunday and directed officials to expedite their completion.

Flight from Kenya makes priority landing in bid to save infant with heart condition

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

An aircraft made priority landing at the Chennai International Airport after a 58-day-old infant's health condition deteriorated onboard on Saturday.

The parents - Mwai and Muthoni - who were citizens of Kenya, were on their way to a private hospital in Manapakkam, Chennai, to get medical treatment for the infant's heart condition.

On noticing the deteriorating condition of the child, they informed the cabin crew about it, following which the flight captain requested priority landing for the flight.

The child was to get treated at a private hospital in the city, but it was declared dead on arrival at the Chennai airport

According to the police, the aircraft was permitted priority landing 23 minutes ahead of the scheduled time of arrival at 8.15 a.m.

After the aircraft landed at 7.52 a.m., the medical team at the airport immediately examined the infant and declared the child dead.

The body of the infant was taken to the Chengalpattu Government Medical College Hospital for a postmortem examination.

THE HINDU
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APPOINTMENT

V.O.Chidambaranar Port Authority
General Administration Department, Tuticorin
(An Autonomous Body under MoPSW, GoI)

GAD-EST10ESTC/3/2025-GAD(7392)/D. Date:15.06.2026

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For details regarding upper age limit, educational qualifications, etc., visit VOC Ports' website at www.vocport.gov.in (careers). Last date for the receipt of applications is 14.07.2026.

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INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI-38
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The following e-tender is published in IREPS website. Firms details about Eligibility and other Terms & Conditions, please refer website https://www.ireps.gov.in. Manual Offers will not be entertained for the tender.

Tender No.	Name of the work	Date of Tender	
		Closing	Opening
2026472212247	Setting up of Disaster Recovery Solution at D&D Centre	09.07.2026 15.00 Hrs.	09.07.2026 After 15.00 Hrs.

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI-38
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Tender No.	Name of the work	Date of Tender	
		Closing	Opening
2026472212262	Upgradation of STAR-CCM Software Licenses for CFD analysis	06.07.2026 15.00 Hrs.	06.07.2026 After 15.00 Hrs.

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From Page One

HC rejects plea against Fujitsu General in $19 m dispute in sale of ACs

However, ETA General had to close down its manufacturing unit in Puducherry since FGL was unable to supply the engineers. However, Fujitsu General (Thailand) continued to supply the air conditioners to ETA General for their sale in India. In 2018, FGL floated Fujitsu General (India) Private Limited and in 2019, it decided to terminate the agreement with ETA General and instead do business in India on its own from 2020.

Since the 1999 Master Technical Licence and Distribution Agreement as well as the other agreements such as the shareholders agreement that ETA had entered into with FGL and its group companies contained an arbitration clause, the Chennai-based company insisted that the suit filed by Fujitsu General (Thailand) for recovery of $19 million be dismissed and the dispute be referred for arbitration.

Justice Asha had rejected the plea for dismissal of the suit after holding that those agreements had nothing to do with the purchase orders and the invoices for which the recovery proceedings had been initiated. "The question of group concept cannot be brought into the instant case, particularly when transactions that are contemplated under these agreements and the purchase orders between the defendant and the plaintiff stand on two independent and distinct contracts. Therefore, the application filed for referring the parties to arbitration is without merit and is therefore dismissed," the judge had written.

INBRIEF

Gautami quits AIADMK citing 'prevailing political situation'

Actor and AIADMK deputy propaganda secretary Gautami Tadimalla quit the party on Sunday. She announced her decision on social media. "With a heavy heart, I have resigned from the AIADMK today," she said in a post. "Considering the prevailing political situation and to involve myself in social service, I resign from the primary membership of the AIADMK as well as my post as the party's deputy propaganda secretary with a heavy heart, effective today [June 14, 2026]," Ms. Tadimalla said in her letter to AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami.Ms. Tadimalla was previously with the BJP for 25 years and quit the party in October 2023.

Applications invited to appoint non-hereditary temple trustees

Seeking to ensure transparency in the appointment of non-hereditary trustees for 214 temples under its control in Tamil Nadu, the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE) Department has issued a notification inviting applications. The temples include the Palani Dhandayuthapani Temple and the Samayapuram Mariamman Temple. According to the notification, those interested can submit their applications, along with the required documents, before 5.45 p.m. on July 22. The eligibility criteria have been published on the department's website. Applications, along with the necessary documents, can be uploaded online, submitted in person, or sent by Speed Post.

C.Ve. Shanmugam hits out at Palaniswami, accuses him of suppressing dissent in party

The rebel leader and Mailam MLA says the AIADMK is falling into the clutches of a single family and alleges that the general secretary is staging a 'drama' to facilitate his son's entry into the party

The Hindu Bureau
VILLUPURAM

AIADMK rebel leader and Mailam MLA C. Ve. Shanmugam on Sunday accused party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami of refusing to correct errors and suppressing dissent in the party.

Speaking to reporters at Tindivanam, Mr. Shanmugam said the AIADMK was founded on the principle that any of its workers could become the Chief Minister, a Minister, or a Member of Parliament, and this principle attracted lakhs of people to the party. He said the AIADMK was not a family outfit, but a cadre-based party. He claimed that 31 of the 47 constituencies won by the AIADMK in the 2026 Assembly election were "alms" given by the Pattali Makkal Kattchi (PMK). If the PMK was not in the alliance, Mr. Palaniswami would have struggled but still would have won.

C.Ve. Shanmugam

Mr. Shanmugam said that today, the party was falling into the clutches of a single family and accused Mr. Palaniswami of staging a "drama" to facilitate his son's entry into the party. "Anyone can enter politics, and the general secretary's son, too, can enter politics. There is no second opinion on this point. Hence, what is the need to stage a drama," he asked.

Pointing out that the party had suffered a series of defeats owing to a lust for money and power, Mr. Shanmugam urged Mr. Palaniswami to take everyone along and convene a general council meeting on a convenient date to discuss the reasons for the defeats. "He should at least convene the executive council, invite all of its members, and discuss the reasons for the defeats and what action needs to be taken. Why are you hesitant to convene the meeting," he asked.

Differences of opinion were part of democracy, and no one was bigger than "Amma" (late Chief Minister Jayalalithaa), who within two years of a defeat in 1996 secured alliances and achieved a massive victory, Mr. Shanmugam said, recalling that she had inducted those who took contradictory stands into the party and made them Ministers. When the party faced a major defeat in 1996, she accepted responsibility. But, even after a string of defeats, no one was taking responsibility today, he added.

He warned the leadership not to live in a dream world, protect the party founded by M.G. Ramachandran, and not destroy it because of ego. "If pushed to the extreme, the dissenters will be forced to take their own course of action," he said.

TMC(M) exits NDA, but Vasan says no differences with allies

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) (TMC (M)) on Sunday decided to exit the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) hoping to focus on strengthening the party.

TMC(M) leader G.K. Vasan made the announcement after chairing the party's executive committee meeting in Chennai. However, Mr. Vasan maintained his party did not have any difference of opinion either with the BJP or with the AIADMK or other allies in the NDA.

G.K. Vasan

'Alliance for elections'

TMC functionaries, he said, were of the opinion that in an alliance, the party functionaries had lesser responsibilities and for the TMC(M) to grow as a political movement, it needed to function independently. However, Mr. Vasan also said that alliance was needed for elections. He acknowledged that the alliance his party was a part of could not win the elections during the past few years in Tamil Nadu.

"The TMC(M) is leaving the NDA, even as it remains on friendly terms with the other constituents," Mr. Vasan said. The decision, he hoped, would help the party strengthen itself.

The TMC(M) is the first party to leave the AIADMK-led NDA in Tamil Nadu after the recent Assembly elections, where the alliance was pushed to the third place.

Restore Sathangadu Lake to original extent of 135 acres, remove encroachments on 65 acres: TNIC

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Information Commission (TNIC) has urged the State government to evict encroachments and restore Sathangadu Lake in Tiruvallur district to its original geographical extent of 135 acres from the present 70 acres.

With Revenue Department officials admitting in writing that nearly 60 acres of the lake had been encroached upon by various public and private organisations, including Government of India undertakings, State Information Commissioner R. Priyakumar asked the Tiruvallur Collector to accord top priority to the issue and take stringent action in accordance with the law to restore the lake in its entirety.

He also requested the Commissioner of Revenue Administration and Disaster Management to directly supervise the eviction of encroachments and ensure measures were taken to protect the lake from future encroachments. The Public Information Officer (PIO) of the Revenue Department was directed to appear in person before the Commission and submit an action taken report on July 30.

Key resource: The Sathangadu Lake is not only a major source of water for several areas in north Chennai but also serves as a habitat for numerous species of migratory birds. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

The case arose from a petition filed by S. Anandan of Manali, who stated the original extent of Sathangadu Lake, measuring 135 acres, had shrunk to 70 acres due to encroachments over the years. Seeking details of the lake's extent as per official records, he filed an application under the Right to Information Act, 2005.

The petitioner also submitted a report published in *The Hindu* on March 28, 2008, in which the then Tiruvallur Collector was quoted as stating the lake extended over 135 acres. As no satisfactory reply was forthcoming from the PIO or the First Appellate Authority, Mr. Anandan filed an appeal before the TNIC.

When the matter came up before Mr. Priyakumar, he directed the Tiruvottiyur Tahsildar to furnish information on the lake's extent as recorded in official documents and details of encroachments, if any.

He warned that the maximum penalty of ₹25,000 would be imposed on the PIO and disciplinary action initiated if he failed to provide the information sought by the petitioner.

Joint inspection done

In his report, the Tahsildar informed the Commission a joint inspection had been conducted in the lake area along with officials from the Survey Department.

The inspection revealed that two public sector enterprises under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, Government of India, with offices located in Sathangadu and two private petrochemical companies had encroached upon nearly 10 acres of the waterbody for more than 15 to 20 years. The report further stated a residential area named MGR Nagar, spread over nearly 10 acres, was home to around 200 families. The encroachments also included a temple and a public toilet constructed by the State government.

Expressing serious concern over the encroachments and their impact on the environment and water resources in the locality, Mr. Priyakumar observed protecting waterbodies was not only the duty of the government but also a collective responsibility of the people.

Speaking to *The Hindu* on the issue, Mr. Priyakumar said Sathangadu Lake was not only a major source of water for several residential and industrial areas in north Chennai but also served as a habitat for numerous species of migratory birds.

The destruction of the waterbody through unchecked encroachments, he said, would cause irreversible damage to both the environment and industry.

He said his recommendation to the appropriate authorities to evict encroachments and restore the waterbody were based on G.O. (Ms.) No. 540 of the Tamil Nadu government, which mandated all District Collectors to form redressal committees for removing encroachments on government lands, as well as the Tamil Nadu Protection of Tanks and Eviction of Encroachment Act, 2007.

Mr. Priyakumar further stated his order was in consonance with several Supreme Court rulings that came down heavily on encroachments on waterbodies.

White Paper on Tangedco soon: Minister Nirmalkumar

L. Srikrishna
MADURAI

The State government will soon table a White Paper on the functioning of the Tamil Nadu Generation and Distribution Corporation Limited (Tangedco), Minister for Energy Resources and Law R. Nirmalkumar said here on Sunday.

Interacting with journalists, he blamed former Electricity Minister V. Senthilbalaji for having "ruined Tangedco". Malpractice, maladministration, and mismanagement had pulled down the department. There was corruption and favouritism in floating of tenders, purchase of transformers, or sanctioning of licences to new applicants seeking to enter the renewable energy sector.

Instead of encouraging entrepreneurs to set up units, the DMK government was only keen on making money and keeping a few beneficiaries happy. Thus, genuine business groups relocated to other States, he alleged.

"For each megawatt, Mr. Senthilbalaji had demanded ₹25 lakh as commission from the applicants through his loyalists," he alleged.

The fate of Nagapattinam's lost vihara mentioned in Anaimangalam copper plates

K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

The celebrated Anaimangalam copper plates – commonly known as the Leiden plates – are expected to return to India soon. This historic repatriation brings renewed focus onto a centuries-old mystery: what actually became of the grand, Chola-backed Buddhist monastery and the tax-free lands recorded in these famous inscriptions?

In the 11th Century, Rajaraja Chola I donated the village of Anaimangalam and its surrounding lands to the Chudamani Varma Vihara in the port city of Nagapattinam. The construction of this monastery was initiated in 1005 CE by King Chudamani Varman of Kadaram (the Sri Vijaya Kingdom) and was completed by his son, King Maravijayottunggavarman, who dedicated it to his father's memory.

Rajaraja made the land grant during the 21st year of his reign, but following his demise, it was his son, Rajendra Chola I (Madhurantakan), who officially documented the boundaries of the gift on 21 copper plates in 1035 CE. The land was designated as Pallichchandham (tax-free land gifted to non-Hindu religious institutions). Decades later, around 1090 CE, the ruler of Sri Vijaya dispatched two envoys to Kulothunga Chola I – Rajendra's grandson. The envoys requested a fresh charter to reaffirm the gift, evict external squatters, and hand exclusive territorial custody back to the monastery. Kulothunga issued a secondary set of three copper plates accordingly.

Eventually finding their way to Europe, these historic documents were preserved at Leiden University in the Netherlands. They were fully deciphered by epigraphists Pandit Natesa Aiyar in the late 19th Century and K.V. Subrahmanya Aiyar in the 1930s.

In the late 1960s, historian Achyuthan Govindan Kutty (K.A.) Menon joined the university and conducted extensive research by correlating the plates with later Dutch and local records. "I went there in September 1968," Mr. Menon explained to *The Hindu*. "At that time, it was easy to access and examine those copper plates. Since they had already been deciphered, I analysed their data alongside later Nayak-period records and Dutch documents."

Historical record: The Anaimangalam plates document lands donated to a Chola-backed Buddhist monastery in Nagapattinam.

Mr. Menon published his findings in a research paper titled, *Copper Plates to Silver Plates: Cholas, Dutch and Buddhism*, which provides critical details on the Vihara's nomenclature, the transformation of the village names, and the eventual destruction of the monastery. By the 19th Century, Buddhism had long vanished from the Coromandel Coast, but the imposing brick skeleton of the monastery still stood. Known locally as the *Pudhuveli Gopuram*, the structure served as a coastal landmark for international ships sailing the Bay of Bengal.

In 1846, British civil servant Sir W. Elliot surveyed the ruins, deeply impressed by its unique architectural design. In an 1878 record, Elliot described the Vihara as: "...a somewhat four-sided tower of three stories, constructed on bricks closely fitted together without cement, the first and second stories divided by corniced mouldings, with an opening for a door or window in the middle of each side... The top was open."

Erasure of past

Despite its immense archaeological value, the ancient tower met a tragic end. In 1859, French Jesuit priests petitioned to clear the historic structure. Overriding initial hesitations from regional authorities, a final demolition order was signed on August 28, 1867. The three-story tower, which had survived nearly nine centuries of coastal weather and changing dynasties, was completely levelled.

While the physical monastery was erased, what happened to the vast lands given to support it? By tracking land deeds across Chola edicts, 17th-Century Nayak and Maratha silver plates, and Dutch East India Company treaties, Mr. Menon mapped out a fascinating linguistic and political transformation.

While 'Anaimangalam' and 'Anaimangalam Brahmadeyam' are mentioned in both the Larger and Smaller Leiden copper plates, the name 'Anaimangalam' disappears from documents written after the Smaller Leiden plates. Conversely, the name 'Sangamangalam' appears in these later post-Leiden records. Based on this, K.A. Menon suggests that after Anaimangalam village was gifted to the Buddhist Vihara and its monastic community (Sangha), its name likely morphed into 'Sangamangalam'.

Mr. Menon's research notes that when Buddhism ultimately faded from the region, subsequent rulers repurposed the properties. The same villages were donated to the Portuguese, with the same kind of rights and conditions as in the time of the Cholas.

Railway Board likely to give approval for CMRL takeover of MRTS in four to six weeks

Sources said a joint proposal was sent to the board recently and no further delay is expected; the MoU between Southern Railway and State government will be signed after the approval is granted

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

The Railway Board is expected to approve the Chennai Metro Rail Limited's (CMRL) takeover of the MRTS network in about 4-6 weeks.

The project, which has been on the cards for several years, got a boost in July last year when the Railway Board gave the nod for the transfer and merger of MRTS with CMRL.

Sources said a joint proposal in this regard was sent to the board recently and the approval is likely to come by the end of July. "We don't foresee any delay after this," a source said.

If this comes through, the signing of the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Southern Railway and the State government will follow, which will pave the way for the actual takeover and the gradual change of infrastructure and systems in the months to follow.

Mega project: The State government is mulling various options to seek funding before the MoU is signed, as the estimated cost of the project currently stands at nearly ₹4,500 crore. M. SRINATH

In April this year, Southern Railway had forwarded the draft MoU to the Railway Board. But subsequently, a joint proposal of the MoU with the concurrence of the State government was asked and that too was sent to the board recently.

Since the estimated cost of the project currently stands at nearly ₹4,500 crore, the State government is mulling various options to seek funding before the MoU is signed.

Six-month delay

Though the deadline was December last year, the signing of this agreement has faced delays as Tamil Nadu government had to wait for the consent from Railways regarding the document.

Commuters who frequently travel in the MRTS system have been anticipating the takeover process for years.

T. Sadagopan, a commuter and an activist said, " A commuter who takes the train every day yearns for the time when the maintenance and services will get better in MRTS system. We hope there is policy continuity and the State government secures the final approval soon."

Some fuel outlets cap diesel at 195 litres per customer after order from Centre

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Petroleum retailers have been facing a difficult task over the past two days, declining fuel even to their regular bulk customers.

Some fuel outlets have imposed a cap of 195 litres of diesel for vehicles whose owners are not regular customers.

"These are not companies or factories, but educational institutions, apartment complexes, and hospitals that depend on us. They come once or twice a month with large barrels. They do not have underground tanks or Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organization (PESO) licenses. In this weather, with frequent power cuts, diesel is essential," said a dealer near Chennai.

"Even earlier, there was a cap of 200 litres per customer, but that was only an oral instruction. This time, the Central government's order came in writing and the oil marketing companies (OMCs) have issued stern warnings. Why should I invite punishment unnecessarily? I would rather not fill tanks of heavy vehicles," said another dealer.

Apart from diesel for generators, the fuel is also used by buses and lorries with large tank capacities.

"Customers are now forced to fill half their tanks at one outlet and scout around for the rest. I am afraid to fill these vehicles even using two bills, as the government and OMCs are currently focused on preventing the diversion of fuel. We are advising our regular customers either to make frequent trips to the outlet or visit nearby outlets," he added.

"Like other outlets, I have imposed a cap on petrol as well. It is 50 litres for cars," said a dealer.

GCC officials to inspect functioning of streetlights

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation officials will conduct a field inspection on June 15 to verify the functioning of all streetlights across the city.

According to a press release, the inspection will be carried out ward-wise in all 15 zones by GCC officials on Monday evening. Residents can report non-functioning lights to the Corporation's helpline, 1913, the release said.

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Timings
CHENNAI

MONDAY, JUN. 15			
RISE	05:43	SET	18:36
RISE	05:34	SET	19:05
TUESDAY, JUN. 16			
RISE	05:44	SET	18:36
RISE	06:42	SET	20:09
WEDNESDAY, JUN. 17			
RISE	05:44	SET	18:37
RISE	07:50	SET	21:07

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	37	26
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	38	28

Chennai Airport Today
39°C The weather will be hot and uneasy. The night will be very uneasy. A spell of light rain and thundershowers may occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
40°C The morning will be comfortable. The day will be hot and uneasy. The night also will be uneasy. There are chances of light rain and thundershowers.

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Auroville Foundation at Auroville (AVF), Tamil Nadu, an autonomous body under the Government of India. AVF invites applications from eligible Indian Nationals for engagement to the Accountant positions purely on contractual basis.

Detailed advertisement indicating qualifications for the post, application format, etc. have been uploaded on the website of the Auroville Foundation at www.aurovillefoundation.org.in. Interested candidates may send their application to email id: contract_avf@auroville.org.in on or before 23-06-2026. The candidates are requested to bring original testimonials, self-attested copy of testimonials and copy of application submitted, on the date of walk-in-interview.

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Procedure for appointment

- Appointment will be made from a panel of names recommended by a committee constituted under the provisions of Act of the University.
- The advertisement is available on the websites ***https://dohe-education.gov.in*** and ***https://www.manuu.edu.in***
- Candidates are required to **"APPLY ONLINE ONLY"** on the Ministry of Education SAMARTH portal as per the link given below:

https://vcrec.samarth.ac.in/index.php/

- The above link will be active from **15.06.2026**, 10:00 Hours to **14.07.2026**, 17:00 Hours.

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7.00 PM: Vid. K. Bharat Sundar – Vocal, Vid. Sayee Rakshith – Violin, Vid. Sumesh Narayanan - Mridangam
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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, SUNDARARAJAN, S/o Madurakavi, residing at No.33, Siruvani Nadhi Street, MG Nagar, Madurai- 625020, do hereby declare that I have changed the Name of my Son from "Sujan Sriram to Sujan Sriram Sundararajan", vide affidavit dated 12/06/2026

I, BALAMURALIKRISHNA Nagarajan & Sharmila Thoota Chengalvarayan, citizen of India, currently residing at [6005 state bridge road #1025 Duluth, Georgia –30097], parent of minor [Kevin Balamuralikrishna], born on [22/07/2017], do hereby change the name of my child to [Kevin Bala] for all future purposes, as per the final name change decree index/case number [26CV004744] granted by the [Superior Court of Fulton County, Georgia] on [Date Decree Signed 20/05/2026].

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, OSWIN D, Pallikaranai, Chennai 600100, declare my wife's name was incorrectly printed as Vinitha Joshy Oswin in my daughter's ICSE Class 10 records under UID 8908326 and Index 1266232/006 whereas her true legal name is Vinitha Joshy P as per affidavit dated 12.06.2026 affirmed before the Taluk Executive Magistrate, Thiruvattar, Kanyakumari District.

I, OSWIN D, Pallikaranai, Chennai 600100, declare my daughter's name was incorrectly printed as Karen Oswin in her ICSE Class 10 records under UID 8908326 and Index 1266232/006 whereas her true legal name is Karen O as per affidavit dated 12.06.2026 affirmed before the Taluk Executive Magistrate, Thiruvattar, Kanyakumari District.

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INBRIEF

Govt. is lacking coordination in managing Nipah: Pinarayi

Alleging a lack of coordination in the Kerala government's handling of the situation after a Nipah virus infection was reported in Kozhikode, Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan has said that the government should take immediate steps to prevent the spread of the virus and to ensure necessary treatment to the patient. "...The Health Minister is attempting to wash his hands of all the responsibilities by blaming the officials," Mr. Vijayan alleged.

Mild tremors felt in Bhadradri Kothagudem of Telangana

Mild tremors lasting for a few seconds were felt in some parts of Bhadradri Kothagudem district in Telangana in the early hours of Sunday. According to sources, residents in some parts of Kothagudem and Palvancha experienced light tremors. An earthquake of 3.8-magnitude on the Richter scale of 10 km depth was recorded at 2.26 a.m. on Sunday, officials said, quoting data from the National Centre for Seismology.

UDF endorses demand for bifurcation of Malappuram

The long-standing demand to bifurcate Kerala's Malappuram district gained fresh momentum on Sunday after the ruling United Democratic Front (UDF) endorsed it. A district-level UDF meeting discussed the matter and decided to seek the appointment of a special officer to examine its feasibility. UDF district chairman K.P. Abdul Majeed said bifurcation had become a necessity, citing "inequitable distribution of government resources" across the district.

Activists seek accountability from Centre at CJP protests

Protests were held in Hyderabad and Bengaluru as part of a nationwide campaign pressing for Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation; in Bengaluru, Sonam Wangchuk says country has 'trust deficit'

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD/BENGALURU

Founder of CJP Abhijeet Dipke, actor Prakash Raj, and environmentalist Sonam Wangchuk during a protest at Bengaluru's Freedom Park on Sunday; (right) CJP activists stage a protest at Dharna Chowk near Indira Park in Hyderabad on Sunday. ANI & G. RAMAKRISHNA

The Cockroach Janta Party on Sunday held protests in Hyderabad and Bengaluru as part of a nationwide campaign seeking the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over exam irregularities. The protests were held at Dharna Chowk in Hyderabad and Freedom Park in Bengaluru, with climate activist Sonam Wangchuk joining protesters in both places.

Dharna Chowk witnessed an unusual blend of satire and dissent, apart from "Cockroach is the New Tiger" posters and chants demanding accountability. The protest also gradually evolved into a wider conversation on educational inequality, democratic freedom and political accountability, with speakers repeatedly questioning the state of India's education system and the responsibility of those in power.

People started arriving from around 9 a.m., carrying placards demanding Mr. Pradhan's resignation. Posters reading 'Dharmendra Pradhan Resign' competed for attention while volunteers and supporters slowly filled the tent erected at the venue.

As the morning progressed, the crowd continued to swell. By noon, the tent had reached capacity, forcing many participants to stand outside. Several banners reflected Hyderabad's distinctive Dakhni flavour.

The loudest cheers of the day erupted shortly after 11 a.m. when Mr. Wangchuk arrived. Mr. Wangchuk congratulated Hyderabad's youth and described the city as one of the most peaceful and energetic places he had visited during his travels with the CJP. Mr. Wangchuk said education and environmental protection should remain the twin pillars of India's aspirations to become a developed nation. The four-hour-long protest concluded around 2 p.m.

Bengaluru protest

In Bengaluru, amid tight security and heavy rain, students, unions and supporters who called themselves "cockroaches" gathered in large numbers as the CJP held its first protest in the city. While many said they were there to demand the Union Education Minister's resignation, others said they saw the CJP as a movement reflecting public anger against the government's agenda, be it politics over religion, corruption or a lack of accountability on multiple issues.

The protest saw massive participation despite the steady rain. Among those who joined the protest were actor Prakash Raj, actor Kiran Srinivas, and filmmakers Senani Hegde and Krupakar B.S.

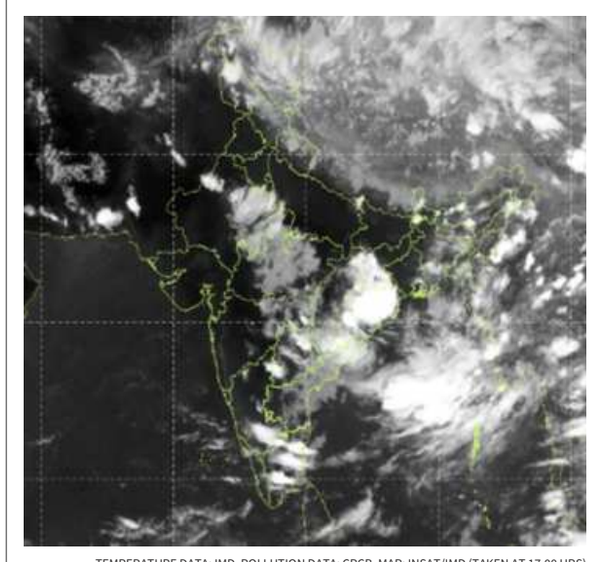
Claiming that the country was facing not just a fiscal deficit but also a trust deficit, Mr. Wangchuk called on the government to be accountable and to ensure a free press. "Otherwise, please declare that India is no longer a democracy. It has become a totalitarian country," he said.

Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the CJP, said there were lakhs of students who could have become doctors in the future and gone on to save lives, but ended up losing their own. "I don't think there can be anything more shameful than this for the country. We are a better nation than that," he said.

CJP members said they would continue protesting until the Minister resigned. "It started with a single tweet by Mr. Dipke, which led to this movement. We are challenging everyone, including the Supreme Court and the Chief Justice of India, who called us cockroaches," CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy rainfall very likely in Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, West Bengal and Sikkim. Thunderstorm accompanied with lightning very likely in Andhra Pradesh, South Karnataka and Telangana.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	—	32	23	Kurnool	—	36	27
Ahmedabad	51%	42	28	Lucknow	—	39	28
Aizawl	63%	27	20	Madurai	51%	37	26
Bengaluru	55%	28	20	Mangaluru	68%	28	16
Bhopal	51%	35	25	Mumbai	—	36	29
Bhubaneswar	51%	39	26	Mysuru	55%	30	21
Chandigarh	—	37	25	New Delhi	—	37	27
Chennai	67%	36	28	Patna	—	38	29
Coimbatore	60%	32	23	Port Blair	—	—	—
Dehradun	51%	34	22	Prayagraj	—	40	29
Gangtok	79%	23	16	Puducherry	51%	38	27
Goa	71%	34	28	Pune	—	37	25
Guwahati	49%	33	25	Raipur	—	39	28
Hubballi	51%	31	22	Ranchi	—	34	25
Hyderabad	—	38	26	Shillong	74%	23	18
Imphal	55%	29	22	Shimla	—	27	16
Jaipur	—	40	27	Srinagar	51%	26	12
Kochi	66%	30	26	Thiruvananthapuram	68%	32	23
Kohima	83%	24	19	Tiruchirappalli	51%	38	27
Kolkata	—	37	27	Vijayawada	—	38	28
Kozhikode	70%	32	25	Visakhapatnam	54%	34	28

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO_2	NO_2	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE
Ahmedabad	122	20	35	79	87	
Bengaluru	.11	.29	41	—	92	
Chennai	5	.14	54	40	52	
Delhi	.24	.74	.—	171	287	
Hyderabad	.12	.14	30	49	76	
Kolkata	.14	.24	11	79	97	
Lucknow	.29	.12	24	54	86	
Mumbai	.29	6	12	68	79	
Pune	—.	.35	78	57	75	
Visakhapatnam	.18	.48	10	58	121	

Yesterday

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Panipat, Haryana, recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 258 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Ambernath, Maharashtra recorded a healthy AQI score of 14.

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO_2: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO_2: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

3 children and man drown as boat capsizes in Krishna river in A.P.

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

People gather to witness rescue operations after a boat capsized in Palnadu district of A.P. on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Four persons, three of them children, drowned in the Krishna river when the boat in which they were travelling capsized near Konuru village in Palnadu district of Andhra Pradesh on Sunday. Six passengers were rescued.

The deceased were identified as Battula Karthik, 12, Konatha Chaitanya, 26, Gandham Saini, 10, and Gandham Sandhya, 8.

The deceased were from the Marrichettupalem and Chilakaluripet areas.

They had come to Konuru to attend a function at the house of K. Gangaiah. They went on a boat ride after the function. "Local people jumped into the water, rescued six persons, and brought them to the bund," said Ramana, a resident.

No safety material

There were no life jackets or other safety material in the boat, the villagers alleged.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, who was away in Singapore, expressed grief over the loss of lives in the boat tragedy.

Mr. Naidu announced an *ex gratia* of ₹5 lakh each to the next of kin of the dead.

CM orders probe

The Chief Minister also directed the District Collector to disburse the amount immediately, and ordered a full-fledged investigation by a team of Revenue, Police, and Water Resources departments.

The officials informed the Chief Minister that the boat capsized around 2 p.m. after hitting a sandbar in the Krishna river.

YSRCP president Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy expressed shock over the accident and conveyed his condolences to the bereaved families.

Mr. Reddy appealed to the government to extend all help to the victims' families.

Sitharaman reviews progress of work on Bengaluru-Chennai Expressway

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Sunday inspected the ongoing construction of the Bengaluru-Chennai Expressway at Devanahalli in Karnataka as part of the 'Pragati Path Yatre Darshan' programme.

Ms. Sitharaman reviewed the progress of road construction, traffic management measures, and infrastructure development associated with the Greenfield expressway project, which is being developed under the Bharatmala Pariyojana Phase-I scheme to provide high-speed connectivity between Bengaluru and Chennai. She noted that the expressway would strengthen connectivity to major industrial and logistics hubs.

Odisha State Medical Corporation Limited (OSMC)
In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-III, Bhubaneswar-751001
Tel.:(0674) 2380608; Website: https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in ; Email: proc.osmcl.od@nic.in
Assuring Quality, Saving Lives

Notification No. 5484/OSMCL/2026 Date: 11.06.2026

NOTICE INVITING Re-Tender for Selection of Service Provider for Biomedical Equipment Maintenance Service in the State of Odisha

Online Bids through e-Tender portal **(https://tendersodisha.gov.in)** are invited from eligible Service Providers for Biomedical Equipment' Maintenance Service in the State of Odisha as per the particulars mentioned below :

Sl.	Bid Reference No.	Item Name	Bid Document Cost inclusive of GST (Rs.)
1.	OSMCL/2026-27/Re-tender_BEMP/01	Re-tender for Selection of Service Provider for Biomedical Equipment Maintenance Service in the State of Odisha	Rs.5,900/-

Sl. No.	Particulars	Date and time	
1.	Date & time of release of bid	11/06/2026, 10.30 AM	
2.	Date & time of Pre-bid Meeting	18/06/2026, 11.30 AM **Venue** : Conference Hall, Odisha State Medical Corporation Ltd., In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-III, Bhubaneswar	
3.	Date & time of Online bid submission	Start Date & Time	End Date & Time
		25/06/2026, 3.00 PM	15/07/2026, 5.00 PM
4.	Date & time of online Technical Bid Opening	20/07/2026, 3.00 PM	
5.	Date of opening of Price Bid	To be informed to the qualified bidders	

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites : **https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in** and **https://tendersodisha.gov.in** . The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason thereof.

Managing Director, OSMCL

10001/275/2627 OIPR-10001/10112/1/26-27/0003

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

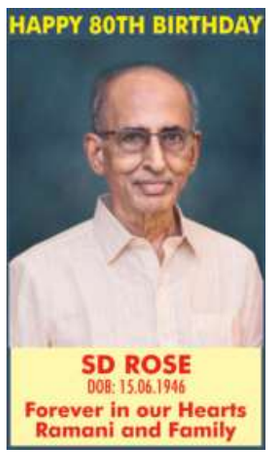
DEATH

S ANANTHA NARAYANAN
Retd. AGM SBI
left for his heavenly abode on 12.06.26
Deeply mourned by
Family & Friends
Dasasthu on 21.06.26 at Janardhanam Gyanawapi, Chennai-126.
Contact Giridhar 9176888853

DEATH

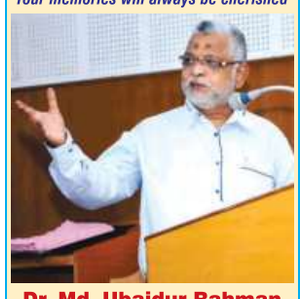
With profound grief, we inform our beloved mother,
Mrs.Mythili Srinivasan
(Aged 86), attained Acharyan Thiruvadi on 14th June 2026.
Final rites & Obsequies will be performed on 16th June 2026.
In Deep Mourning:
Ramesh & Savita
Rajagopalan & Sridevi
Krishnan & Deepta
Lakshmi Narasimhan & Indira
Grand children
Great Grandchildren
Near relatives and friends
Cell : 9841281797, 9840904797

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE



DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

SIXTH ANNIVERSARY
Your memories will always be cherished



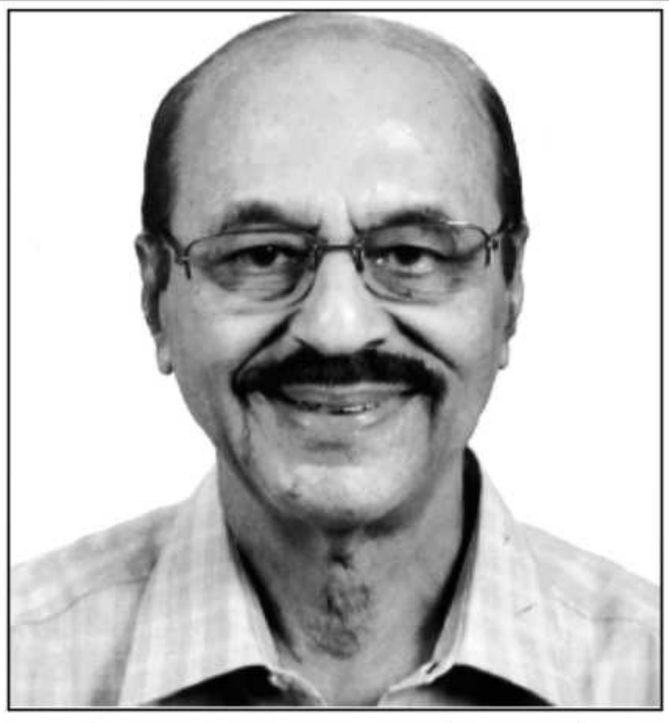
Dr. Md. Ubaidur Rahman
Former Head of Urdu Dept,
The New College, Chennai &
Chief Marketing Officer, COSCO (India) Ltd.
Fondly remembered by family members

FIFTH ANNIVERSARY
Forever in our hearts

Prof. Dr.R.DAKSHINAMURTHY
Retd. Prof. of Tamil (H.O.D.)
Pachaiyappa's College, Chennai
Fondly Remembered by
Wife, Sons, Daughters-in-law & Granddaughters.
Anna Nagar (W), Chennai - 101
94440 50709

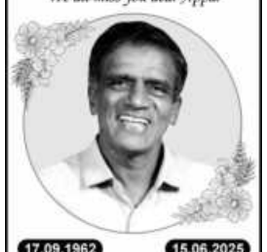
DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

11th ANNIVERSARY



Mr. C.N.RAMDAS IAS (R)
(03.10.1937 to 15.06.2015)
Your life is an inspiration to us & we will always cherish your loving memories. We still feel your presence around, that gives us strength to go on
Family & Friends
"GNG House" K-48 Anna Nagar East, Chennai – 102.

First Year Anniversary
To a Sincere Son, Loving Husband, Caring Father, Doting Grandfather, Good Friend, Healing Doctor...
We all miss you dear Appa.



17.09.1962 15.06.2025
Dr. KUMARAN APPUCHAMI
MBBS., DLO.,
A year has passed without your physical presence. You live in our hearts as Love, guidance and memories..
Family
Dr. K. Vijayalakshmi
Er. Rajkumar Appuchami, Er. Ashwini
Dr. Sampathkumar Appuchami, Dr. Nandhini
Grandchildren Yavan and Radhya Kumaran
APPUSAMI HOSPITAL, SALEM
MY CHEDI NURSERY, SALEM

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Keep it real

Why we need digital identity checks in academic life

GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Biju Dharmapalan

In an age where a researcher's reputation is often built – and judged – online before a single conversation takes place, the integrity of one's digital academic identity has become as critical as the research itself. Before a paper is read or a conversation begins, a quick online search often defines first impressions. Yet, the systems designed to track scholarly output are increasingly failing to present a coherent and accurate picture of researchers. This raises an urgent question: Do we need systematic digital identity checks to prevent private digital mismatching of academic profiles? The answer is an unequivocal yes.

Academic databases and professional platforms like ORCID (Open Researcher and Contributor ID), Scopus, LinkedIn, and others were designed to clarify scholarly contributions. Instead, they frequently generate a labyrinth of redundant profiles, misattributed publications, and incongruous affiliations. What was intended to improve visibility is, paradoxically, compromising accuracy.

Digital mismatch

Digital identity ambiguity often begins innocuously. While platforms such as ORCID, LinkedIn, and indexing databases and preprint servers all go to some lengths to distinguish between researchers who share the same name, they update according to their own schedules and have a variety of rules for their users. Even on a single platform, some details are captured more reliably than others. Scopus, for instance, receives information from the journals that it indexes but the author profiles it produces do not always reflect a complete affiliation history.

Occasionally, when a researcher changes their institution or affiliation, they neglect to update their profile. Over time, these distortions emerge as major issues in the profiling of researchers. In today's academic environment, driven by metrics, discrepancies are not merely technical errors; they shape how researchers are perceived.

There is a common perception that digital technologies facilitate easy verification. But a simple name search can yield numerous profiles and, in the absence of a standardised identity or coherent metadata, differentiating one individual from another is a challenge. Even seasoned evaluators may find it difficult to ascertain which profile accurately reflects the "authentic" researcher. Thus, an increase in data does not inherently lead to enhanced comprehension.

Identity checks

Digital identity verification guarantees that the online version of a researcher's academic trajectory is accurately represented. Moreover, it reinstates the individual's autonomy within a system that frequently operates outside their immediate supervision. Three pragmatic measures can markedly enhance digital coherence:

An updated ORCID profile: Most researchers have a unique ORCID throughout their lifetime. Even when a researcher changes affiliation, this remains the same. The profile should be linked to PURE and Scopus. Keeping affiliations and research output up to date makes one's ORCID page a stable reference point. Moreover, including the ORCID identifier when submitting papers allows publishers to add work to your record once it is published.

Institutional profile: Linking ORCID with institutional systems like PURE or the Indian Research Information Network System (IRINS) allows verified data such as publications and affiliations to be synchronised automatically.

Audit external platforms: Regularly checking profiles in databases such as Scopus, Web of Science, and Google Scholar helps identify duplicates, correct misattributions, and merge fragmented records.

Although personal attention is crucial, academic institutions, publishers, and database providers must collaborate to develop interoperable systems that mitigate fragmentation. Standardised IDs, enhanced integration across platforms, and proactive error-detection methods ought to be standard practice rather than anomalies.

A researcher's digital identity influences visibility, credibility, and opportunity. In contrast to a conventional CV, which is meticulously crafted and fixed, a digital profile is fluid, broadly available, and frequently outside direct oversight. This also serves as a lasting documentation of a career, referenced by future partners, institutions, and historians of science. Ensuring its truth transcends personal advantage; it pertains to academic honesty. As the quantity of academic data proliferates, the likelihood of misrepresentation concurrently increases. The resolution resides in awareness, regular maintenance, and structural reform, as your profile speaks for you, not just your study.

The writer is the Dean - Academic Affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru, and an adjunct faculty at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. E-mail: bijudharmapalan@gmail.com

SCHOLARSHIPS

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An initiative of Valvoline Cummins Private Ltd.
Eligibility: Students in Classes 9 to 12 from all southern and northeastern states and Bihar, Chhattisgarh; Jharkhand, Odisha, and Sikkim who are children of commercial drivers and mechanics, and belong to the economically weaker sections and have secured 60% and above in their previous class. Annual family income must not exceed ₹800,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹12,000 (based on actual expenses) and mentorship
Application: Online
Deadline: August 20
www.b4s.in/edge/MKSP3

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

SAVE THE DATE

InnoVent-27
Tata Technologies, in collaboration with Emerson's Test and Measurement Business and Amazon Web Services, has launched the fourth edition of InnoVent-27, its engineering innovation hackathon.
Theme: AI at the Edge: AI solutions for Automotive, Aerospace, and Industrial Heavy Machinery Industries
Eligibility: Engineering students in the third and fourth year of B.E. or B.Tech programmes
Deadline: July 5
For more details, visit https://shorturl.at/C5FGu

Space for Good India Challenge
Viasat Inc has launched the 2026 Viasat: Space for Good India Challenge, which aims to inspire university students to think about how space technology can improve life on Earth, explore solutions across areas such as equitable and sustainable access to space, direct-to-device (D2D), Internet of Things (IoT), multi-orbit constellations, and disaster and humanitarian response.
Eligibility: Those who are 18 years at the time of entry and are UG, PG, and doctoral students in any year and area of study
Deadline: July 19
For more details, visit https://shorturl.at/L2DbO

Admissions
IIT-Jammu has introduced the B.Tech Unified Engineering programme, which offers an interdisciplinary approach to students who aspire to explore beyond conventional engineering disciplines. It combines experiential learning with industry immersion. Visit https://iitjammu.ac.in/ue/faq.html for details.

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• B.Sc. Computer Science with Cognitive Systems Collaboration with HCL Guvi
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THE WEEK HANSA RESEARCH SURVEY INDIA'S BEST COLLEGES 2025
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"SCAN TO APPLY"

Fuller expression

A rapid decline in inflation appears unlikely even if the war ends

India's May retail inflation at 3.93%, the highest in the current CPI series and roughly a 15-month high if compared with the previous series, has begun to reflect the pass-through effects of surging food and fuel costs more clearly than in previous months. However, last month's wholesale inflation numbers, the first under the new WPI series and due later this month alongside India's first Producer Price Index (PPI), should reveal how much of the price shock producers and wholesalers continue to absorb. May's food inflation rose at a faster clip to 4.78% from 4.20% in April. While transport inflation rose by 1.75% after a marginal contraction in April, a subdivision within the sector – transport services for goods – surged by 7.63%, signalling growing price pass-through. This was largely driven by the four tranches of petrol and diesel price increases beginning in mid-May. Significantly, the sharp rise in commercial LPG prices – by about ₹1,300 per 19-kg cylinder, representing an increase of over 75% since February – appears to be reflected in inflation in the restaurants and accommodation services category, which stood at 5.75%, the second-highest division after personal care and miscellaneous goods and services. Inflation in the latter category reached 18.46%, reflecting soaring precious metals prices. Domestic LPG's second price revision by ₹29 earlier this month will likely find a fuller expression in June's consumer food price inflation.

Although May's inflation remains below the RBI's 4% target and within its 2%-6% tolerance band, the RBI retained its neutral stance at its latest monetary policy review, signalling concern over the possibility of further price pressures. Its intervention in the foreign exchange market through dollar sales has meanwhile helped shore up the rupee, Asia's worst-performing currency since the U.S.-Israeli conflict with Iran escalated. The currency, which briefly approached ₹97 to the dollar in May, is now trading closer to ₹95-₹96. The Centre may nevertheless draw some comfort from the fact that core inflation, which excludes food and fuel, remained relatively contained at around 3.8%-3.9% in May, largely unchanged from recent months. This coincides with signs of a U.S.-Iran rapprochement and uninterrupted shipping through the Hormuz. Yet, uncertainty persists over whether Iran may impose fees or restrictions on transit through the waterway, which could keep fuel prices elevated for energy-importing nations such as India. Even if crude prices soften, oil marketing companies are unlikely to immediately reverse retail price increases as they seek to recover losses. LPG prices, too, may remain sticky. Thus, while the prospects for a durable peace may have improved, a rapid decline in inflation appears unlikely.

Series of gaps

Distrust of police has led to underreporting of child sexual abuse

Child sexual abuse in India remains persistently under-reported and the state response to it has shown up trenchant systemic inefficiencies. In over 90% of cases, including the recent Sulur case in Coimbatore in which a charge sheet was filed last week, the threat to a child is from within the family's trusted circles. Public imagination often fixates on predatory strangers, which is not conducive to helping families and communities identify a risk in time. Migrant and working-class communities are especially at risk as they are less integrated in local protective social networks. Second, abandoned industrial sites and poorly maintained common land tend to become crime scenes. But despite the 'Safe City' project and the recognition of child-friendly urban development paradigms, urban redesign still focuses on core areas of major metros. The social safety dimensions of urban wetland restoration, like that of the Noyyal river, are often overlooked as well. Next, while POCSO trials are required to conclude within a year of the special court taking cognisance, POCSO courts face an 89% pendency rate and conviction rates have historically ranged between 3% and 30%, undermining confidence in the police and judiciary. The Sulur case prompted promises of swift action, but this is only one case; systemic reforms to protect vulnerable children remain elusive. In 2024, the NCRB recorded 69,191 POCSO cases involving more than 70,000 child victims.

Public distrust discourages residents from reporting suspicions and encourages families fearing police apathy to search for missing children themselves, potentially allowing the perpetrators to hide evidence or flee. Ultimately, when the state fails to deliver due punishment, the people perceive the police to be a bureaucratic hurdle, leaving children more vulnerable. Repeatedly strengthening penalties merely suppresses reporting in most cases where the offender is familiar. Even the 2018 and 2019 amendments to the POCSO Act reacted to public outrage rather than considered evidence and focused on harsher punishments. Both comprehensive longitudinal data on recidivism and analyses of whether harsher legal penalties are effective deterrents remain scarce. While data collection has improved, the Ministry of Women and Child Development has noted that qualitative analyses of acquittals rarely inform policy changes. Finally, survivors and families face secondary victimisation from insensitive administrative responses and media reports. Together with the lack of policing informed by trauma response and stigma, true safety continues to evade thousands of children leaving them vulnerable to a cycle of unreported and unpunished violence.

The hidden history of the Thai-Bharat connection

Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament, Congress party (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram, the Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs and the Sahitya Akademi Award-winning author of 29 books, including, most recently, 'The Sage Who Reimagined Hinduism: The Life, Lessons and Legacy of Sree Narayana Guru'

Today, June 15, marks the 84th anniversary of a historic meeting we have allowed ourselves to forget, which led to the birth of the Indian National Army (INA). I learned about it on a visit to the Thai-Bharat Cultural Lodge (TBCL) in Bangkok, discovering a remarkable, overlooked chapter of history that reveals Thailand's vital role as a neutral, strategic beacon for Indian revolutionaries seeking refuge from British colonial rule. From its humble beginnings as a hub for cultural and intellectual exchange, the organisation evolved into a cornerstone of the Indian independence movement, providing the essential infrastructure for the formation of the INA.

From culture to cause

The roots of this alliance were sown in 1927 during a historic visit to Siam, now Thailand, by Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore, who met with King Prajadhipok (Rama VII). Their dialogue centred on the deep, enduring connections between India and Thailand – ancient ties rooted in religion, philosophy, and shared cultural narratives such as the Ramayana and the Thai Ramakien. Inspired by his vision, Prafulla Kumar Sen, a Bengali scholar who became known as Swami Satyananda Puri, arrived in Bangkok in 1932.

A brilliant intellectual who had taught at the University of Calcutta and Visva-Bharati University, the Swami immersed himself in the Thai language and culture, mastering it in six months and becoming an esteemed professor at Chulalongkorn University. In 1939, he established the Dharam Ashram, a sanctuary for spiritual and cultural exchange, which served as a focal point for the growing Indian diaspora in Bangkok.

In December 1940, this ashram was transformed into the TBCL. A defining moment in the organisation's history occurred shortly after, when the Indian Tricolour was hoisted at the Lodge – a bold, defiant gesture that signalled the arrival of the Indian independence movement in Thailand and drew strong protests from the British Ambassador. As the Second World War descended upon Southeast Asia, the TBCL shifted from a cultural institution to an active political base. By late 1941, as Japanese forces advanced, the Lodge became a nexus for Indian nationalists and independence activists.

One of the most instrumental figures in this era was Sardar Giani Pritam Singh, a Sikh missionary and Ghadar Party veteran who had been preaching revolutionary ideals among the Indian diaspora in Bangkok. Operating from gurdwaras and working closely with the TBCL, Pritam Singh established vital covert links with Major Iwaichi Fujiwara, the chief of the Japanese intelligence unit, F-Kikan. In December 1941, the Indian National Council (INC) was founded at the Silpakorn Theatre in Bangkok by a group of nationalists associated with the TBCL, with Swami Satyananda Puri as its president and Debnath Das as its secretary. This organisation played a crucial role in coordinating the efforts of the Indian independence movement, bridging the gap between civilian aspirations and the military mobilisation led by the Indian Independence League (IIL).

> An enduring Thailand-India bond that played a pivotal role in India's independence movement

Toward organised resistance

The cooperation between these groups culminated in the historic Bangkok Conference, which took place between June 15 and June 23, 1942, at the Silpakorn Theatre. This gathering represented a turning point in the struggle, bringing together more than a hundred representatives of Indian communities and freedom fighters from across Southeast Asia, including Burma, Malaya, and Singapore.

The conference served three primary functions. It brought together diverse nationalist factions under a coherent political and military framework, effectively establishing the IIL as the central body for Indians residing outside of India. It adopted a comprehensive 34-point resolution, which provided the official blueprint for the INA, stipulating that it would be composed of volunteers and former prisoners of war and supervised by the IIL rather than the Japanese military. The delegates urged Japan to formally recognise India as an independent nation and acknowledge the IIL as its sole legitimate representative, reflecting a strategic effort to ensure that the independence movement maintained its own agency despite its reliance on Japanese support.

The struggle began with a tragedy that shook the movement to its core. In March 1942, a plane carrying the Swami and the Sardar, who were en route to a high-level meeting in Tokyo to secure further commitments for the movement, crashed, resulting in their deaths. Their loss was a devastating blow, yet their sacrifice served to deepen the resolve of those who remained and who conferred in June with the Japanese to set up the INA. Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's arrival in 1943 provided the centralised, charismatic, and revolutionary military leadership needed. He took command of the IIL and the INA, shifting the focus from decentralised regional council discussions toward a unified, disciplined military and political front designed to launch an armed struggle for Indian independence.

While the TBCL's roots were in intellectual and cultural exchange, Netaji's arrival accelerated the transition to a mass-mobilisation effort, drawing in thousands of civilian volunteers and former prisoners of war who were inspired by his call for "Total Mobilization". Under Bose, the collaboration with the Japanese military was elevated to a high-stakes diplomatic partnership aimed at securing full recognition for the Provisional Government of Free India.

Despite the shift toward a more militarised and centralised command under Netaji, the TBCL continued to serve as a vital institutional bridge. It provided the necessary civilian and cultural cover for many activities that supported the broader independence movement. As the war progressed, the TBCL remained a steadfast centre for the Indian diaspora, even as the focus of the struggle moved to the front lines of the INA's march toward the Indian border. The Lodge maintained its role as a sanctuary for those committed to the ideals of independence, preserving the vision that had been articulated during the early days of Swami Satyananda Puri's tenure – that India's freedom was inextricably linked to the broader cause of Asian liberation from colonial rule.

Keeping history alive

Following the conclusion of the war in 1945, the TBCL was banned by Allied forces and its leaders imprisoned. Even after the conclusion of the war and the dissolution of the INA, the legacy of this era persisted. Thanks to the tireless efforts of figures such as Pandit Raghunath Sharma, the Lodge was successfully re-established in 1946. The Lodge's survival serves as a testament to the fact that the political and military efforts of the Bose era were supported by the deep-rooted cultural and social networks fostered in the years prior. These networks allowed the movement to survive the vacuum of leadership following the war and continue to inform the historic relationship between India and Thailand.

Today, the TBCL remains the only surviving institution from this era, functioning as a living archive, housing a precious collection of rare texts, historical photographs, and documents that provide an intimate window into the lives of the Indian families who contributed to the fight for freedom.

During my visit I was treated to a passionate tour of the premises by Pandeyji, a descendant of Indian rajpurohits who had migrated to Thailand three centuries ago. As he evoked the stories behind each grainy photograph and historic document, it became clear that the TBCL stands not just as a library or a museum, but as a monument to the enduring friendship between the people of Thailand and the Indian diaspora – a symbol of the shared courage and determination that defined one of the most critical, yet often forgotten, chapters of the global anti-colonial movement.

The 'seven-point IQ opportunity' for Indian children

Beena Koshy

Senior Professor, Developmental Paediatrics, Christian Medical College (CMC), Vellore, Tamil Nadu

Riday Chokshi

Senior Associate – National Initiatives and Policy, Rocket Learning

What if we could increase the IQ of India's future generations by seven points with a pivot in the understanding of early childhood development under the Anganwadi system?

For decades, India's early childhood agenda has focused on ensuring that children survive early childhood, reducing under-five mortality from 43 in 2012 to 32 in 2020 (UNICEF and World Bank data) with sufficient inputs invested toward their health, nutrition, immunisation and sanitation conditions. The Anganwadi system reflects these priorities at scale: approximately eight crore children (ages 0-6 years) receive supplementary nutrition, growth monitoring and health services, alongside counselling and home visits for their parents. However, body and brain development in the early years do not proceed on separate tracks.

Early childhood development is an ecological process in which nutrition, health, and early learning interact dynamically with each other through the body, brain, and environment. The developing brain is highly energy-intensive, consuming nearly one-fifth of the body's energy at rest. In the first year alone, grey matter volume increases by 149% and the cerebellum by 240% as millions of synapses form in regions associated with movement, language, and planning.

Middle-income evidence is clear

Paediatric research in Jamaica in the 1980s provided hard academic evidence to an idea that many cultures already understood. Researchers working with stunted children found that nutritional supplementation improved physical health alone, but adding regular psychosocial stimulation (love-talk-play and responsive interaction) resulted in stronger cognitive gains.

Similar findings emerged in India from a birth cohort study in Vellore (250 children followed from birth to age 9) where children stunted early in life performed worst on later cognitive assessments, but those who recovered physically also showed better cognitive outcomes.

> Anganwadis can help boost cognitive development through holistic early intervention

International research on enteric dysfunction and poor sanitation has shown that nutritional inputs are mediated by the child's environment. A child's body may receive food, but infection, inflammation, toxic exposure and deprivation of stimulation can adversely influence this very nutrition. In studies in Vellore, children with iron deficiency or high lead exposure in early life, score lower on developmental and cognitive assessments, even when their height and weight appear normal. It is not simply what children eat that matters, but whether their bodies can absorb and use it. Yet, numbers on a growth chart never tell the full story. The quality of the home environment – how much they are talked to, read to, played with and emotionally supported, keeps emerging as a stronger predictor of cognitive outcomes than diet alone.

Most encouragingly, exposure to structured preschool and early stimulation has the potential to transform a generation. Children in the Vellore cohort who attend preschool regularly for 18 to 24 months, including in Anganwadi centres, are scoring seven IQ units higher on cognitive tests than those not attending preschool, even after accounting for poverty, maternal education and early stunting. In a similar Brazilian birth cohort, children who received structured preschool had higher cognition scores by eight units at age five. This is powerful evidence that stimulation and nutrition have strong, independent effects and amplify each other when both are fulfilled.

A role for Anganwadis

Indian policymakers are responding to new evidence quickly. The Anganwadi system has started to incorporate this broader understanding of holistic early childhood development into its core design. This shift is most visible in the rollout of national frameworks such as Aadharshila and Navchetana and programmes such as Poshan Bhi Padhai Bhi. They are critical inputs in redefining neighbourhood Anganwadis as vibrant early childhood education centres that nourish both mind and body. Aadharshila strengthens play-based preschool education within centres, while Navchetana extends early stimulation into the home, equipping caregivers with simple, science-based ways to support development through everyday interactions.

In clinical practice, we offer these frameworks to parents everyday, helping to turn routine moments into opportunities for learning. We encourage the integration of Navchetana's "loving, talking and playing" into daily life while feeding, cooking or playing with children. The home lays the foundation of early language, cognition and socio-emotional skills in the first three years, and Anganwadis deepen it through structured play-based activities, storytelling and peer learning from ages three to six.

Systemic community mobilisation initiatives, such as Poshan Pakhwada conducted in April 2026 by the Ministry of Women and Child Development focus on promoting early stimulation for brain development, play-based education in the early years, and the role of parents and communities in reducing screen exposure and strengthening engagement with Anganwadis. The campaign signals that early childhood development is not confined to centres or programmes, but depends on what happens within households and neighbourhoods.

Building futures

An "ecological" approach uplifts families as much as it strengthens children. Reliable childcare gives mothers the time, the confidence and the opportunity to work, study or contribute economically. In Vellore, we have seen women trained as childcare workers gain both dignity and livelihood, creating a virtuous circle of care. When the kitchen, classroom and crèche align, children flourish, women work and communities thrive.

For a Viksit Bharat, progress cannot rest on calories alone. The physical and interactive learning and playing environments in homes, Anganwadis and communities must be as enriching as the meals they receive.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Safeguarding shipping

While the protection of maritime routes and the enforcement of sanctions are matters of international policy, the use of lethal force against merchant ships — especially those with documented connections to neutral nations — is a dangerous escalation. It is imperative that all parties prioritise diplomatic channels over confrontation to ensure that the lives of merchant sailors are protected and that international maritime commerce is not treated as collateral damage in geopolitical disputes.

Ram Kumar Viswanathan,
Bengaluru

Surface appearances

The 'Open Page' article, "The demands of beauty" (June 14), made for realistic and engaging reading. Today, gyms and spas have become ubiquitous. Sadly, even fruits and vegetables are not spared in the pursuit of appearance. They may look attractive on the outside, but are often tasteless within, their natural fragrance diminished by the excessive use of chemicals and pesticides, both harmful to health.

In a world obsessed with appearances, physical beauty is frequently prioritised over inner well-being. The finest cosmetics and make-up offer only temporary enhancement. Our ancestors lived in an era when gyms, spas and beauty products were largely unknown. Yet, they were often healthier and, arguably, looked better than we do today. Nothing can truly replace the original.

Balasubramaniam Pavani,
Secunderabad

Corrections & Clarifications

In the Data Point, "A World Cup like no other" (Opinion page, June 9, 2026), the photograph of Cristiano Ronaldo was used instead of Ronaldo Nazário.

The Readers' Editor's office can be contacted by Telephone: +91-44-28576347/28576300; E-mail:readerseditor@thehindu.co.in

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Towards a fair, efficient insolvency regime

Vinay Juneja

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The outline of India's Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) has long been demarcated by an innate stiffness between the inevitability to preserve distraught companies and the necessity to safeguard the interests of creditors. This contradiction is often cited as the 'Chakravyuha Challenge'– a structural paradox by which the economy eases a company's entry into the system but forms formidable formal fences when it wishes to exit.

From the Sick Industrial Companies Act, which demonstrated a debtor-in-possession model and had been plagued by promoter misuse, to the creditor-in-control model of the IBC, the historical flight of such laws reflects an incessant effort to improve the balance. Though the IBC aimed at providing time-bound resolutions, it has fallen short due to protracted litigation and procedural lapses. In light of this, the 2026 Amendment to the IBC presents the Creditor-Initiated Insolvency Resolution Process (CIIRP), a hybrid apparatus attempting to espouse debtor-in-possession topographies with the creditor-in-control model. Nevertheless, the amendment's restrictive framework bounds initiation rights to only a fine class of financial creditors belonging to "notified financial institutions", thereby inviting constitutional contests and economic ineptitude.

Swift yet stringent alternative

The CIIRP is a clever attempt to address financial crisis without the value-destroying disruption of typical liquidation proceedings by allowing the current management to maintain control over activities under the supervision of a resolution specialist. In order to reduce judicial intervention and procedural delays, the IBC established the CIIRP procedure by adding Sections 54C to 54P.

Significantly, the change is a legislative response to the ruling in *Vidarbha Industries*. The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) was formerly given discretionary authority via the interpretation of "may" in Section 7(5)(a), which permitted it to postpone or reject admission even in cases where debt and default were proven. This has now been replaced by the required "shall" via the 2026 amendment, thereby compelling the NCLT to accept cases based on information utility records. As a less disruptive restructuring instrument, the CIIRP is an appealing, if exclusive, resort for creditors because corporate debtors experiencing transitory liquidity crises suddenly lack the breathing room to fight initiation.

However, by limiting the ability to start the CIIRP only for "notified financial institutions," the Act creates an arbitrary hierarchy within the class of financial creditors. Although the distinction between financial and operational creditors was previously maintained in *Swiss Ribbons* via the "intelligible differentia" standard of Article 14, this sub-classification is essentially different. The government's argument that "notified" institutions have special knowledge is out of date; sophisticated investors with the ability to perform in-depth restructuring analysis can be found in today's financial markets. The Act runs the danger of being overturned as arbitrary since it does not explain why these excluded parties are less able to promote resolutions that maximise value.

Operational and smaller financial creditors are significantly disenfranchised under the current arrangement as they are already at the bottom of the repayment priority list. Smaller creditors may be forced to the sidelines of restructuring talks as a result of the CIIRP's propensity to concentrate bargaining power in the hands of notified institutions. It compels non-notified creditors to undertake the more aggressive and disruptive Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) just to protect their financial interests. This compromises the equity of the entire insolvency ecosystem.

> India can make an efficient insolvency system that benefits everyone by using a universal CIIRP model based on financial interest instead of institutional identity

The way ahead

The Indian method is mysteriously constrictive. The U.S.' Chapter 11 and the U.K.'s Part 26A restructuring plans base their access on objective financial conditions rather than the regulatory identity of the creditor. A wide range of stakeholders can participate in the restructuring process in both the U.S. and the U.K. as long as they meet certain requirements. India's choice to restrict initiation rights to a particular group of creditors is an anomaly that deters foreign investors from participating because they believe that the Indian market is intrinsically skewed against their asset classes. The law gives notified institutions procedural dominance, which makes Inter-Creditor Agreements less clear and informal negotiations less fair. If a lender who hasn't been notified is put on hold, they have to file for formal CIRP to protect their capital.

There must be a "universal CIIRP" with a "default-neutral initiation rule". This proposal does away with regulatory status and replaces it with a threshold based on financial exposure. Any financial creditor could start the process as long as they get the support of creditors holding at least 51% of the total financial debt. This takes care of constitutional issues while keeping a strong protection against one-sided, malicious filings.

By adding debtor-in-possession features, the 2026 amendment shows that the pure creditor-in-control model doesn't keep business value. But the 'notified institution' criteria could hurt these gains. India can make an efficient insolvency system that benefits everyone by using a universal CIIRP model based on financial interest instead of institutional identity.

Pawar struggles: parties in flux

Internal dissent, diminishing power, and leadership crises mar the two NCPs

STATE OF PLAY

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit

In Maharashtra, the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) is at a crossroads. The party, which was formed by Sharad Pawar in 1999, has been a strong regional force, being in power for 20 of the 27 years of its existence, in alliance with parties across the ideological spectrum. Its split in 2023 led to a majority of the leaders and cadre turning to Ajit Pawar, who had joined hands with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). He claimed ownership of the original party, which the top court eventually ratified. Sharad Pawar was thus left with only a fraction of the party's strength, and had to float a new party named the NCP-SP (Nationalist Congress Party-Sharadchandra Pawar). He now looks to his daughter Supriya Sule to lead the party, as a young and comparatively inexperienced grand-nephew, Rohit Pawar, tries to flex his muscles in Baramati and beyond. Away from power, the cadre and its leaders are in a state of disarray.

After the split in 2023, Ajit Pawar proved his mettle in the State in the 2024 elections, while Sharad Pawar's party dominated in the Lok Sabha polls. But the sudden demise of Ajit Pawar earlier this year dealt a heavy blow to both parties as their leaders admitted that talks of a merger were underway when Ajit Pawar was alive. Today, Ajit Pawar's NCP has been inherited by his politically inexperienced wife, Sunetra Pawar, who continues to be a part of the Mahayuti government led by the BJP. She is Maharashtra's first woman Deputy Chief Minister. A massive sympathy wave got her elected by a national record during her first Assembly election (by-polls) in April this year from Baramati; none of the major parties fielded any candidate against her. The Baramati constituency is considered to be a bastion of the Pawars, with Ajit Pawar being elected as its legislator for eight consecutive terms.

The possibility of a merger between the two NCPs has now faded, largely due to the interpersonal relations within the Pawar family. During his address on the foundation day last week, Sharad Pawar started his speech by taking a dig at his former party over their full-page advertisements in all the major newspapers.

A new dynamic

In the NCP, the murmurs in the power corridors about Sunetra Pawar being highly influenced by her son, Parth Pawar, who is a political novice, cannot be ignored. Several complaints of his high-handed behaviour, rude nature, and efforts to sideline experienced leaders are being heard within the party. Party leaders also point to the undue influence of its alliance partner – the BJP. If the party continues to be handled this way, disruptions are likely to be seen by the 2029 elections, leaders opine. Meanwhile, Sunetra Pawar warned against 'undue interference' in the party during her foundation day address.

The cadre is also unhappy with opportunities being doled out to 'outsiders'. Recently, Parth Pawar's friend Vikram Kakade was given the Legislative Council seat from Pune, much to the opposition of the local leadership.

However, in the NCP-SP, there is no doubt as to who is in charge – Sharad Pawar. He is a beacon of hope for the disgruntled elements in the NCP. At the party's foundation day celebration in South Mumbai's YB Chavan auditorium, the octogenarian's large cut-outs were prominently displayed. Supriya Sule stayed away from the stage, and did not deliver an address. She did however wait for photo opportunities with the party workers after the event. Rohit Pawar, even though seated on the stage, spoke briefly and left immediately after the event to launch a protest. He appealed to party workers to struggle as an effective opposition, adding that the fruits of power enjoyed by the NCP were transient in nature. He glorified the value of struggle in Maharashtra's history, lauding those who had stayed with Sharad Pawar after the split.

Thereafter, Sharad Pawar went on to praise Jawaharlal Nehru, Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi in his speech, slamming Prime Minister Narendra Modi for comparing himself with Jawaharlal Nehru. This was significant given the consistent speculations about the likelihood of his party merging with the Congress.

Today, the family, which has chartered Maharashtra's electoral landscape for more than four decades, lacks robust leadership, and is also dealing with the raw political ambition of the younger generation which lacks political experience. This, even as their leaders accuse each other of further splits and mergers.

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Making sense of the biggest IPO in history

SpaceX's grand entry has raised concerns over the relaxation of rules enabling wealth concentration in the hands of a few

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A.
Sambavi Parthasarathy
Nitika Francis

Technopreneur Elon Musk, who was already the planet's richest person, became the world's first trillionaire with his company SpaceX's stock market debut on June 12, 2026. The company saw the biggest-ever initial public offering (IPO) in history.

However, SpaceX's entry has also raised concerns over the company's valuation; the relaxation of rules that enables the company to enter indices like the Nasdaq-100; and the increasing concentration of wealth among a few. New York City's mayor Zohran Mamdani, in a cryptic reaction on X said, "Reason #1,000,000,000,000 why we should tax the rich".

SpaceX's market capitalisation, now estimated over $2 trillion is less than the Gross Domestic Product of only 11 countries in the world, an indication of the unequal distribution of wealth **(Chart 1)**. Additionally, Mr. Musk had merged his companies Starlink and xAI (which includes X) with SpaceX before he planned the IPO. As of Friday, SpaceX was the sixth largest company in terms of market capitalisation **(Table 1)**. However, as the table shows, it is the only loss-making company in the list.

Among the three companies that are part of SpaceX, Starlink is the only company that has reported profits last year, leading many to express concerns that Mr. Musk has managed to sell the potential of his company, which includes building data centres, instead of its actual track record **(Table 2)**.

If one were to place SpaceX's IPO in Indian terms, the initial offering of all the top 100 IPOs in India would not match the $75 billion raised by the U.S. giant on Friday.

Soaring disparity

The data for the charts were sourced from Space Exploration Technologies Corp's Securities and Exchange Commission filings, Nasdaq, Renaissance Capital, World Bank, India Budget and Forbes

CHART 1: SpaceX's market capitalisation is greater than the GDP of 157 of the 168 countries analysed based on available World Bank data

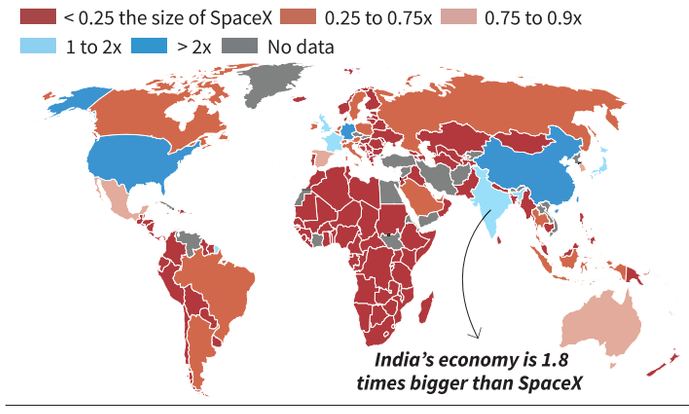

CHART 2: The chart shows the net worth (in $ billion) of five of the most richest persons in the world

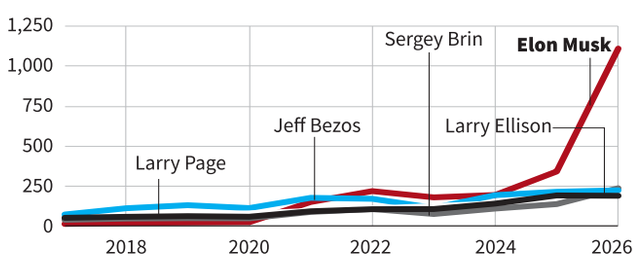

CHART 3: The 25 biggest-ever IPOs in history in terms of values of shares offered (in $ million). SpaceX is nearly four-times bigger than Aramco

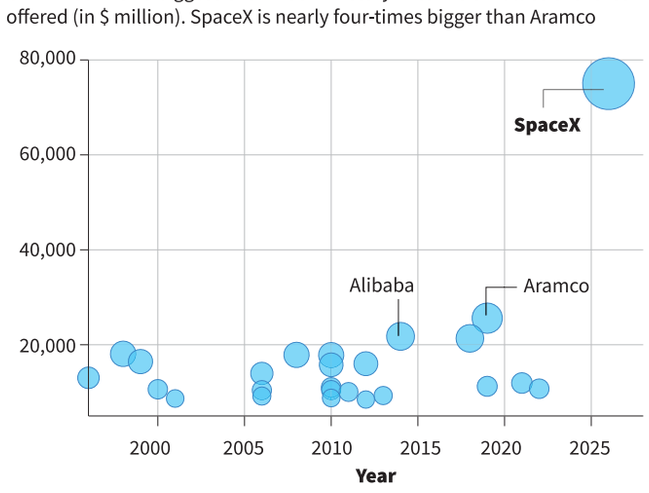

CHART 4: The 10 biggest IPOs from India in terms of the total value of shares offered (in ₹ crore). They do not add to even a tenth of the $75 billion raised by SpaceX

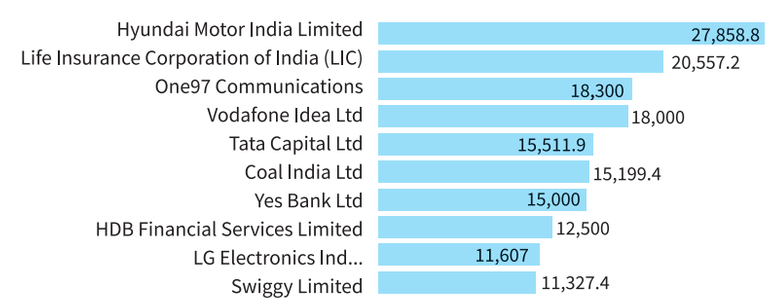

TABLE 1: The five biggest companies in terms of market capitalisation, along with their revenues, and income

Rank	Company	Market capitalisation (in $ trillion)	Revenue in 2025 (in $ billion)	Net income in 2025 (in $ billion)
1	NVIDIA	4.96	215.93	120.06
2	Alphabet	4.35	402.83	132.17
3	Apple	4.27	416.16	112.01
4	Microsoft	2.90	281.72	101.83
5	Amazon	2.56	716.90	77.60
6	SpaceX	2.10	18.67	-4.94

TABLE 2: Starlink is the only company to have reported profits in the last year

Companies part of SpaceX	Revenue (in $ billion)	Operating income (in $ billion)
SpaceX	4.086	–0.657
Starlink	11.387	4.423
xAI	3.201	–6.355

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JUNE 15, 1976

U.S. planning arms aid to Kenya, Zaire

Washington, June 14: The United States is on the verge of beginning a military aid programme for Kenya and Zaire under which those two nations would become the first African countries below the Sahara (besides Angola) to receive weapons and military training from the U.S.

Reports reaching here from Brussels said the U.S. Defence Secretary, Mr. Donald Rumsfeld, who was attending meetings at the NATO headquarters was now en route to Nairobi and Kinshasa, to discuss with African leaders there, their military equipment needs.

The Rumsfeld trip to Africa, which comes not long after the Secretary of State, Dr. Kissinger's own visit to that continent, apparently has more or less the same purpose – prevent African nations from going the Angola way into the Soviet orbit of influence.

But while Dr. Kissinger sought to do this by diplomatic means and by promising moral and economic support to the Africans' struggle against white oppression in such places as Rhodesia, Namibia and South Africa, Mr. Rumsfeld apparently is trying to achieve the same thing by promising American military aid to selected African countries which perceive a need for them as security against neighbours who have Soviet connections.

There is a Soviet presence in Somalia which is Kenya's north-eastern neighbour. Zaire borders Angola, whose leaders have not forgotten that Zaire backed the pro-Western rebels during the recent civil war. While Zaire is said to be seeking American anti-tank weapons for ground defence, Kenya is said to be interested in U.S. fighter aircraft.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JUNE 15, 1926

A new lightship

Rangoon, June 14: A new lightship known as 'China Bakir' lightship to be stationed at the mouth of the Rangoon river is being erected by the Port Commissioners. The vessel which has a candle power of 50,000 is reported to be unique of its kind in the East in respect of up to date arrangements and labour saving devices. Special care has been taken to make the ship's light visible under the most favourable circumstances. The vessel is expected to be completed within the next three months.

From Page One

PM, Macron talk stresses economic security

Calling for the early implementation of the India-EU FTA, which was signed in February this year, the two sides agreed to set up a High-Level Mechanism to double trade in five years. The discussion also focused on cooperation in the SME, rail, and aviation sectors.

Mr. Modi and Mr. Macron agreed to strengthen supply chain resilience, particularly in critical minerals, as part of the 'Dialogue on Economic Security', as per the press release.

On the major crises in the world - in West Asia, including Iran and Gaza, as well as on Ukraine - the press release remained circumspect relative to the February 17, 2026 joint statement from the two countries, saying only that leaders exchanged views "on matters of global importance, including the situation in West Asia and Ukraine".

The Prime Minister thanked Mr. Macron for the speedy implementation of visa-free transit for Indians in French airports and invited French universities to open campuses in India under the New Education Policy, as per the government statement.

The two leaders discussed private sector collaboration in the space sector and the SHANTI Act's (legislation governing the nuclear sector) implications in India.

"I think the field is open for French nuclear companies in this case to start looking at direct participation in the Indian nuclear sector, or do so with in participation with Indian private sector companies, whether in conventional nuclear power reactors or in the more advanced small modular reactors," Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said at a press briefing in Nice.

Mr. Misri also confirmed that discussions between French power giant EDF and the Nuclear Power Cooperation of India Limited for the Jaitapur nuclear power plant - with six reactor units - were still on-going. The project has been under discussion for more than 15 years.

Following the bilateral discussions, Mr. Modi departed France for Vienna from where he travelled to Bratislava, Slovakia, for the second leg of his Europe visit.

Iran questions U.S. deal after Israel hits Beirut

"The Supreme National Security Council has concluded that the path of dialogue should be pursued," the Iranian President said, pointedly adding that the council was in charge of "decisions regarding war and negotiations".

U.S. Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said he did not expect the Israeli attack to "disrupt" the progress towards a deal.

"From all I know, we are on track," he said. "It is not a matter of if. It is a matter of when."

The U.S. President and mediator Pakistan said on Saturday they expected the deal would be signed on Sunday, but Tehran had cast doubt over the timing while hardline protesters in Iran voiced opposition. Mr. Trump had said the Strait of Hormuz would open immediately after the signing.

Mohammad Jafar Assadi, deputy commander of Iran's top joint military command, was quoted by state media as saying Israeli "crimes" in Beirut's southern suburbs would not go unanswered.

Mr. Trump stressed in a later post that "there should be no more attacks by Israel anywhere in Lebanon, but there should also be no more attacks by any other party, including Hezbollah, against Israel."

Hezbollah fired missiles into Israel on March 2, two days after the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran and sparked the war in West Asia. Israeli troops have since pushed their invasion of Lebanon deeper than at any point in over a quarter century.

Iran wants a ceasefire deal to include the fighting in Lebanon.

Iran's government warned that any division at home over the deal weakens its negotiating position, and those criticising negotiators are taking aim at a national decision. Iranians must recognise that no war lasts forever, spokesperson Fatemeh Mohajerani told the state-run *IRNA news agency*. Mr. Trump was expected to discuss demining the Strait of Hormuz during the G7 summit in France on Monday.

Seven held for lynching Kerala man in Bengal

The man arrived in Kultali two weeks ago with his friends who had been working in Kerala, the police said adding that the incident took place at a market in the village's Sankijahan area where he had gone alone on the morning of June 9. Local media reports said the man had lost his way.

"The villagers tied him with a rope and assaulted him. A section of locals said that the man could not clearly explain his identity due to language barrier," said the officer.

A team from the Kultali police station reached the spot, rescued the injured man, and took him to the Joynagar-Kultali Rural Hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

"We have *suo motu* lodged an FIR and have started the investigation. The reason for his death is not yet clear. The body has been sent for an autopsy. His name is not known. We are speaking to the locals and are trying to trace his friends," said the officer. A case has been lodged under the Section of 103 (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

World needs inclusive, human-centric tech: PM

India is emerging as a technology provider, says Modi at France event; India is not a country full of contractors alone but a country of innovation and technological disruption, says French President

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Inaugurating the Bharat Innovates 2026 event in Nice in France, Prime Minister Narendra Modi pitched India as a destination for innovation and development. Both the Prime Minister and French President Emmanuel Macron focused on themes of trust and cooperation in technology.

"I earnestly invite every investor, every university, every research institution, and every entrepreneur ...come to India... design in India. Develop in India. And create solutions for the world," he said. Mr. Macron also spoke at the event, which he co-inaugurated with Mr. Modi. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar were also present as was the Mayor of Nice.

India was seen as a technology adopter a decade ago but was now emerging as a technology provider, the Prime Minister said as he batted for India's innovation ecosystem, citing work in the defence and space sectors. Referring to the recent legislative changes (via the SHANTI Act) permitting private sector participation in the nuclear power sector, Mr. Modi said, "This is creating new possibilities in the fields of clean energy, advanced reactors, and frontier research."

While speaking of upheaval of technologies, Mr. Macron at the inauguration mentioned that France is a 'part of Make in India'. PTI

India and France had a relationship characterised by shared conviction, connection, innovation, and inspiration as well as shared values and vision, Mr. Modi said.

Both the Prime Minister and Mr. Macron referred to trust in technology, with Mr. Modi saying the world was looking for trusted, inclusive and human-centric technologies.

"In recent days we have seen the temptation to close up the AI models and to make them a power tool and to stop any cooperation," Mr. Macron said, presumably referring to the U.S. government banning non-U.S. citizens from accessing AI company Anthropic's state of the art models.

India and France believe in "true partnerships", in multilateralism, and respect for cooperative AI, Mr. Macron said.

Mr. Goyal had also alluded to trust as an issue in technology in his introductory remarks saying that right now, the upheaval in geopolitics was meeting the upheaval in technology. "At such moments, the world seeks trusted and reliable partners, and that is what India brings to the table," he added. Citing India's Chandrayaan-3 lunar mission of 2023, Mr. Macron said it demonstrated not just innovation but also industrial application.

Make in India

India is not a country full of contractors alone but a country of innovation and technological disruption, Mr. Macron said. The French President also addressed entrepreneurs and investors at the gathering, pitching France as the top destination for AI and tech. Mr. Macron claimed that France was the only country whose development of LLMs (Large Language Models, a type of AI) could compete with that of China and the U.S.

"'Make in India' is something we respect and we are a part of it," Mr. Macron said.

According to French diplomatic sources, France was willing to align its defence cooperation with India, including the proposed sale of 114 Rafale fighter jets to New Delhi with the 'Make in India' programme, *The Hindu* had reported last week.

Security forces will retaliate if fired at, warns Manipur DGP

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Earlier, CRPF D-G had asked forces to neutralise miscreants moving in civilian areas with weapons

A week after Central Reserve Police Force Director-General Gyanendra Pratap Singh advised personnel deployed in Manipur to neutralise miscreants moving in civilian areas with weapons, the State's Director-General of Police Mukesh Singh said that the security forces would retaliate if attacked with guns.

Warning individuals carrying firearms and trying to create unrest, the DGP said that such people who fire at the security forces would face strict action in self-defence. "Anyone with arms who tries to take law into their own hands will be dealt with very strictly. Those with weapons will be arrested, and those who fire at us will be dealt with in self-defence," he told presspersons in Churachandpur after his first visit to the Kuki-Zo-dominated district on Saturday.

The DGP said the security forces have so far recovered about 70% of the weapons looted during the initial days of the ethnic violence in Manipur. He also said the police were monitoring online platforms and taking action against individuals and groups spreading misinformation that could trigger ethnic tensions. "Our social media monitoring cell is dealing with such cases," he said.

'On growth path'

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Yumnan Khemchand Singh told journalists on Sunday that Manipur has been on the path to growth during the tenure of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The Chief Minister said Manipur benefited through major initiatives in infrastructure, education, healthcare, sports, connectivity, and social welfare during Mr. Modi's 12 years in office.

He underlined the establishment of the National Sports University, the first of its kind in India, and the implementation of the Inner Line Permit (a temporary travel document for non-residents under a British-era regulation) as examples of the Prime Minister's focus on Manipur.

CISF trains 7,120 personnel in counter-drone operations post-Operation Sindoor

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

A year after Operation Sindoor, the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) has trained over 7,000 personnel in drone and counter-drone operations, a CISF official said.

The training in conjunction with the Indian Air Force (IAF) was initiated amid the growing threat from unauthorised Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs).

The official said the CISF had been tasked with auditing the security of critical installations such as nuclear power plants and thermal power plants among others.

"It is imperative that the CISF personnel posted at vital installations are aware about the emerging threat scenario from UAVs. They should know how to identify and disable such flying objects. The training is going on an intensive scale," said the official.

The training in conjunction was initiated amid the threat from Unmanned Aerial Vehicles.

A barrage of attacks by drones along the Pakistan border were thwarted by security forces in May 2025 after Operation Sindoor. So far, the CISF had trained 7,120 personnel in drone and counter-drone operations, which covered piloting the drones, aerial surveillance, mapping, and neutralisation of hostile drones. The CISF was also in the process of establishing dedicated Drone Training Schools in Hyderabad, Bhilai and Behror, with advanced academic programmes planned alongside the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Kanpur and the Defence Institute of Advanced Technology (DIAT), Pune.

While combating terror and cyberthreats, the CISF continued to be a crucial first responder for industrial disasters, the official said. Its dedicated Fire Wing successfully saving property worth ₹172.55 crore.

Acting on the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) directives, the CISF recently trained 450 State Fire Services personnel from 187 cities in advanced industrial firefighting and disaster management at its Fire Services Training Institute, Hyderabad.

HC seeks NIA reply as Varavara Rao wants to shift to Hyderabad

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court has sought a response from the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on a plea filed by P. Varavara Rao, an accused in the Bhima Koregaon case, seeking permission to relocate from Mumbai to Hyderabad. The 85-year-old Telugu poet, who is out on medical bail, has argued that he cannot financially afford to live in Mumbai.

A Division Bench of Justice Ajay Gadkari and Justice Kamal Khata on Friday issued a notice, directing the NIA to file its reply within two weeks.

Bail condition

Mr. Rao, who has been booked under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, has challenged a March 16 order of a special NIA court, which dismissed his application to reside in Hyderabad. In 2022, the Supreme Court granted him bail on medical grounds. However, the top court had earlier refused to modify a condition that required Mr. Rao to seek prior permission from the trial court if he wished to leave the Greater Mumbai area.

Varavara Rao

The NIA has accused Mr. Rao and 14 other activists of furthering the agenda of the banned CPI(Maoist) and conspiring to overthrow the government. Mr. Rao was arrested on August 28, 2018.

Efforts on to bring back sailor's body from Oman

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Indian Embassy in Muscat on Sunday said it was working to facilitate the earliest repatriation of the body of an Indian national who died due to medical complications aboard a vessel in Oman waters.

In a social media post, the mission said it remained in close touch with the family members of Nishanth Uirthanathan, crew members of the vessel *MT Celestial*, and the authorities concerned. However, it did not provide details of the medical conditions that led to Uirthanathan's death. It said the vessel is soon expected to berth at Duqm port in Oman.

According to the Forward Seamen's Union of India, Uirthanathan passed away on June 11 "after falling seriously ill".

Guwahati students under probe over selling deepfakes

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Assam Police's Crime Branch has begun investigating a case involving some students of two Guwahati-based private schools who circulated digitally altered images of 64 schoolgirls and teachers on social media for a price.

The police said a case was registered with the Crime Branch after at least two students allegedly created the explicit content and sold the images of their female classmates and teachers for ₹50 and ₹100. "We have recorded the statements of the principals, counsellors, and the students involved in circulating the explicit content," Joint Commissioner of Police Ankur Jain told presspersons.

The accused students created the explicit content and put it up for sale on the Telegram app, according to presspersons.

On Friday, one of the schools suspended the students behind the incident and referred the matter to the Child Abuse Monitoring Committee. In a statement, the school said it has a zero-tolerance policy towards cybermisconduct, bullying, harassment, and misuse of digital platforms.

The school also urged all students and parents to refrain from circulating unverified information or indulging in rumour- mongering.

Army unveils new uniform policy, phases out colonial-era practices

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

In a significant move aimed at modernising military traditions and reinforcing an indigenous identity, the Indian Army has introduced revised dress regulations that progressively remove residual colonial-era practices, terminology, and non-essential accoutrements.

The new policy, elaborated in the Army Uniforms-2026 Pamphlet, reflects the Army's effort to align its dress regulations with contemporary Indian values while maintaining the service's rich traditions and professional standards.

A notable feature of the revised regulations is the introduction of a common Uniform Numbering Scheme for the Army, Navy, and the Air Force. The initiative is intended to improve clarity, interoperability, and synergy among the three services while simplifying references to various dress categories.

The changes are aimed at enhancing uniformity, practicality and ease of implementation across the force. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENTS

The Army has retained four broad categories of uniforms – Ceremonial Dress, Working Dress, Mess Dress, and Combat Dress. Unique dress numbers have been assigned to each uniform for ease of identification and administration.

Reflecting India's evolving national identity and contemporary ethos, the latest edition of the Army Uniforms Pamphlet introduces several key changes aimed at shedding remnants of colonial-era practices. Among the notable reforms are the inclusion of the traditional Bandi Jacket as part of formal civil attire, removal of the pouch belt from Mess Dress Nos. 5 and 6, making sword carriage by the Reviewing Officer optional, and discontinuing outdated terminology such as "Royal".

The Army has announced the phased withdrawal of legacy patterns such as Dress No. 3A, which will be discontinued by June 30, 2029.

Structural rejig in Trinamool; rebels removed from roles

Kunal Ghosh, Alifa Ahmed and Arnab Banerjee get new organisational positions in party

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

The rebellion by several Trinamool Congress MPs has forced party supremo Mamata Banerjee to undertake an organisational overhaul.

As part of it, three rebel MPs – Sudip Bandyopadhyay, Mala Roy, and Sayoni Ghosh – were removed from their organisational roles, while new leaders in-charge were appointed for the youth wing, women's wing, and North Kolkata organisational district.

Hours after Sudip Bandyopadhyay, six-time MP from the North Kolkata constituency, met Union Minister Bhupendra Yadav at the latter's residence in New Delhi on Saturday morning, Ms. Banerjee called a meeting and removed him as the president of the party's North Kolkata organisational district. The party's national spokesperson and Beleghata MLA, Kunal Ghosh, was appointed in his place.

Kolkata South MP Mala Roy was removed as president of the party's women's wing and replaced by Alifa Ahmed.

The two-time MP joined the rebel bloc of the 20 MPs led by Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar and attended the group's first meeting with Mr. Yadav and Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari in New Delhi on June 8.

Another rebel MP, Sayoni Ghosh of Jadavpur, who had been retained as the president of the Trinamool Youth Congress during an earlier reshuffle in the party on June 5, was removed. Arnab Banerjee has been appointed in her position.

On Friday, Ms. Ghosh's signature appeared on the list of rebel MPs who decided to extend support to the National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

New inductees

The Saturday's overhaul also saw Dum Dum MP Saugata Roy and former Minister Jyotipriya Mallick inducted into the party's national working committee.

Mr. Roy announced the rejig. He said, "The main thing is that this meeting condemned 'atrocities' on Trinamool Congress workers who are being harassed, beaten up, and whose offices are being burnt. Mahua Moitra, Biman Banerjee and others joined the meeting virtually. It was a full meeting."

20 rebel Trinamool MPs seek to merge with NCPI

The leaders met Lok Sabha Speaker and requested separate seating arrangements; will seek recognition as the Trinamool in July, when Parliament session begins, says Bandyopadhyay

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

After days of speculation, 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs on Sunday met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla at his residence in New Delhi and submitted a letter announcing their decision to merge with the National Citizens Party of India (NCPI).

The decision by the rebels to merge with a registered regional political party rather than form a separate bloc within the Trinamool Congress was to avoid any legal complications under the anti-defection law. The law states that when two-thirds of the legislators of a political party decide to merge with another party, neither those who join the new party nor the ones who stay with the original party face disqualification.

"The MPs met the Speaker and requested separate seating arrangements. We are more than two-thirds of MPs (of the Trinamool Congress) and will merge with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India. We will work with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the NDA for the interest of the country," Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, MP, told presspersons after the meeting.

Big changes: Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla receiving a letter from Trinamool Congress MPs in New Delhi. PTI

Support of 20 MPs

The office of the Speaker confirmed that 19 MPs attended the meeting. The rebel faction, however, claims the support of 20 MPs, with Sudip Bandyopadhyay joining the group on Saturday.

Mr. Bandyopadhyay, the senior-most MP in the rebel camp, said that while the MPs were merging with the NCPI as of now, in July, when Parliament session begins, they would seek recognition as the Trinamool Congress since they had a two-thirds majority.

"We will merge with the Nationalist Citizens Party, which is a registered regional party. This is the system. When you leave with two-thirds of the party, you cannot demand the name of that party on the first day itself. In July, we will seek recognition as the Trinamool Congress since we have two-thirds of its MPs. Then the courts will decide," he said.

The NCPI was launched as National Citizens Party of India in Tripura in 2015 by a Kolkata-based woman Shewly Kundu.

Later, the party registered itself as Nationalist Citizens Party of India in February 2, 2023 at Sankrail in Howrah district, data from the Election Commission suggest.

Separate bloc

After the defeat of the Trinamool Congress in the 2026 Assembly election in West Bengal, the majority of its Lok Sabha members had decided to set up a separate bloc and held meetings at the residence of Union Minister and Bharatiya Janata Party leader Bhupendra Yadav.

On Sunday, the majority of MPs had gathered at Mr. Yadav's residence before meeting the Speaker. The decision to merge with an almost unknown regional party has come as a surprise in political circles.

Before the rebel MPs met the Speaker, two MPs considered loyalists of Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee also met Mr. Birla and submitted a letter from party leader Abhishek Banerjee.

The letter from the party's leader in Lok Sabha urged the Speaker to treat the Trinamool as a single party represented by its authorised whip and leader and urged him not to recognise any separate group.

Abhishek appears before CID again in fake signature case

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Trinamool Congress national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Sunday appeared before the West Bengal Police's Criminal Investigation Department (CID) for the second time in connection with the case pertaining to alleged forgery of signatures of MLAs.

The CID had asked Mr. Banerjee to appear before it at noon. However, he reached the police headquarters at Bhabani Bhawan at 11.43 a.m. Trinamool spokesperson and Beleghata MLA Kunal Ghosh arrived around 3 p.m. for questioning in the same case. Mr. Ghosh left the building after four hours around 7.25 p.m. while Mr. Banerjee left around 8.30 p.m.

Mr. Banerjee made his first appearance before the CID on Thursday after the Calcutta High Court had earlier in the day directed the Trinamool leader to appear before the agency in connection with the West Bengal Assembly signature scandal investigation by 6 p.m.

The court also granted three-week interim protection to Mr. Banerjee, directing that the CID cannot take any coercive action as long as he cooperated with the investigation.

Abhishek Banerjee at the CID headquarters for questioning on Sunday. ANI

Mr. Banerjee faces interrogations on Monday and Tuesday. On Monday, he is likely to be questioned by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) at its Salt Lake office in the multi-crore cash-for-school job case in West Bengal. The ED served him a notice in the matter on June 3.

On Tuesday, he is again expected at the CID headquarters to face interrogation in a case where he has been accused of inciting violence and threatening Union Home Minister Amit Shah before the recently concluded Assembly election in the State.

It is not clear whether he will appear before the officials in these two cases. Mr. Banerjee does not have protection from the High Court against police action in these cases for now.

Ram Temple panel chief welcomes move to form SIT amid donation issue

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Nripendra Mishra, Chairman of the Ram Mandir Construction Committee, on Sunday welcomed the decision of the Uttar Pradesh government to form a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe the alleged financial irregularities in the donations received by the Ram Temple Trust.

"The most praiseworthy aspect is that the State government acted in less than 24 hours to constitute the SIT and appointed very senior officers to it... we should support the initiative, given the speed at which the State government is acting, setting a time frame of just 15 days. A preliminary report is due in seven days...," Mr. Mishra told presspersons in Ayodhya. He said that the probe panel would make recommendations regarding any pending issues, identify shortcomings, and suggest necessary remedial measures.

Nripendra Mishra

The SIT has been formed to probe allegations of disappearance of donations made to the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, following a request from the Shree Ram Janmabhoomi Temple Trust. It has been directed to submit a final report within 15 days and preliminary report within seven days.

Committee members

The members of the SIT are Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant; Inspector-General Kiran S.; and Special Secretary (Finance) Neel Ratan.

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav, in a cryptic message, reacted to the decision of the State government to form the SIT.

"The origin of this conspiracy is not far away, so there will be no need to go far to take action. If the police are unable to trace the culprit, we can help," he wrote on the social media platform X.

Former BJP MP terms fund row 'serious'; SP calls it an 'insult to Sanatana Dharma'

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

A day after the Uttar Pradesh government formed a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe alleged irregularities in the donations received by the Ram Temple Trust, former Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MP Vinay Katiyar on Sunday termed the matter "serious". He said some members involved in running the trust were "thieves".

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav called the episode an "insult to Sanatana Dharma".

"The investigation is on and it is a very serious matter. People have sacrificed for the temple. Kalyan Singh sacrificed the government, people went to jail, afterwards the temple issue progressed. Some present there are thieves, we will remove them. Either they will run away or we will throw them out," said Mr. Katiyar, a former MP who represented both the Houses, and a key figure of the Ram Temple agitation.

Akhilesh Yadav

Reacting to the SIT probe, Mr. Yadav said it was "very unfortunate" that officials will investigate priests. "It is an insult to the Sanatana Dharma that such a prestigious temple has to be probed."

The Congress described the allegations as a "question mark" on faith, accountability and trust, and said the BJP cannot "evade responsibility".

"The alleged misappropriation of devotees' donations at the Ram Mandir is a question of faith, accountability and trust. When an institution built on the devotion of millions faces such serious allegations, transparency cannot be optional. The BJP, which sought political dividends from the temple, cannot now evade responsibility when questions arise. An independent, credible probe must reveal the truth and fix accountability. Prabhu Ram deserves better than secrecy and silence," said Abhishek Singhvi, MP.

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Invites offers from interested parties for purchase of Mild Steel scrap items, for the two month period JUL - AUG 2026.
Details of the items available for disposal and tender terms and conditions can be had from the Company on written request.
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Notice Inviting e-Tender

The Project Manager (Executive Engineer Designs), PMU-ADB, PWD, Puducherry, on behalf of the President of India, invites online proposals through a Request for Proposal (RFP) for "Consultancy Services for Carrying out Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA), Environmental Management Plan (EMP) and obtaining Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) Clearance for Various Infrastructure Development Projects in the U.T. of Puducherry" proposed under the Asian Development Bank (ADB) loan. For further details, please visit **www.pudutenders.gov.in.**

No:065/DIP/AD(Press)/2026-27 **Project Manager (PMU-EAP)**

Congress to organise job fair on Rahul Gandhi's birthday

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress has announced a job fair, "Maha Rozgar Mela", at the Talkatora Stadium here, on June 19, marking the birthday of the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi. Over 150 companies and institutions will participate, it said.

Addressing a press conference, Youth Congress president Uday Bhanu Chib accused the Bharatiya Janata Party government of failing to check the rising rate of unemployment. Unemployment and exam paper leaks had reached record levels during the tenure of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Mr. Chib alleged.

More than 90 examination papers had been leaked, he said, criticising Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

While the Congress is not in power at the Centre and therefore cannot provide government jobs, the party is attempting to create employment opportunities for young people through engagement with the private sector, he said.

Job seekers, from Class 10 pass to postgraduate degree holders, can participate, according to the organisers. Registration is free.

Cong. questions PM's 'silence' on death of mariners, slams Rubio's remarks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Questioning the government's "silence" over the death of three Indian mariners in a U.S. attack on a commercial vessel near the Gulf of Oman, and the "threatening" and "unacceptable" language allegedly used by U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio in his conversation with External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar in this context, the Congress on Sunday accused the Narendra Modi government of failing to defend India's sovereignty and dignity.

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, accused the government of remaining silent in the face of what he described as overbearing language from the U.S. He said the absence of any regret or apology from Washington, coupled with directives issued to vessels, undermined India's standing. "A free country would never tolerate such language. But our Compromised PM? Silent. They listen like an obedient servant and comply with the orders," Mr. Gandhi said in a post on X.

> A free country would never tolerate such language. But our Compromised PM? Silent. They listen like an obedient servant and comply with orders
> **RAHUL GANDHI**
> Congress leader

"Silence can't be a substitute for accountability," Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge said, pointing out that even three days after the incident, there has been no condolence message or public statement from Mr. Modi. He accused the government of treating Indian lives as an "afterthought" in matters of foreign policy.

Mr. Modi is set to meet U.S. President Donald Trump on the sidelines of the G-7 summit in France next week. Citing the upcoming engagement, Congress general secretary (Communications) Jairam Ramesh questioned whether Mr. Modi would condemn the incident off the Oman coast, as well as Mr. Rubio's "threatening" and "really unacceptable" language when he meets his "self-declared good friend" President Trump.

He also called for scrapping the India-U.S. trade deal, arguing that it would endanger the future of crores of Indian farmers.

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Notice Inviting Tender

RFP No. 01 **Date 15-06-2026**

Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL) invites online bids, till 11.00 hrs. on 10-07-2026, for selection of Transaction Advisor cum Merchant Banker/Arranger for mobilization of Rs. 10,000 crore through proposed issuance of NCDs/bonds from all SEBI Registered 'Category-I' Merchant Bankers, whose registration is valid for at least last five financial years i.e., since 1st April 2021. More details on the Services are provided in the RFP document.

Availability of RFP documents	Can be downloaded from website **https://eproc.punjab.gov.in** from 16th June, 2026 (zero date) onwards
Last date for submission of bids	11.00 hrs. on 10-07-2026
Opening of Technical bid	12.00 hrs. on 10-07-2026
Bid validity period	120 days from the date of opening
Pre-Bid Conference	Bidders interested to participate in the pre-bid meeting are required to get themselves registered by sending an email to **Financial Advisor, PSPCL** at **finance-advisor@pspcl.in** with name, designation and mobile numbers of persons interested to participate latest by **23rd June, 2026** Date and time of Pre-Bid Conference shall be intimated by email.

Note: Corrigendum(s) & addendum, if any, shall be published on **https://eproc.punjab.gov.in** only.

-sd-
Financial Advisor,
PSPCL, Patiala

1079/12/2026-27/12332 C 652/26

INBRIEF

INS Sharda concludes visit to Colombo, boosts bilateral ties

Indian Naval Ship (INS) *Sharda* departed Colombo on June 13 after a successful port call that further strengthened maritime cooperation and friendship between India and Sri Lanka. The visit featured a range of professional, training and sporting engagements between the two maritime forces. The Indian Navy informed that as part of capacity-building initiatives, Sri Lankan Navy personnel received training in small arms handling, basic firefighting, first-aid and rescue procedures aboard the ship. The engagements were aimed at enhancing operational preparedness and fostering greater interoperability between the two forces.

8 killed in lightning strikes across 6 Jharkhand districts

Eight people, including three women and two boys, were killed in lightning strikes across six districts of Jharkhand, the police said on Sunday. Two people each were killed in Ranchi and Garhwa districts, while the remaining deaths were reported in Chatra, Giridih, Seraikela-Kharsawan, and Jamtara districts. The bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination. The two deceased from Ranchi district were struck by lightning while working in their fields, sub-inspector Sataydeo Prasad of Pithoria police station said. In Giridih, a 10-year-old boy died from burns sustained from a lightning strike.

4 jump off train in M.P. over rumour of fire, run over by another train

Three women and a child were killed in incident in Morena district; Jhansi DRM says passengers stopped at curve due to which they may not have seen the approaching train; denies fire incident

The Hindu Bureau
BHOPAL

Four passengers, one a child, who jumped off a train following a rumour of fire, were run over by another train in Morena district of Madhya Pradesh on Sunday, officials said.

According to officials of the North Central Railway, the incident took place around 4.15 p.m. between the Hetampur and Dholpur sections of Jhansi railway division after a passenger in a general coach pulled the alarm chain of the Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity Express.

The deceased include three women and a child who were identified as Virma Devi, 60, a resident of Bikaner district in Rajasthan; Shakuntala Devi, 60; Afreen, 35; and her four-year-old son Asad Khan, all residents of Agra district in Uttar Pradesh.

"According to preliminary information, while the train was stopped, some passengers alighted and moved onto the adjacent railway track," North Central Railway said in a statement, adding that some passengers who got down were hit by the Firozpur-Seoni Patalkot Express.

Police and railway officials recover bodies from the railway tracks in Morena district of Madhya Pradesh on Sunday. PTI

"Upon receiving information about the incident, officials from the Railway Administration and local administration immediately rushed to the site," the statement said.

Nadeem Khan, Afreen's husband, said that he and his family jumped off the train after some people started a rumour of fire in the train.

"People started jumping off the train, so we also jumped. But, my elder child got left behind in the train, so I went to check on him while my wife and younger son were outside. That was when another train approached and my wife and son were run over by it," he said.

Jhansi Divisional Railway Manager (DRM) Anirudh Kumar said that the passengers had stopped at a location where there was a curve due to which they may not have seen the approaching train.

"There is a 1.8 degree curve at the spot and people who were on the second track may not have seen the train. The train was in a significant speed and the driver even tried to hit the emergency breaks but people got run over due to the fast speed," he said, after inspecting the spot.

Mr. Kumar denied that there was a fire incident in the train saying that the railway did not receive any information of a blaze.

"We received an official complaint that a woman had pulled the chain and she got down with some other women, and their legs got cut by the other train. If there were a fire, at least one photo or video of it must have come to light since there were about 120 people in the general coach," he said.

CBSE must disclose tender process for answer sheet: CIC

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has directed the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to disclose "point-wise categorical" information, permissible under the Right to Information Act, related to expenditure on exams and details of answer books, including the tendering and procurement process, for Class 10 and 12 board examinations.

After setting aside the CBSE's earlier denial of information under the RTI, the transparency panel asked it to furnish revised replies.

The case arose from an RTI application seeking details of answer books used in Class 10 and 12 Board examinations during the 2023-24 and 2024-25 sessions, including paper quality, number of pages, size, purchase cost, total expenditure, GST payments and details of the tender process for procurement of answer sheets.

In its response, the CBSE disclosed certain specifications of the answer books.

Setting aside the CBSE's earlier denial of information, the CIC asked it to furnish replies.

However, information relating to the purchase cost of answer books, the number purchased and total expenditure incurred on procurement was denied under Section 8(1)(e) of the RTI Act.

The Commission found that the Central Public Information Officer (CPIO) had denied information under multiple exemption clauses "without giving any proper justification".

"...the Commission, deems it fit, to direct, CPIO to revisit the contents of the RTI application in question and provide a revised point-wise categorical replies along with relevant permissible information that can be provided," the CIC said.

Eight killed as vehicle falls into well in Maharashtra

Press Trust of India
SOLAPUR

Eight people - four women and four children - were killed and seven injured on Sunday when a pick-up vehicle carrying them plunged into a roadside well in Solapur district of Maharashtra, the police said. Fifteen people were travelling in the vehicle when the accident occurred. The vehicle plunged into the well after the driver lost control, said Atul Kulkarni, Superintendent of Police, Solapur.

The vehicle was being pulled out of the well, and the injured people were being rushed to the hospital, he said.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis expressed grief over the loss of lives in the accident and announced financial assistance of ₹5 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased person.

Odisha village to get crocodile alert system under 'Smart Village' plan

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

As the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) accelerates the deployment of technologies in Kusunpur, a remote village in Odisha's Kendrapara district, as part of the 'Smart Village' initiative, residents may soon receive alerts whenever crocodiles stray dangerously close to their homes.

The CSIR laboratories are planning to introduce an artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled wild animal detection and alert system. The system is likely to be installed at two key entry points to the village.

Kendrapara has logged one of the worst rates of human-crocodile conflicts in the State, with more than 20 fatalities reported over the past four years.

Kusunpur is set to witness a comprehensive infrastructure upgrade, including a renovated water gate facility, an underground drainage system, a reconstructed community building, community toilets, and a revamped cremation centre. Roads will be developed using innovative methods, including cold mix technology, waste plastic road technology, and cement grouted bituminous mix.

CBRI Director Pradeep Kumar Ramancharla interacting with villagers in Kusunpur on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Under the initiative, the village is expected to emerge as a hub for green livelihoods. The initiative could generate a range of green jobs, while encouraging local entrepreneurs to explore sustainable business opportunities.

Aligned with the CSIR's guiding 'lab to land' principle, a suite of technologies has been proposed for deployment in the village. These include dry flower processing, production of value-added crispy fruits through freeze-drying, and the development of nutritious food products to combat malnutrition.

Other initiatives include biodegradable tableware, small-scale processing units, herbal floor-cleaning liquids, mosquito repellent lotions, and scented candles made from natural beeswax. Plans also include the installation of brick and block-making machines, village-scale rice and green gram milling units, and a scientifically designed parboiled rice processing unit.

"Over the next three years, scientists from 17 CSIR laboratories will visit Kusunpur to ensure smooth deployment of these technologies for the village's overall development," CSIR-Central Building Research Institute (CBRI) Director Pradeep Kumar Ramancharla, who visited the village on Sunday, said.

Vaishnaw expects more companies to produce memory chips in India

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

New companies are likely to invest in India to manufacture memory chips while existing investors will scale up production to address the demand-supply gap in the segment, Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said.

Strong demand for memory (data storage) cards and advanced chips has tightened global supplies and supported higher prices in past quarters, and manufacturers have been sprucing up investments and production capacities to meet market requirements worldwide.

The higher memory chip prices have, in turn, led to a rise in production costs for a range of electronic products, including smartphones and laptops.

"Definitely, a lot more investment is coming in the memory manufacturing units, and that is because for the first time in the way the semiconductor industry has grown at such a rapid pace, for the first time we are seeing a huge shortage of certain components which are required in the AI data centres, the high bandwidth memory chips," Mr. Vaishnaw said.

Ashwini Vaishnaw

Data centre investments in India are expected to cross $200 billion soon, which may need billions of gigabytes of storage capacity.

The Minister said there is a global phenomenon of supply-demand imbalance, which is now getting addressed by setting many more units.

When asked if there will be new investments in the memory chip segment or only existing players have plans to ramp up production, Mr. Vaishnaw said, "Looks like both might happen". He said the India Semicon Mission (ISM) 1.0 could get about 48 startups to work on the tech products.

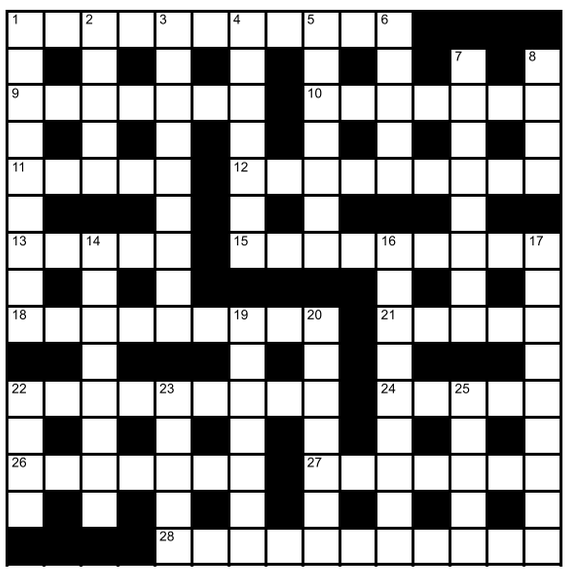
"In ISM 2.0, that will be the topmost priority, design will be the topmost priority. The second biggest priority will be machines, which are used in the manufacturing of semiconductors," Mr. Vaishnaw said.

TH CROSSWORD + 14820

(set by Afterdark)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Assume that a piano expert's press release is having one worried (11)
9 It's tricky to contain West Indies with force on time quickly (7)
10 Tails of rhinoceros, cheetah, impala, lizard, kangaroo, cow, hippopotamus are tails (7)
11 Man wearing hat is shoddy (5)
12 Collected grant? Heard wrongly outside (9)
13 One having primarily rugged muscles, horses perhaps (5)
15 Report on plight faced by people with temperature (9)
18 Old tax I have is too much (9)
21 From the time the French seceded, its quiet (5)
22 Don angrily poses for reforms first (9)
24 Kisses Nora, Erica, Carol, Kate, Susan on the heads (5)
26 Stage of surgeon! (7)
27 Say, Ivy was 151 metres last year-end (7)
28 Country handles rent haphazardly (11)

Down

1 Partner's a saint, hence spies cantered essentially (9)
2 Prince's journey gave satisfaction (5)
3 Say, MNCs upset COO terribly on Saturday (9)
4 Beats HR myths extraordinarily (7)
5 Playing sitar at one university in European country (7)
6 Searches area covering from south to north for excise (5)
7 Relating to a direction, the Royal Navy follows shogun intermittently (8)
8 Second-hand bus Edward secured (4)
14 Tied up with a routine overnight and essentially intense day (8)
16 Principal with teens sail at sea (9)
17 Heartless trader promises to detain apprentice ultimately and release son for money (9)
19 Audit in school, physical education coach initially faces tempo (7)
20 Painful condition is clear, AC here is suffocating (7)
22 First person at say, Pondicherry collecting cess at the end for Lays (4)
23 Had hybrid tea (Earl) with some nougats (5)
25 Ministers expel stranger out of room (5)

SUDOKU

		8		7		5	6	
	1							2
		9	3	2		7		1
			9		1		2	
	5		2		6			
6		7		4	3	2		
2							4	
	4	1		6		9		

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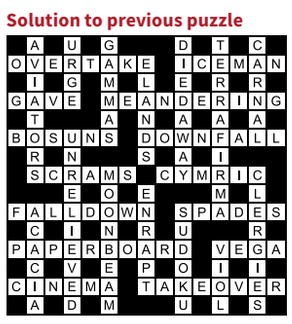
DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

6	5	7	8	3	9	2	1	4
4	8	3	7	1	2	9	6	5
2	1	9	5	6	4	8	3	7
8	7	4	1	2	5	3	9	6
9	6	1	4	8	3	7	5	2
3	2	5	6	9	7	1	4	8
7	9	6	2	5	1	4	8	3
5	3	2	9	4	8	6	7	1
1	4	8	3	7	6	5	2	9

FAITH

Divine blessings of Acharya

Maha Periyava was truly a walking deity in this age. Referring to the saying "*Vidya dadati vinayam*" (knowledge should lead to humility), Maha Periyava explained that Lord Krishna does not like pride arising from knowledge (*vidya garvam*) or pride arising from wealth (*aiswarya garvam*). Narayana Bhattathiri also emphasises this truth. These qualities create a barrier between the devotees and Lord Krishna. Everyone knows of Lord Krishna's immense love for Kuchela (Sudama). Mahalakshmi restrained Lord Krishna from giving excessively. Why? Not because she was unwilling to bless Kuchela, but because too much wealth might make him forget his devotion to Krishna. Wealth should never become a cause for forgetting God.

We were fortunate to live during the time of Maha Periyava and receive his darshan, Damal Sri Ramakrishnan said in a discourse. "Without the grace of the Guru, it is impossible to attain the grace of God."

We call Adi Sankara, the *Jagadguru* (world teacher), yet Adi Sankara himself refers to Lord Krishna as the true *Jagadguru*. He cites the famous verse: "*Vasudeva-sutam devam...Krishnam vandhe jagat gurum*." Lord Krishna, serving as the divine teacher (guru) in the Bhagavad Gita, declares: "*Yada yada hi dharmasya glanir bhavati...*" Whenever righteousness declines and unrighteousness rises, He incarnates to protect dharma. Acharyas explain another important distinction. We are born in this world due to the accumulated results of our past *karma* – our merits and sins. In this Kali Yuga, with the blessings of the guru and through *Nama Sankirtanam* (chanting the divine names of God), people can gain an effective spiritual path.

When to opt for balance transfer in home loan?

Santosh Agarwal

Home loans are mostly availed for the long term and even a marginal shift in interest rates can dramatically increase the total loan cost over time. Home loan interest rates have significantly moderated after peaking a couple of years ago. Borrowers who availed home loans at higher rates should reassess their loan terms and explore home loan balance transfer options.

Home loan balance transfer allows borrowers to migrate their outstanding principal to a new lender offering more competitive rates and favourable terms. Understanding when the balance transfer is optimal can help save on the loan cost significantly. Here's what you need to keep in mind:

If your existing lender is charging a higher interest rate than the prevailing market rates, transferring your home loan to another lender offering lower rates can help reduce your overall borrowing cost.

Even a small reduction in the interest rate can result in significant savings over the loan tenure. For instance, a reduction of 50 basis points in the interest rate after 4 years of repayment of a ₹1 crore home loan for 30 years at an initial interest rate of 8.75% p.a. can reduce the interest outgo by more than 10 lakh over the repayment period.

A larger portion of the EMI is allocated towards interest repayment rather than principal repayment during the initial years of a home loan. As the loan tenure progresses, the interest component gradually reduces while the principal repayment component increases.

Opting for a home loan balance transfer during the early stages of repayment is usually more beneficial. Transferring the loan in the later years may not generate substantial savings.

Borrowers who availed home loans long ago may still have loans linked to older benchmark structures such as the base rate or MCLR regime, often carrying higher spreads. As a result, even when RBI reduced repo rates, many borrowers did not receive the full benefit immediately.

After the adoption of RLLR/EBLR, new home loan rates depend directly on RBI repo rate changes that transmit benefit more quickly from rate revision to borrowers. Opting for a balance transfer to an EBLR/repo rate-linked loan can help borrowers benefit from rate reductions faster.

Borrowers who may have secured a home loan earlier at a higher interest rate due to a lower credit score can consider a low-interest rate home loan balance transfer when their credit profile improves over time. A stronger credit score, usually 760 and above, generally enhances the chances of securing lower interest rates and more favourable loan terms from lenders.

*When the Outstanding Principal is High*It is advisable to opt for a home loan balance transfer when the outstanding principal amount is still high, as transferring a larger loan amount at a lower interest rate can lead to substantial savings over the repayment tenure.

Considering the previous instance, even if the borrower paid the loan for 20 years, the outstanding principal would still remain around ₹42 lakh. At prevailing rates of nearly 7.5% p.a., the borrower can still save close to ₹4 lakh over the loan duration.

A home loan balance transfer can be an effective financial strategy for borrowers looking to reduce their overall borrowing cost. However, a lower interest rate alone should not be the sole factor driving the decision.

Borrowers should carefully evaluate the total savings after accounting for processing charges, foreclosure fees, insurance premiums, legal expenses and other associated costs. It is equally important to assess whether the remaining loan tenure is sufficiently long to generate meaningful savings, as transferring a loan nearing completion may offer limited financial benefits.

Before proceeding with a balance transfer, borrowers should compare offers from multiple lenders, calculate the revised repayment outgo using a Home Loan EMI Calculator, evaluate their financial stability and understand the long-term implications of the switch.

(The writer is CEO, Paisabazaar)

True prosperity will arrive not when more citizens display status, but when more citizens build enduring wealth. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

The price of prestige: Is status up for sale?

Some purchases buy comfort, convenience and time, while others appear to buy something far less tangible: prestige, visibility and status. Inside the economic trap of looking rich

VEBLEN VEIL

Vaishali R Venkat

A humble sleeper-class train ticket from Chennai to Delhi might cost barely ₹1,000, while a seat aboard an airline for the same destination could easily swallow at least ₹13,000. Nearly thirteen times higher. And yet no reasonable soul would name the disparity absurd or extravagant.

For, the flight does something the train cannot: it is folding the distance and compressing time. Here the premium price is no caprice. What the traveller purchases is not just a seat, but comfort, speed and something irrecoverable, something that eludes even the grasp of billionaires: time.

Now let us descend from the skies to the earth. Vroom... Chennai-Bengaluru Highway. Two cars race along the same ribbon of asphalt. One costs ₹4 lakh and the other ₹40 lakh. A tenfold difference in price.

Both battle the same traffic snarls, pause at the same signals, halt at the same toll plazas and arrive in Bengaluru at roughly the same time.

Yet one carries a price tag large enough to buy nine more cars. Engineering, leather upholstery or horsepower explain only part of the story, but much of it lies elsewhere.

The extra cost purchases something far more curious: visibility, prestige and status. Human beings do not merely consume, but also communicate.

> The ultimate irony of the Veblen Effect is that the very things designed to signal wealth actively hinder its accumulation

> The tragedy of many status purchases is not merely what they cost, but what they fail to create

A luxury watch displays far more than time. A designer handbag carries more than just belongings. A premium bungalow shelters far more than its occupants. Sometimes the product itself fades into the background.

The physical object costs only a fraction of the price; the rest buys an invisible narrative wrapped around it: a quiet signal of status, prestige, and the world you belong to. This illusion is what I call the "Veblen Veil," which hides a harsh reality: it drapes itself over the aspiring middle class, blurring the line between real wealth and 'luxurious' lifestyle. More than a century ago, American economist Thorstein Veblen identified a strange paradox at the heart of human behaviour.

For most goods, a higher price cools desire; we buy less as things grow dearer, whereas certain products become more desirable precisely because they are expensive. For such items, the price tag ceases to be a barrier to demand, becoming part of the attraction itself.

The Veblen Effect reaches far beyond luxury cars and designer handbags, quietly shaping household finances, borrowing habits, and even public policy. Families stretch their budgets and sink into debt to host lavish weddings, chase branded lifestyles, or buy duplexes filled with more rooms than their lives have room for. These choices are collective rituals, each a 'status coronation,' wherein families crown themselves with debt to broadcast a lifestyle they cannot afford.

And therein lies the danger: this pursuit of prestige has no finish line. As more people acquire the symbols of prestige, they cease to feel special. Society then raises the bar, creates new markers of status, new aspirations are born, and the race begins again.

The ultimate irony of the Veblen Effect is that the very things designed to signal wealth actively hinder its accumulation, as tomorrow's real wealth is sacrificed for today's fleeting applause.

That ₹40 lakh luxury sedan does not merely cost ₹40 lakh. Hidden within its price tag is an opportunity cost: the crores of rupees that money might have grown into over the decades had it been invested and allowed to compound.

A lavish wedding is celebrated and photographed, but its opportunity cost is rarely photographed: the gold not accumulated, the land not purchased, the investments not made, or the retirement corpus that never had the chance to grow. A sprawling bungalow competes with liquidity by locking a large portion of wealth into bricks and concrete. The extra rooms may stand silent for years, but the maintenance bills or property taxes rarely do. The tragedy of many status purchases is not merely what they cost, but what they fail to create. They consume capital without necessarily producing income, productivity or future wealth.

And the debate does not end here. In a developing country, should success be measured by status consumption or by the ability to withstand economic uncertainties? Does success lie in luxury cars and grand displays of wealth, or in the quieter foundations of prosperity: savings, investments, education, skills, adequate health insurance coverage and financial security? For a rising nation like India, the answer to this question will define the future. True prosperity will arrive not when more citizens display status, but when more citizens build enduring wealth.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Arbitrage funds demystified

COVERNOTE

Arb funds are positioned to exploit any mispricing between futures and its underlying asset, hence they may not necessarily generate alpha from the same benchmark as the active fund

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Arbitrage (arb) funds are positioned to take advantage of the mispricing in futures contracts. The average annual return on such funds is 6.5%. Most investors compare arb funds with bank fixed deposits and conclude that the former may not be a meaningful investment. In this article, we show why it is optimal to compare a combination of an arb fund and a passive fund (ETF or index fund) with an active fund on the same benchmark as the passive fund.

Alpha returns

Active funds are mandated to generate alpha returns. This refers to the excess returns that a fund generates over its appropriate benchmark. Average fees of large-cap active funds are about 1% fees, for index funds about 0.25% and for ETFs less than 0.10%. Active funds charge higher fees for the alpha returns they strive to generate. Note that active funds generate returns that is a combination of market (benchmark) returns and alpha. Empirical evidence suggests that more than 85% of the returns from an active fund can be attributed to the movements in its benchmark index. The higher fee is charged on the entire portfolio including the benchmark return, not just on the alpha component. Not that you can capture the benchmark return through a cheaper passive product.

In other words, you have two ways of generating active returns. You can buy an active fund. Or you can buy an ETF benchmarked to the same index and combine it with an arb fund. The ETF will generate market returns and the arb fund can generate the alpha. Note that arb funds are positioned to exploit any mispricing between futures and its underlying asset. So, arb funds may not necessarily generate alpha from the same benchmark as the active fund. Nonetheless, you would have created your own active fund by combining a passive product and an arb fund.

Bank deposits are exposed to credit risk but have no market risk. Arb funds do not have credit risk. They have typically low market risk, as they are structured to generate returns regardless of the market direction. The issue is that arbitrage opportunities may not always be available. Importantly, funds must be quick to capture such opportunities. So, arb funds may be unable to continually capture such returns. When arbitrage opportunities are unavailable, such funds may have to invest in money market instruments (treasury bills), earning lower returns.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%) Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.35	7.40	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	7.75	7.10	7.10	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	7.75	4.75	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	7.77	7.00	7.50	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	7.80	6.00	6.75	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.10	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.55	7.25	7.25	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	8.10	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.25	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.25	6.65	6.50	6.25
CSB Bank	7.35	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.85	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.50	6.90	7.00	7.50
Federal Bank	6.80	6.25	6.75	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.35	6.50	7.35	6.75
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	7.00	6.65
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.25	6.75	6.65	6.60
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	7.00	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.35	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.30	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70
YES Bank	7.25	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.45	6.25	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.70	6.50	6.70	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.20	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.25	6.10	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.80	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.35
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.75	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.65	6.20	6.10	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

(In %)

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.) Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60
Punjab National Bank	7.25-9.25	7.20-9.15	7.20-9.15
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.10 #	7.10 #	7.10 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
ICICI Bank	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.47 - 11.70	7.47 - 11.70	7.47 - 11.70
Federal Bank	8.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 9.75
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-13.38	8.41-13.38	8.41-13.38
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.30 #	8.30 #	8.30 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.25 #	7.25 #	7.25 #
Tata Capital	8.00 #	8.00 #	8.00 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	9.35 #	9.35 #	9.35 #
Sammaan Capital	8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #
Aditya Birla Capital	8.60 #	8.60 #	8.60 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.65 #	7.65 #	7.65 #

*Extra 0.05% concession to borrowers taking insurance policy
#onwards Rates as on June 10 Source:Paisabazaar.com

DHAKA

Bangladesh's former police chief arrested in Dubai, Minister says

AP

Bangladesh's former police chief Benazir Ahmed was arrested in Dubai, the Interior Minister said. An Interpol Red Notice had been filed against Mr. Benazir — a close ally of former leader Sheikh Hasina — who left the country in 2024. The official was sanctioned by the U.S. in 2021 for his alleged role in extrajudicial killings. AFP

DEIR AL-BALAH

Palestinian death toll in Gaza tops 73,000, officials say, despite truce

AFP

The Palestinian death toll from the Israel-Hamas war has surpassed 73,000, Gaza's Health Ministry said on Sunday, despite a fragile ceasefire that has been described as stalled. The number of deaths since the beginning of the war is now 73,001. Israeli attacks killed at least six Palestinians in the Gaza Strip on Sunday. AP, REUTERS

WASHINGTON

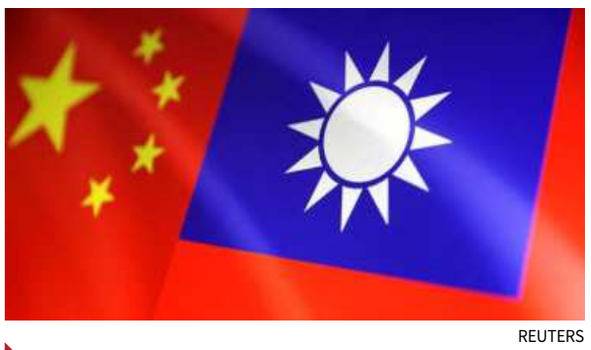
Obama says Trump-Tehran deal will not improve on his 2015 pact

AP

Former U.S. President Barack Obama expressed doubt that any deal between Donald Trump and Iran would "significantly improve" upon his own nuclear pact, referring to 2015 deal that Mr. Trump has abandoned. Mr. Obama said that the U.S. cannot "just bully or bomb our way to solutions" instead of engaging in diplomacy. AFP

TAIPEI

Taiwan launches new intelligence portal amid tensions with China



REUTERS

Taiwan said on Sunday it is establishing a channel for Chinese nationals to offer tips securely, at a time when tensions between Beijing and the self-ruled island remain elevated. Taiwan's National Security Bureau said a new website will act as a secure channel for Chinese nationals to provide intelligence-related information. AP

U.K. forces intercept sanctioned oil vessel linked to Russia's shadow fleet

Armed forces board and detain the fuel tanker attempting to cross the English Channel 'in the first U.K.-led operation of its kind', British Ministry says; Ukraine's Foreign Minister welcomes the operation, calls the shadow fleet a 'tool of war'

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

British forces on Sunday intercepted a sanctioned oil tanker belonging to Russia's shadow fleet in an operation hailed by Kyiv as a blow to Moscow's war machine.

Navy commandos boarded the ship in the English Channel by fast-roping from a helicopter, according to footage released by the Defence Ministry.

Ukraine's Foreign Minister Andriy Sybiga welcomed the operation.

"Russia's shadow fleet is a tool of war. Every such vessel stopped means less money for Russia's war machine," he posted on social media. "Cutting off these revenues helps reduce Russia's ability to finance missile and drone attacks against Ukrainian cities."

Drop and deploy: Royal Marine commandos detain a sanctioned tanker, the *Smyrtos*, in the English Channel on Sunday. AP

The six-hour interception operation was supported by Chinook, Merlin Mk4 and Wildcat helicopters and a maritime patrol aircraft, a Ministry statement said. The frigate *HMS Sutherland* and the minehunter *HMS Ledbury* were also involved.

"In the first U.K.-led operation of its kind, the vessel *Smyrtos* was boarded by Royal Marine Commandos and specially trained law enforcement officers despite Russia's best efforts to evade sanctions and continue fuelling its war with Ukraine," the Ministry of Defence statement said.

The vessel was to be moved to an anchorage off the south coast of England and monitored, it added.

Embargo evasion

The U.K. has sanctioned hundreds of vessels suspected of being part of the shadow fleet used by Russia to bypass Western embargoes since the invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

"Russia relies on its shadow fleet to fund their conflict in Ukraine and our interdiction delivers a blow to [Russian President Vladimir] Putin's illegal war," said newly appointed U.K. Defence Minister Dan Jarvis. He said the operation was carried out in "coordination with the French".

According to the MarineTraffic website, *Smyrtos* sails under the Cameroon flag and left the Russian port of Ust-Luga on June 5, with Port Said, Egypt, listed as its destination.

France, Belgium, Finland and other European countries have also seized sanction-busting vessels believed to belong to the so-called shadow fleet.

Three killed as Israel strikes 'Hezbollah targets' in Beirut

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Israel struck Beirut's southern suburbs on Sunday, killing three people, in response to what it said was Hezbollah fire at northern Israel, while its military also carried out broader strikes on southern Lebanon.

Lebanon's official National News Agency (NNA) said a strike hit an apartment in the Ghobeiry neighbourhood of Beirut's southern suburbs, a Hezbollah stronghold known as Dahiyeh.

Lebanon's civil defence agency reported three dead and six wounded.

Israeli officials including Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu have warned that Israel would strike south Beirut if the Iran-aligned Hezbollah group targets northern Israeli communities, a position they say has the backing of Washington.

Dire straits: People gather at the site of an Israeli airstrike in Beirut's southern suburbs on Sunday. AFP

The Israeli military on Sunday said three suspected Hezbollah drones struck northern Israel in separate incidents, causing no casualties. Hezbollah claimed several attacks on Israeli troops who have invaded south Lebanon, but none on northern Israel.

Lebanon's NNA also reported Israeli strikes on more than 20 locations in the country's south, including the city of Nabatieh. The strikes came both before and after the Israeli Army issued evacuation warnings for almost 30 locations.

Israel's military activity in recent days has been focused on the region around Nabatieh.

Putin and Zelenskyy speak with Trump as strikes kill 2 in Russia

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian President Vladimir Putin and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy each spoke by phone with U.S. President Donald Trump on Sunday, as the war in Ukraine remained a flashpoint ahead of this week's G7 summit.

Mr. Zelenskyy said in a statement on Telegram that he had a "wonderful conversation" with Mr. Trump. He said they discussed "what could help bring peace closer now".

Mr. Putin argued that attacks on Russian civilian infrastructure by Kyiv would not change Ukraine's position on the battlefield, according to Kremlin aide Yuri Ushakov.

The diplomatic exchanges came as Ukrainian drone attacks killed one person and wounded nine others overnight in Oryol region. Another drone attack killed one person in Bryansk region, officials said.

A separate drone strike hit fuel storage facilities in Russia's Yaroslavl region.

China's ability to launch direct missile strikes on Australia 'growing': report

Agence France-Presse
SYDNEY

China is capable of a direct missile strike on Australia and the threat is growing as Beijing amasses long-range and hypersonic weapons and builds islands in the South China Sea, an Australian think tank said on Sunday.

A Lowy Institute report found the main threat to Australia was from Chinese missiles fired from ships, submarines and a new intermediate-range ballistic missile that could reach the island continent from China.

On the watch: China test-fires an intercontinental ballistic missile into the Pacific Ocean, at an undisclosed location. FILE PHOTO

China's capacity to strike Australia would grow over the next decade as "the Dong Feng (DF)-27 intermediate-range ballistic missile, and potentially a conventionally armed intercontinental ballistic missile, grow in service numbers", it said.

The DF-27 missile has a range of 5,000 to 8,000 kilometres, the U.S. military said in December.

"I think the growth of the People's Liberation Army is the most important thing to happen to Australian security since the collapse of the Soviet Union," said Sam Roggeveen, the director of the Lowy Institute's International Security Programme.

Australia reshaped its military strategy three years ago in response to China's rapid navy build-up, focusing on deterring an adversary from its northern approaches.

Swiss voters poised to reject plan to cap country's population

Associated Press
GENEVA

Voters in Switzerland have cast their final ballots on Sunday on an initiative championed by the top right-wing party to cap the rich Alpine country's population at 10 million. Early results showed voters were leaning against it.

The Swiss People's Party, which has the most seats in Parliament, has stirred up and fostered anti-migration sentiment over the years, notably about an influx of workers from the neighbouring European Union.

Some have dubbed the proposal a "Swiss Brexit" because it could jeopardise Switzerland's deep ties to the EU.

Preliminary results showed that nearly 53% of voters rejected the proposal, with nationwide turnout exceeding 57%.

The number of people living in Switzerland has soared by nearly one-quarter over the last generation, and foreigners today make up nearly one-third of the population.

Hamilton claims first win with Ferrari

FORMULA ONE

Agencies
MONTMELO (SPAIN)

Lewis Hamilton claimed his first victory for Ferrari on Sunday at the Barcelona-Catalunya Formula One Grand Prix, ending championship leader Kimi Antonelli's five-race winning streak.

The seven-time world champion finished ahead of George Russell and Lando Norris, while Antonelli was forced to abandon in the final stages because of a technical problem.

Hamilton, 41, cut down Antonelli's title lead to 41 points. Mercedes polesitter Russell came in 19 seconds behind Hamilton, with Norris completing an all-British podium.

Russell, pre-season favourite for the championship, arrived in Barcelona bemoaning bad luck for his recent struggles but after team-mate Antonelli edged in front of him late on he had some good fortune to cut the gap on the teenager to 53 points after the Italian abandoned. Hamilton increased his record win haul to 106 career victories with his first since the Belgian GP in July 2024 while he was still with Mercedes.

The seven-time world champion took advantage of fresher tires and a superior pitstop strategy by Ferrari to overtake Russell.

Antonelli had passed his Mercedes teammate Russell when his car came to a stop on the track with just four laps to go. Hamilton broke Mercedes' grip on the top spot of the podium this season, which had lasted six races.

The results (66/66):
1. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) 1h:32m:28.105s; 2. George Russell (Mercedes) +19.561s; 3. Lando Norris (McLaren) 23.719; 4. Max Verstappen (Red Bull Racing) 40.497; 5. Oscar Piastri (McLaren) 58.661.
+1 lap: 6. Isack Hadjar (Red Bull Racing); 7. Pierre Gasly (Alpine); 8. Franco Colapinto (Alpine); 9. Liam Lawson (Racing Bulls); 10. Arvid Lindblad (Racing Bulls).
+2 laps: 11. Gabriel Bortoleto (Audi); 12. Carlos Sainz (Williams) 13. Esteban Ocon (Haas); +3 laps: 14. Sergio Perez (Cadillac)
DNF: Charles Leclerc (Ferrari); Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes); Oliver Bearman (Haas); Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin); Lance Stroll (Aston Martin); Nico Hulkenberg (Audi); Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac).
NC: Alexander Albon (Williams) + 11 laps.
Standings: Drivers: 1. Antonelli 156; 2. Hamilton 115; 3. Russell 106; 4. Leclerc 75; 5. Norris 73.
Constructors: 1. Mercedes 262; 2. Ferrari 190; 3. McLaren 141; 4. Red Bull Racing 89; 5. Alpine 60.

Manpreet equals Tirkey's 412-game record, but India loses

PRO LEAGUE

Press Trust of India
ROTTERDAM

Veteran midfielder Manpreet Singh equalled former captain Dilip Tirkey's record of 412 international appearances for India but saw his team lose 2-3 to the Netherlands in the FIH men's Pro League game here on Sunday.

Miles Bukkens (third), Koen Bijen (23rd) and Tijmen Reyenga (40th) made it to the scoresheet for the host while Dilpreet Singh (10th) and Sukhjeet Singh (33rd) sounded the board for the visitor. India equalised twice but could not stop the Netherlands from spoiling an eventful day for Manpreet, who is the only active member in the club of players with 400-plus senior international caps.

On the historic moment, Hockey India president Tirkey said: "I congratulate Manpreet on reaching this significant milestone, which is a remarkable achievement.

"It reflects his dedication, commitment and consistency over the years. I wish him the very best for the matches ahead and hope to see him play on many more occasions".

The result: Netherlands 3 (Bukkens 3, Bijen 23, Reyenga 40) bt India 2 (Dilpreet 10, Sukhjeet 33).

WINNING START

Juairiya shines as Bangladesh outplays the Netherlands

AFP

Bangladesh rode on a half-century from Juairiya Ferdous to score a six-wicket win over the Netherlands in the Women's T20 World Cup Group A game in Birmingham on Sunday. **The scores:** Netherlands 139/8 in 20 overs (De Leede 50) lost to Bangladesh 141/4 in 19.1 overs (Juairiya 50). **Toss:** Netherlands; **PoM:** Juairiya.

SENSATIONAL STUFF

Campbelle does the star turn as West Indies stuns New Zealand

GETTY IMAGES

Shemaine Campbelle's unbeaten 90 helped West Indies stun defending champion New Zealand by seven wickets in a Women's T20 World Cup Group B game in Southampton on Saturday. **The scores:** NZ 162/6 in 20 overs (Alleyne 4/27) lost to WI 163/3 in 19.5 overs (Campbelle 90 n.o.). **Toss:** WI. **PoM:** Campbelle.

MOMENT TO SAVOUR

Qatar strikes in injury time to hold Switzerland, bags first WC point

REUTERS

Qatar's Boualem Khoukhi stunned Switzerland by playing a major role in the late equaliser (90+4) as the sides drew 1-1 in their World Cup Group B clash in Santa Clara on Saturday. The leveller initially appeared to come via a Khoukhi header but it was later determined to be an own goal by Swiss midfielder Miro Muheim.

THE DIFFERENCE

McGinn's first-half goal propels Scotland to victory over Haiti

REUTERS

John McGinn's shot deflected off an opposing defender and went past goalkeeper Johny Placide as Scotland defeated Haiti 1-0 in a World Cup Group C encounter in Foxborough on Saturday. Scotland, making its first appearance in the global tournament since 1998, earned its first World Cup victory since 1990.

Smriti, Deepti combine to power India past Pakistan

Game-changing spell: Deepti, right, returned career-best figures of five for 10. GETTY IMAGES

T20 WORLD CUP

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BIRMINGHAM

Richa Ghosh could breathe life into the death overs the way few women do.

Her explosive batting is something India depends heavily on. It is crucial to the the team's fortunes in the T20 World Cup.

In front of a big, noisy, colourful, crowd, made up largely of Asian origin, on a sunny afternoon at Edgbaston, Richa came out to bat when India desperately wanted her to fire. She did.

Her magnificent onslaught (34, 17b, 5x4, 1x6) turned India's score from a potentially competitive one into a winning total against Pakistan. The less resourceful of the Asian neighbours was always going to find the target of 171 daunting.

So it proved. The Women in Blue won by 64 runs, to start their campaign on a satisfactory note.

In the Group of Death, in which they have to face Australia and South Africa, they could not have afforded a hiccup in the opening match. But, the innings had wobbled, and the PowerPlay belonged to Pakistan.

It required all the skills and experience of India's most accomplished batters, vice-captain Smriti Mandhana (68, 44b, 9x4, 2x6) and captain Harmanpreet Kaur (36, 35b, 4x4) to steady the ship, and to set the stage for Richa. The innings had begun in rousing fashion though, with Shafali Verma hitting the first ball for six, as she effortlessly lofted Sadia Iqbal over long-off.

The left-arm spinner, however, had her revenge in the same over. Shafali backed away to produce a faint edge, which was smartly taken behind the stumps by Muneeba Ali. Before long, Jemimah Rodrigues played too early against Tasmia Rubab, skying one to extra cover, where Natalia Pervaiz fumbled but completed the catch on her second attempt, and threw ball down hard to the ground, as if admonishing it for causing her, and teammates, a few anxious seconds.

The Indian dugout must have now felt a bit worried. But Smriti, who had come to the tournament in not-so great touch, and Harmanpreet calmed those nerves. They knew they needed to bat deep on a surface that wasn't quite a belter, against an attack that was testing.

The duo put on 91 for the third wicket. Smriti, who was dropped on a couple of occasions, may not have been at her very best, though she did play some of those lovely shots you have grown accustomed to.

Smriti's dismissal triggered a collapse though, as India slid from 109 for two to 123 for five. At this stage, Pakistan may have sensed an opportunity. But Richa and Deepti Sharma took 23 off Tasmia in the 19th over.

In reply, Pakistan began well, with Muneeba (41, 35b, 5x4) and Gull Feroza adding 38 for the opening wicket.

That would prove by far the biggest partnership of the innings as India bowled and fielded with vigour, not even allowing its familiar rival any hope.

Deepti finished with exemplary figures of five for 10.

Smart ploy: Smriti counterattacked after the early fall of Shafali and Jemimah. GETTY IMAGES

SCOREBOARD

INDIA

Shafali Verma c Muneeba b Sadia 6 *(5b, 1x6)*, Smriti Mandhana c Fatima b Rameen 68 *(44b, 9x4, 2x6)*, Jemimah Rodrigues c Natalia b Tasmia 1 *(7b)*, Harmanpreet Kaur c Natalia b Fatima 36 *(35b, 4x4)*, Bharti Fulmali st. Muneeba b Sadia 1 *(3b)*, Richa Ghosh b Fatima 34 *(17b, 5x4, 1x6)*, Deepti Sharma (not out) 12 *(9b, 1x4)*, Shreyanka Patil (not out) 1 *(1b)*; Extras (nb-1, w-10): 11; Total (for six wkts. in 20 overs): 170.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-6 (Shafali, 0.5 overs), 2-18 (Jemimah, 3.2), 3-109 (Smriti, 13.5), 4-110 (Bharti, 14.2), 5-123 (Harmanpreet, 16.2), 6-168 (Richa, 19.5).

PAKISTAN BOWLING

Sadia 4-0-41-2, Fatima 4-0-33-2, Tasmia 4-0-41-1, Rameen 4-0-30-1, Nashra 4-0-25-0.

PAKISTAN

Muneeba Ali run out 41 *(35b, 5x4)*, Gull Feroza c Bharti b Deepti 12 *(9b, 2x4)*, Ayesha Zafar c Smriti b Deepti 12 *(8b, 2x4)*, Saira Jabeen c Harmanpreet b Shree Charani 2 *(3b)*, Natalia Pervaiz c Harmanpreet b Shree Charani 7 *(13b)*, Fatima Sana c Smriti b Shafali 0 *(3b)*, Aliya Riaz c Jemimah b Deepti 18 *(17b, 1x4)*, Rameen Shamim c Shreyanka b Shree Charani 4 *(6b)*, Nashra Sandhu c Harmanpreet b Deepti 4 *(5b)*, Tasmia Rubab c Jemimah b Deepti 0 *(2b)*, Sadia Iqbal (not out) 1 *(1b)*; Extras (lb-1, w-4): 5; Total (in 17 overs): 106.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-38 (Feroza, 4.5), 2-53 (Ayesha, 6.3), 3-58 (Saira, 7.4), 4-75 (Muneeba, 10.5), 5-77 (Fatima, 11.3), 6-79 (Natalia, 12.1), 7-91 (Rameen, 14.4), 8-105 (Aliya, 16.2), 9-105 (Tasmia, 16.4).

INDIA BOWLING

Arundhati 2-0-21-0, Shreyanka 3-0-17-0, Kranti 1-0-14-0, Deepti 4-0-10-5, Shree Charani 4-0-21-3, Shafali 3-0-22-1.

Toss: India.

Player-of-the-Match: Deepti.

India won by 64 runs.

India's next match: June 17 vs. Netherlands, Leeds, 7 p.m. IST.

Brazil, Morocco play out entertaining stalemate

Vinicius' individual brilliance helps the Selecao restore parity after Saibari puts the Atlas Lions ahead; a point against one of the favourites is another sign of the African team's growing stature

FIFA WORLD CUP

Ayon Sengupta
NEW JERSEY

The final sentence of F. Scott Fitzgerald's *The Great Gatsby* reads: "So we beat on, boats against the current, borne back ceaselessly into the past."

Few football nations understand the struggle of moving forward while being anchored to the past better than Brazil.

Morocco arrived with no such burden, but with the momentum of a generation determined to push beyond the boundaries it has already broken down.

In East Rutherford, history and possibility shared the same pitch, and neither could find a way past the other.

Brazil's last World Cup match on American soil was a famous one – victory in the 1994 final, where the side overcame Italy, which had Selecao's current coach, Carlo Ancelotti, as its assistant manager, on penalties.

Here, in the early evening heat, the sea of canary yellow vastly outnumbered the red of Morocco in the stands as members of the Brazilian diaspora from across the tri-state area turned up in large numbers.

But the Moroccans lost little time in silencing the partisan crowd, pushing Brazil back with Achraf Hakimi and Brahim Diaz combining effectively down the right flank.

The breakthrough duly came in the 21st minute as Ismael Saibari nonchalantly lifted the ball over an onrushing Alisson Becker, having outpaced a chasing Gabriel after Diaz threaded a measured through ball into his stride.

Yet, minutes after the hydration break, a moment of individual brilliance from Vinicius Junior restored parity and brought life back to the Brazilian fans. The Real Madrid attacker played a one-two with Bruno Guimaraes near the left touchline before dropping his shoulder to whip in a curling right-footer into the top-right corner to make it 1-1.

The equaliser shifted the momentum. In the first minute of stoppage time, Morocco goalkeeper Yassine Bounou had to produce an acrobatic reflex save to keep out Lucas Paqueta's sumptuous side volley that was arrowing towards the bottom corner.

As the second half progressed, Morocco retreated into a considerably deeper defensive block, inviting Brazil forward while looking to strike on the counter.

That approach nearly paid off with 15 minutes remaining as the Atlas Lions carved out two openings in quick succession, first down the left and then from the right. Brazil's defence, however, stood firm on both occasions.

An errant back pass from Noussair Mazraoui then almost gifted Raphinha a clear run on goal, but Bounou was quick to sense the danger and raced off his line to snuff out the chance. At the other end, Neil El Aynaoui forced Alisson into a diving save to his left, and the Liverpool goalkeeper was nimble enough to push away the follow-up from Amaimouni-Echghouyab for a corner-kick.

Neither side could find the decisive breakthrough. But for Morocco, a point against one of the tournament favourites was another sign of the team's growing stature. For Brazil, the search for a future worthy of its past goes on.

Showing the way: Vinicius drills in Brazil's equaliser past the Moroccan defence. GETTY IMAGES

Australia's gamble pays off in the win over Turkiye

Agencies
VANCOUVER

Australia recorded a stunning 2-0 victory over Turkiye in its World Cup Group D opener on Saturday as coach Tony Popovic's bold selection gamble paid off.

Nestory Irankunda and Connor Metcalfe scored the goals while rookie goalkeeper Patrick Beach produced a string of crucial saves. Australia head coach Popovic had pulled off a massive shock in his starting line-up, dropping captain Mathew Ryan in favour of Beach, who won only his third cap. Vice-captain Jackson Irvine was dropped in favour of midfielder Paul Okon-Engstler in a starting XI that featured 10 WC debutants.

THE RESULTS

Group B: Qatar 1 (Muheim 90+4-og) drew with Switzerland 1 (Embolo 17-pen). **Group C:** Brazil 1 (Vinicius Jr. 32) drew with Morocco 1 (Saibari 21); Haiti 0 lost to Scotland 1 (McGinn 28). **Group D:** Australia 2 (Irankunda 27, Metclafe 75) bt Turkiye 0. **Group E:** Germany 7 (Nmecha 6, Schlotterbeck 38, Havertz 45+5-pen, 88, Musiala 47, Brown 68, Undav 78) bt Curacao 1 (Comenencia 21).

Tuesday's Matches

GROUP G

Belgium vs. Egypt, 00.30 a.m.

Iran vs. New Zealand, 6.30 a.m.

GROUP H

Saudi Arabia vs. Uruguay, 3.30 a.m.

The day and time(s) pertain to India

Stat attack

0 Morocco's winless streak in its opening game of a World Cup continues (four draws and three defeats)

1 In its fourth World Cup game, Qatar earned its first point

4 Brazil has drawn its first match for the fourth time. The last three times it did so (1974, 1978 and 2018), it didn't reach the final

4 Vinicius has scored four times for Brazil in 11 games under Ancelotti. He scored only six in 39 appearances before that

6 Only Shaqiri (10) has more goals for Switzerland at major tournaments than Embolo

6 This is the sixth time Brazil has failed to win its opening contest (23 appearances) at the World Cup

8 Beach has become the goalkeeper with most saves in a World Cup match for Australia

21 Brazil is now unbeaten in opening matches at 21 editions (since 1934)

28 McGinn has become the first Scot to score a World Cup goal since Craig Burley (vs. Norway) in 1998

31y 238d McGinn is Scotland's oldest goalscorer in the tournament

36 Scotland has recorded its first win at a World Cup since 1990 (vs. Sweden)

44 The number of fouls in the Scotland-Haiti match, the most in a group stage match after 2010 (45, Chile vs. Switzerland)

93:59 Muheim's own-goal to bring Qatar level is the fourth-latest equaliser in the World Cup

Compiled by **ANIRUDH VELAMURI**

20y 124d
IRANKUNDA is the youngest Australian to score in the football showpiece, and the youngest for a team representing the Asian Football Confederation

In seventh heaven: Havertz provides the finishing touch. REUTERS

Germany puts seven past hapless Curacao

Agencies
HOUSTON

Germany thrashed World Cup debutant Curacao 7-1 in its first Group E contest at the Houston Stadium here on Sunday.

Kai Havertz netted a brace while Felix Nmecha, Nico Schlotterbeck, Jamal Musiala, Nathaniel Brown and Deniz Undav were also on the scoresheet. It was Germany's first opening-match win at a World Cup since its successful 2014 campaign in Brazil.

Livano Comenencia had briefly cancelled out Nmecha's opener for Curacao's maiden goal at the global tournament.

Comenencia tied the score with his left-footed shot through traffic in the centre of the box.

But Germany regained the lead via Schlotterbeck's header off Brown's corner-kick. Havertz converted a penalty in first-half stoppage time to make it 3-1.

Germany was awarded the spot-kick after Nmecha was tripped by Riechedly Bazoer. A majority of the crowd was rooting for Germany but there was a spirited contingent of fans cheering on Curacao as it tried to battle it out.

INBRIEF

Brunson sizzles as Knicks end a 53-year drought

The New York Knicks, fuelled by a sensational 45 points from the Finals MVP Jalen Brunson, rallied again to beat the San Antonio Spurs 94-90 and win its first NBA title in 53 years on Saturday.

Connolly helps Australia avoid clean sweep

Opener Cooper Connolly blazed 149 runs off 134 balls to lead Australia to a dramatic one-wicket victory over Bangladesh in the third and final one-dayer in Mirpur on Sunday.

The scores: Bangladesh 274/5 in 50 overs (Hridoy 83, Litton 58) lost to Australia 277/9 in 49.3 overs (Connolly 149, Shoriful 6/48). **Toss:** Bangladesh; **PoM:** Connolly; **PoS:** Mosaddek.

Shanaka, Hasaranga shine as Sri Lanka levels T20I series

Sri Lanka levelled the three-match Twenty20I series with a 37-run win over the West Indies in the second game at Kingston on Saturday.

The scores: Sri Lanka 194/6 in 20 overs (Mishara 61 n.o. Shanaka 58, Shamar 3/32) bt West Indies 157 in 18.1 overs (Powell 43, Chameera 3/9, Hasaranga 3/38). **Toss:** West Indies. **PoM:** Dasun Shanaka.

Parul betters own 5000m record to finish second

Parul Chaudhary bettered her own National record in the women's 5000m, clocking a new personal best of 15:04.26s to finish second at the Meeting Nikaia 2026 in Nice, France. She finished behind Ethiopia's Bereka Seniya Mohammed (15:03.85). Parul also breached the Asian Games 2026 qualifying standard of 15:36.58s.

Tiruvallur records 146-run victory over Namakkal

Tiruvallur defeated Namakkal by 146 runs in a Zone-D first-round match of the TNCA inter-district women's tournament at Salem on Sunday.

The scores (first round): Zone-D (Salem): Tiruvallur 224/7 in 50 overs (B.M. Shrinidhi 90, K. Aasitha 66, Darshana 3/47) bt Namakkal 78 in 32.5 overs (S.G. Shrinithi 34, B. Hasini 3/3). **Zone-E (Chengalpattu):** Chengalpattu 167 in 48 overs (S. Gowri Lakshmi 30, P. Suji 33) bt Tiruchi 96 in 37.4 overs (S. Lithisha 4/13).

LIVE TELECAST

FIFA World Cup: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 7.30, 9.30 a.m., 12.30, 3.30 & 6.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Tri-series: Sri Lanka-A vs India-A: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10 a.m.

Ashwin released as teams announce retention lists

Vijay Shankar and Aparajith not to feature in the forthcoming edition; Washington, Jagadeesan, Varun and Shahrukh among the notable players retained by their respective sides

TNPL 2026

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Former India players R. Ashwin and Vijay Shankar, along with leg-spinner M. Ashwin, have been released by their respective franchises ahead of the TNPL 2026 auction after becoming ineligible to participate in the tournament.

R. Ashwin, who captained Dindigul Dragons, recently signed for the San Francisco Unicorns in Major League Cricket (MLC), while Chepauk Super Gillies' Vijay Shankar is set to turn out for the Kandy Royals in the Lanka Premier League (LPL) after retiring from Indian domestic cricket and the IPL. M. Ashwin, who also announced his retirement from domestic and IPL cricket, has been released by Siechem Madurai Panthers.

TNCA secretary U. Bhagwandas Rao clarified that players who have retired from BCCI-affiliated cricket are not eligible for the TNPL. "The franchise owners were already informed that they will not be eligible for the auction. Basically, whoever has retired from BCCI – retired from all things under BCCI – is not eligible," he said. Super Gillies also released former captain B. Aparajith after the batter informed the franchise that he was not looking to play in the upcoming season.

Dragons keep Indrajith

Among the notable retentions, Trichy Grand Cholas has retained India all-rounder Washington Sundar, while Super Gillies has held on to wicketkeeper-batter N. Jagadeesan. Dindigul Dragons retained Varun Chakaravarthy, Sandeep Warrier, and B. Indrajith, while Lyca Kovai Kings kept faith in M. Shahrukh Khan, B. Sai Sudharsan, M. Siddharth, and R.S. Ambrish.

iDream Tiruppur Tamizhans retained captain R. Sai Kishore and India pacer T. Natarajan, while Madurai Panthers kept pacer Gurjapneet Singh. Nellai Royal Kings, meanwhile, released veteran wicketkeeper-batter K.B. Arun Karthick.

The churn in the TNPL

A look at the players who were retained and released from the eight franchises

CHEPAUK SUPER GILLIES

Retained	Released
Abhishek Tanwar	B. Aparajith
Swapnil Singh	Vijay Shankar
N. Jagadeesan	R. Kirubakar
R.S. Mokit Hariharan	M. Akram Khan
T.D. Lokesh Raj	S. Rohith Suthar
M. Silambarasan	R. Aushik Srinivas
K. Aashiq	B. Sachin
J. Prem Kumar	R. Rajan
S. Dinesh Raj	Arjun P. Moorthy
G. Rajalingam	
N. Sunil Krishna	

DINDIGUL DRAGONS

Retained	Released
Varun Chakaravarthy	R. Ashwin
Hunny Saini	G. Periyasamy
Sandeep Warrier	Maan K. Bafna
B. Indrajith	D.T. Chandrasekar
R. Vimal Khumar	N. Aakaash Sharma
Shivam Singh	V. Bhuvaneshwar
R.K. Jayant	
H. Dinesh	
M. Karthik Saran	
Athul Maruthi Vikar	
M. Viju Arul	
Sasidharan	

NELLAI ROYAL KINGS

Retained	Released
R. Sonu Yadav	K.B. Arun Karthick
G. Ajitesh	Ajay K. Krishnan
Muhammed Adnan Khan	P. Nirmal Kumar
S. Rithik Easwaran	S. Vijaya Kumar
S.R. Athish	Karan Hamir Sampat
Sachin Rathi	Udayakumar
V. Yudheeswaran	
N.S. Harish	
S. Selvaganapathi	
B. Emmanuel Cherian	
D. Santhosh Kumar	
B. Rocky	
J. Rohan	
A. Arun Bala Yoghi	
S. Risheek Kumar	

TRICHY GRAND CHOLAS

Retained	Released
J. Suresh Kumar	H.I. Waseem Ahmed
P. Saravana Kumar	S. Sujay
J. Kousik	U. Mukilesh
R. Sanjay Yadav	J. Rejin
M.S. Washington Sundar	S.P. Vinod
Jafar Jamal	Arya Yohan
R. Rajkumar	
V. Athisayaraj Davidson	
K. Easwaran	
W. Antony Dhas	
M. Ganesh Moorthi	
N. Selva Kumaran	
T. Saran	

LYCA KOVAI KINGS

Retained	Released
M. Shahrukh Khan	P. Bhuvaneswaran
B. Sai Sudharsan	K. Vishal Vaidhya
S. Lokeshwar	R. Rohit
C. Andre Siddarth	S. Guru Raghavendran
M. Siddharth	L. Pradheep Vishal
R.S. Ambrish	N. Kabilan
B. Sachin	K.T.A. Madhava Prasad
Jhathavedh Subramanyan	B. Aaditya
G. Govinth	C.H. Jitendra Kumar
R. Divakar	
P. Vidyuth	

IDREAM TIRUPPUR TAMIZHANS

Retained	Released
R. Sai Kishore	Daryl S. Ferrario
T. Natarajan	B. Surya
R. Silambarasan	K. Rajkumar
Tushar Raheja	S. Radhakrishnan
S. Mohamed Ali	K. Kanibalan
Pradosh Ranjan Paul	S. Prabanjan
U. Sasidev	
R.D. Pranav Raghavendra	
V.P. Amith Sathvik	
S. Mohan Prasath	
C.V. Achyuth	
M. Mathivanan	
A. Esakkimuthu	
V. Anovankar	

SIECHEM MADURAI PANTHERS

Retained	Released
M. Karthik	M. Ashwin
M.A. Atheeq Ur Rahman	K. Gowtham Thamarai Kannan
B. Anirudh Sita Ram	C. Sarath Kumar
Gurjapneet Singh	S. Ganesh
D. Deepesh	V. Sanjeev Kumar
P. Vignesh	R. Ram Arvindh
P. Saravanan	M. Ayush
N.S. Chaturved	Shyam Sundar
S. Rajalingam	J. Ajay Chetan
S. Surya Anand	
S. Shankar Ganesh	

SKM SALEM SPARTANS

Retained	Released
M. Mohammed	Himalaya
C. Hari Nishaanth	J. Gowri Sankar
S. Nidhish Rajagopal	R. Kavin
Boopathi Vaishna Kumar	R. Pavithran
S. Ajith Ram	R. Alexander
M. Eshwar	
S. Abishiek	
Sunny Sandhu	
R. Vivek	
S. Harish Kumar	
M. Poiyamozhi	
Rahil Sanjay Shah	
V.S. Karthick Manikandan	
Sudhan Sanjeevi Kandeepan	
D. Rahul	
M.E. Yazh Arun Mozhi	

Neeraj likely to return to action soon

ATHLETICS

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Neeraj Chopra's long-awaited return to action is possible in the next two weeks with the Olympic champion's conditional inclusion in the Indian athletics squad for the upcoming Commonwealth Games announced on Sunday.

Neeraj will, however, have to clear the AFI's qualification mark of 82.61m to be considered.

The squad:
Men: Gurindervir Singh (100m), Animesh Kujur (200m), Gulveer Singh (5000m/10000m), Tejas Shirse (110m hurdles), Yashas P, T. Santhosh Kumar (400m hurdles), Sarvesh Kushare, Aadarsh Ram (high jump), Dev Meena, Kuldeep Kumar (pole vault), M. Sreeshankar, Lokesh Sathyanathan (long jump), Praveen Chithravel, Selva Prabhu (triple jump).

Samardeep Singh Gill, Tajinderpal Singh Toor (shot put), Neeraj Chopra, Rohit Yadav, Yashvir Singh (javelin), Tejaswin Shankar (decathlon/high jump), Vishal TK, Rajesh Ramesh (400m/4x400m).

Women: Parul Chaudhary (3000m steeplechase/5000m), Pooja (high jump), Manpreet Kaur (shot put), Seema, Nidhi Rani (discus), Ravina, Priiyanka (10000m walk), Ansa Babu, Rashdeep Kaur, Neeru Pathak (4 x 400m).

Four juniors make it to World U-20 c'ships

M.R. Praveen Chandran
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Four junior athletes achieved the qualifying mark for the World U-20 championships at the Indian Athletics Series-10 at the LNCPE Stadium here on Sunday.

In the 800m, Tamil Nadu's Unwin Anand Ananthan clocked a personal best of 1:49.93s to breach the qualifying mark of 1:51.00, Asian under-20 champion Pooja won the women's high jump with 1.81m (qualifying mark 1.80m), K. Ambriesh cleared 2.12m (target 2.09m) in the boys' high jump and Tanu Chaudhary's personal best of 59.15s in junior girls 400m hurdles bettered the the qualification mark of 1:00.75s.

The results (winners only):
Men: 100m: A: I. Gitson (TN) (10.51s), **B:** Jammula Bhanu Srinivas (AP) (10.88), **C:** Halvi S. Vij (Ker) (10.85), **D:** S. Sam Vasanth (TN) (10.60s).
200m: A: Nithin Arunan (TN) (21.76), **B:** Sethu Mishra (Bih) (21.86), **C:** Dharmveer Choudhary (Raj) (20.82). **400m: A:** T. Santosh Kumar (TN) (46.73), **B:** T.S. Manu (NCOE, Tvm) (46.24), **C:** A. Suraj (TN) (47.03), **D:** Mohit Kumar (NCOE, Tvm) (46.82), **E:** Theerthesh P. Shetty (Kar) (46.59).
800m: Pradeep Senthil Kumar (TN) (1:47.09). **110m hurdles: A:** Paaro Kabilan (TN) (14.43), **B:** R. Manav (Rlys) (13.85). **400m hurdles:** B. Ragul (TN) (52.66), **B:** M. Manoop (Rlys) (52.83), **C:** T. Santosh Kumar (TN) (49.91). **High Jump:** Basant (2.19m); **Long jump:** P. David (NCOE, Blg) (8.22m); **Triple jump:** Gailey Venister (TN) (16.38m).
Under-20: Boys: 100m: A: P. Chiranthi (Kar) (10.70), **B:** Mehebubul Ahamed (WB) (10.74), **C:** A. Abubacker (Kar) (10.62), **D:** R. Neil Samraj (TN) (10.59).
200m: A: Arshdeep Singh (Pun) (21.85), **B:** Rudra Shinde (Mah) (21.26).
400m: Bhavesh Rajkumar (TN) (50.07), **B:** V. Vignesh (TN) (47.88), **C:** S. Ranjith Kumar (TN) (47.26).
800m: Unwin Anand Ananthan (TN) (1: 49.93s).
3000m: Dhanush Adithya (TN) (9:03.66).
110m hurdles: A: Dhruv Milind Lawand (Mah) (14.51), **B:** Sandeep Vinodkumar (Reliance) (13.63).
400m hurdles: Sahil Raj (UP) (52.72).
High Jump: K. Ambriesh (NCOE, Bng) (2.12m); **Long jump:** Rajeev Roy (WB) (7.45m); **Triple Jump:** Daksh Bishnoi (Pun) (15.46m).
Women: 100m: A: S. Srireshma (TN) (12.15), **B:** Giridharani Ravikumar (TN) (11.61).
200m: A: Archana S. Suseendran (TN) (25.55), **B:** Sandra Mol Sabu (NCOE, Tvm) (25.61), **C:** Harita Bhadra (Reliance) (23.58).
400m: A: Jisna Mathew (Ker) (55.38), **B:** Olimba Steffi (TN) (54.02), **C:** Rashdeep Kaur (JSW) (53.32).
800m: Gowthami Jayaraman (Police) (2:08.00). **100m hurdles: A:** S. Srireshma (TN) (14.18), **B:** K. Nandhini (TN) (13.42).
400m hurdles: A: Megha (Kar) (1:00.88), **B:** R. Harshitha (TN) (1:00.53), **C:** Tanu Chaudhary (NCOE, Patiala) (59.15).
High jump: Pooja (Har) (1.81m); **Long jump:** Bhavani Yadav (NCOE, Bng) (6.61m); **Triple jump:** Aleena T. Saji (Ker) (12.87m).
Under-20: Girls: 100m: A: Divyangi (Mah) (11.88), **B:** Nipam (UP) (11.75). **200m:** Bhoomika Nehate (Mah) (25.05).
400m: A: A.K. Thiya (NCOE, Tvm) (55.02), **B:** Sehnoor Bawa (Pun) (55.38). **800m:** Davinder Kaur (Har) (2:10.35). **3000m:** M.B. Krishnendhu (Ker) (12:00.63).
100m hurdles: G. Bhavana (TN) (14.52). **400m hurdles:** Latika Dharan (TN) (1:06.39).
High jump: Anamika Ajesh (Ker) (1.45m); **Long jump:** Komal (5.62m), **Pole vault:** Jeena Basil (Ker) (3.50m).

Joshna set for record seventh Asian Games appearance

SQUASH

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Veteran squash player Joshna Chinappa has achieved a feat unmatched by any Indian, qualifying for her seventh consecutive Asian Games.

The 39-year-old sealed her place after battling past Unnati Tripathi in a gruelling five-game encounter during the selection trials at the ISTA Academy here on Sunday.

Drawn in a challenging pool featuring Rathika Seelan, Akansha Salunkhe, Unnati and Pooja Arthi, Joshna was tested by a group packed with talented younger players.

The five-time Asian Games medallist admitted the format was demanding, especially with players having to play two matches a day. "It was hard because I have never played two matches a day. It's always one match a day. I also found my draw tough. Rathika, Pooja and the others are girls I train with here. I wanted to win all my matches and am happy that I did," said Joshna.

The former World No. 10 said representing India continues to be a special feeling, irrespective of how many times she has done it. "It's always special to play for India. It's such a great feeling. I feel very blessed and it's a great opportunity for me," she said.

Joshna said India will field a formidable women's squad at the Games.

"We have a strong team this time with Anahat Singh, Tanvi Khanna and myself. The number four player will also be equally strong. I just hope that I can contribute," she said.

Apart from the team event, Joshna expressed her desire to compete in the mixed doubles at the Aichi-Nagoya Games.

More glory beckons: Joshna will strive to add her Asian Games medal collection. FILE PHOTO

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA inter-district u-19 tournament, quarterfinal, day one, Thiruvallur vs. Kanyakumari, Magna College of Arts and Science (Magaral), Chengalpattu vs Dindigul, Quaid-E-Milleth, Medavakkam, 9.30 a.m.

Margaretta wins feature

BENGALURU: P. Shroff-trained Margaretta (G. Vivek up) won the Zavaray S. Poonawalla Fillies Championship Stakes (1,600m), the first classic of the season here on Sunday (June 14). The winner is owned by Mr. Mehernosh H. Deboo & Mrs. Auzita M. Deboo. Vivek, who confidently kept her filly in handy last position till 600m, gradually improved to fourth rounding the bend, before manoeuvring his mount from the inside in the home stretch. Margaretta started galloping with giant strides in between Havoc and Starzella near the last 150m and won resolutely. Due to poor visibility and underfoot condition not conducive for racing, the Stewards of Bangalore Turf Club Ltd decided to cancel the remaining two races of the day.

1. KRANJI PLATE (2,000M): STALINGRAD (Arvind K) 1, Storm Shadow (Vishal) 2, Azalea (A. Prakash) 3 and Fils De France (Antony) 4. 2-1/4, 2-1/4 and 6. 2m, 11.21s. ₹20 (w), 12 and 11 (p), SHP: 28, THP: 27, FP: 39, Q: 20, Trinella: 57/39, Exacta: 74/48. Favourite: Stalingrad. Owner: Mr. Francis Arun Kumar. Trainer: Irfan Ghatala.

2. MALENAHALLI PLATE (1,600M): TYAARAA (Antony) 1, Sea Diamond (Md. Ashraf) 2, Agape (S. Sachin) 3 and Turkoman (Faizan Khan) 4. Not run: Michiko. Nk, 3-1/2 and Nose. 1m, 43.82s. ₹22 (w), 12, 55 and 20 (p), SHP: 195, THP: 68, FP: 565, Q: 486, Trinella: 2,624/843, Exacta: 15,655 (Carried over). Favourite: Tyaaraa. Owners: M/S. Cherie Sports Pvt Ltd & Mr. Hothur Sajjad Wahab. Trainer: Faraz Arshad.

3. TREASURE GIRL PLATE (1,100M): RAVISHING QUEEN (Suraj) 1, Garzian (G. Vivek) 2, Auspicious King (M. Rajesh K) 3 and Atman (Antony) 4. Not run: Nimbus Speed. 2-1/2, 2 and 4-3/4. 1m, 07.88s. ₹18 (w), 12, 12 and 12 (p), SHP: 27, THP: 43, FP: 37, Q: 26, Trinella: 214/79, Exacta: 365/120. Favourite: Ravishing Queen. Owners: Mr. K. Kaliyaperumal, Mr. M. Rishad, Mr. P.J. Vazifdar, Mrs. P.J. Vazifdar & Mr. S.R. Sanas'. Trainer: James Mckeown.

4. PARSIANA PLATE (1,400M): BELLAVITA (S. Sachin) 1, Aquastic (Yash) 2, Small Dreams (Akshay K) 3 and Silicon Star (A. Ramu) 4. 1-1/4, 5-1/4 and Shd. 1m, 27.16s. ₹31 (w), 17, 12 and 16 (p), SHP: 36, THP: 47, FP: 174, Q: 73, Trinella: 311/156, Exacta: 1,484/595. Favourite: Bellavita. Owner: Mr. Nirash Bothara. Trainer: Neil B. Devaney.

5. STEWARDS CUP (1,400M): CROSSWATER (Aleemuddin) 1, Elysium (Akshay K) 2, Star Studded (Darshan) 3 and Don Carlos (S. Saqlain) 4. 1/2, 1/2 and 1. 1m, 28.20s. ₹48 (w), 28 and 12 (p), SHP: 51, THP: 31, FP: 138, Q: 34, Trinella: 319/161, Exacta: 824/224. Favourite: Elysium. Owners: The Rajagiri Rubber & Produce Company Ltd rep. by Mr & Mrs. Dilip Thomas'. Trainer: Arjun Mangalorkar.

6. ZAVARAY S. POONAWALLA FILLIES CHAMPIONSHIP STAKES (1,600M): MARGARETTA (BELLARDO-IZBA) G. VIVEK 1, Havoc (Sanus Per Aquam-Athena) Suraj 2, Starzella (Leitir Mor-Thora Barber) Antony 3 and Vortex (Dreamfield-Legendofthephoenix) Akshay K 4. 2-3/4, Lnk and 3-1/2. 1m, 41.13s. ₹14 (w), 13 and 31 (p), SHP: 33, THP: 33, FP: 72, Q: 48, Trinella: 108/28, Exacta: 367/233. Favourite: Margaretta. Owners: Mr. Mehernosh H. Deboo & Mrs. Auzita M. Deboo. Trainer: P. Shroff.

Jackpot: ₹917; Mini Jackpot: 170; Treble (i): 1,249; (ii): 10.

Double delight for Dhiraj at World Cup

Terrific show: Kumkum and Dhiraj claimed the mixed team gold before the latter won the individual title. WORLD ARCHERY

ARCHERY

Sports Bureau

Asian champion B. Dhiraj underlined his class as India beat formidable Korean archers and claimed two recurve gold medals, in mixed team and individual, at the Archery World Cup Stage-3 in Antalya on Sunday.

Dhiraj joined hands with 17-year-old rookie Kumkum Mohod to topple the more accomplished Koreans, including Olympic medallist Kim Je Deok and former World youth champion Oh Yejin, 5-1 (37-36, 37-36, 39-39) in the final for the mixed team gold medal.

In an intensely fought match for individual gold, Dhiraj upset multiple World and Olympics medallist Korean Lee Woo Seok 7-3 (30-29, 29-28, 27-27, 27-29, 30-29).

Ready for the 'Counter Strike'

Sindarov is confident about his chances against World champion Gukesh and is guarding against complacency; the 20-year-old is geared up to face the Indian challenge in the upcoming Olympiad

C. Shyam Sundar

Javokhir Sindarov is the quintessential Gen-Z kid and is known to be addicted to 'Counter Strike'. With an endearing smile, the free-spirited 20-year-old is as casual as one can be as he sits down for an interaction with Indian journalists in Oslo.

The Uzbekistan GM's love for the video game sets the conversation going as responds to each question with an inimitable accent and a grin. At times, he finds it a task to come up with the right word(s) in English after saying that in his native language, he manages to continue speaking with a smile that is constant and from his heart.

Having earned the right to challenge D. Gukesh for the title of world champion with a stupendous performance in the Candidates tournament held recently, Sindarov is quietly confident of his prospects but isn't underestimating his opponent by any means.

A prodigy who was taught the game by his grandfather when he was just four-and-a-half, he caught the attention with his impressive play in the age-group categories and titles at the global level, competing against the best.

As questions about his World championship match opponent crop up, especially about the contrasting personalities, Sindarov gets candid about how he would go about it. While Gukesh is as intense as one could get, the young Uzbek GM appears a free-spirited person, so rare for a chess player.

Despite the criticism that the World champion from India has been receiving in recent times, especially from past players, Sindarov isn't ready to be lulled into any sense of hope that he would go in as the favourite given his sizzling form.

"I feel he is a very smart player and is extremely strong," he said, expecting a close contest for the championship.

While Gukesh is said to have set the ball rolling with regard to preparations, lining up seconds and cutting down on tournament play to focus on the big match, Sindarov is bracing up and expects to step up in the days to come with his events lined up along the way.

"From next month I'll start my preparations, but right now I need to focus on the Olympiad. My team is already working on the World Championship," he said.

The title match will be a different kettle of fish for the Uzbek as he has never featured in a match of such a duration (14 games of classical and tie-break if needed to decide the winner), but he said he would be ready for it.

Sindarov has been in unbelievably good form, first winning the World Cup in Goa in 2025 before running away with the Candidates title earlier this year. But the Uzbek Grandmaster is hungry for more

"I know I'm very close (to winning it). Gukesh also has the same chance(s). It will be a very good match."

Sindarov has been in unbelievably good form, first winning the World Cup in Goa in 2025 before running away with the Candidates title earlier this year.

He has set his sights on winning the gold in the Olympiad later this year at home (in Samarkand) and said the biggest challenge would come from India (defending champion in Open and women), the USA and probably China.

He seems to be someone who doesn't want to be buried under the burden of expectations and said that he's doing things his way.

"I don't know about other chess players, I think maybe they're spending their time... I know Hans (Niemann), he loves to play tennis, puzzle. There are other players who love to play poker. But I really like to play Counter Strike," he said, explaining his love for the game.

Sindarov said he ended up spending a lot of time playing it even during the World Cup in Goa.

He brushed aside talk that he wasn't working too hard on his game and said, "I work 10 hours in one day, like probably in one year it should be more than 80-90 days...and we've really worked a lot on chess and the results are coming.

"I want to be a very strong chess player, and if I keep working in this system of putting in long hours, I believe I can become one of the strongest players in the world. There is a dream," he said with loads of optimism and playing down talk that he had lost some motivation after becoming a GM.

He also recalled the camp with his coach (Roman Vidonyak) in Munich some time ago, which proved very beneficial and during which a lot of hard work was put in.

Asked whether more intensive training from a younger age could have already made him the world champion, Sindarov reflected on his development and potential.

"I feel when I was young, if I trained a lot, I would be world champion. I know I have big potential because, in my opinion, I have very good talent for the game, and even when I didn't train much," he said.

"It was very hard to find a good person who can teach me, and when I started working with Roman, I feel I really improved my chess."

The young Uzbek star said he preferred to work more on the board rather than on the computer like the World No.1 Magnus Carlsen.

For someone who was taught chess by his grandfather to keep him away from sneaking away to play games on the computer, sometimes till 4 or 5 a.m, Sindarov recalled that he showed his talent at a young age and won the Uzbekistan under-10 championship which also saw Nodirbek Abdusattorov, who was by then the World under-8 champion, also compete. He said it was a good game with Abdusattorov, which ended in a draw.

"When I started to play chess, I wanted to become like Magnus Carlsen, the world champion," he said of his ambitions.

Speaking about Uzbekistan's rise in global chess which saw the nation win the gold medal in the Olympiad in 2022 at Mamallapuram near Chennai, he said there were strong players including Abdusattorov and himself apart from others.

"We have good talent in Uzbekistan... Absusattorov, me... There are some others too."

He was amazed with the talent in India and said five-time World champion Viswanathan Anand sparked the chess boom. Gukesh, R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi and others were huge talents.

"In my opinion, when Vishy became a world champion it probably made chess popular and more players took it up. Gukesh, Pragg, Arjun... they are the new generation and they are amazing talents," he added.

Did he consider himself the best player in Uzbekistan currently, he said rather modestly that there was Nodirbek (Abdusattorov)...

Sindarov, who would be playing in the Sinquefield Cup in the USA, said he would be following the FIFA World Cup where he would be watching a few of his national team's games at the venues.

The Olympiad later this year would be a huge tournament for the Uzbekistan players after which he would turn his attention to the world title match, the venue for which hasn't been decided yet.

He seemed to express a desire to play in Cyprus, where he cruised to victory in the Candidates in which he didn't lose a game.

Answering a query on conditions, he noted: "Actually, for me, in general, I want to play in a hot country. Winter is a little bit uncomfortable for me. But I'm not a chess player who needs very comfortable conditions, because I grew up in all kinds of conditions.

"So for me, it doesn't matter where I play. Just a nice food centre -- that would be the best thing to have in a match. I will be very happy to play somewhere like Cyprus."

As the conversation veers towards Bibisara Assaubayeva, the Kazakhstan player, who won the women's event in Norway Chess 2026, with whom he is in a relationship.

"We know each other from our youth, so we grew up together, and we help each other a lot in tournaments. She helps me a lot, and I hope I also help her a lot. We have very good memories...but I don't like to tell everything,' Sindarov said blushing.

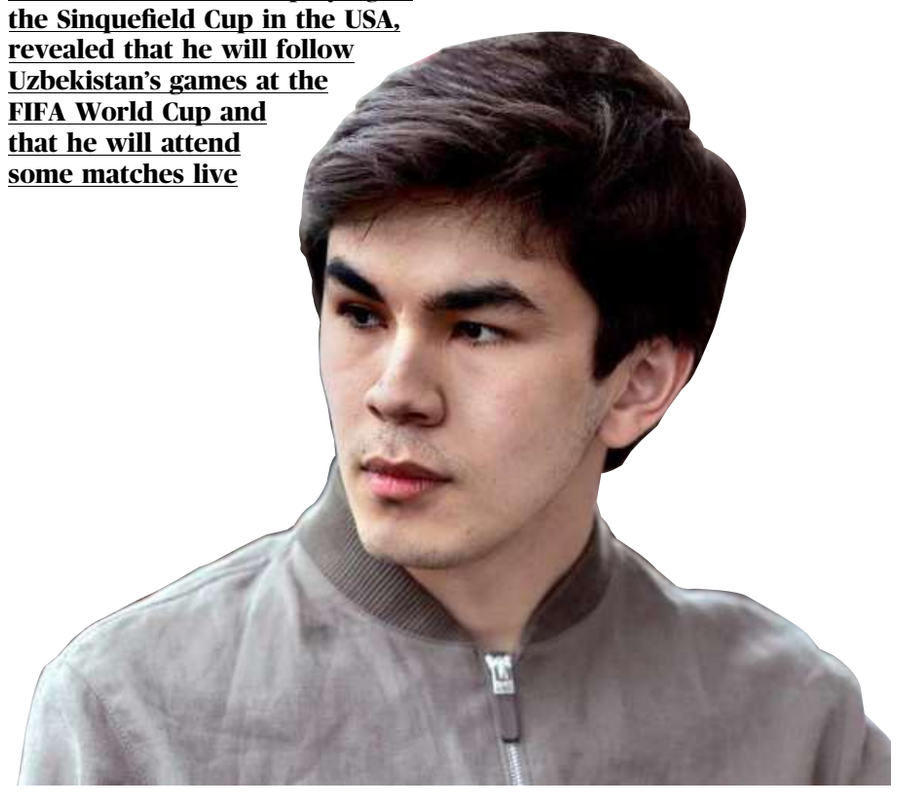
The Uzbek loves 'Counter Strike' and his over-the-board counter-strikes could decide which way fortunes would go in the title match against Gukesh, scheduled to begin on November 23.

(The writer was in Oslo at the invitation of Norway Chess).

THE GIST

- Having been taught to play chess by his grandfather when he was just four-and-a-half, Sindarov caught the attention with his impressive play in age-group categories and titles at the global level
- Despite the criticism that Gukesh has been receiving in recent times, Sindarov isn't ready to be lulled into any sense of hope that he would go in as the favourite
- The Uzbek loves 'Counter Strike', and his counter-strikes could decide which way fortunes go in the title match

Sindarov, who will be playing in the Sinquefield Cup in the USA, revealed that he will follow Uzbekistan's games at the FIFA World Cup and that he will attend some matches live



Deaths in Brazil raise concerns about India's dengue vaccine, DengiAll

Brazilian authorities have stressed that the 42 cases of severe adverse events represent only 0.008% of half-a-million vaccinated; there is no doubt that it is a small risk at the population level; however, at the individual level even one life lost to a severe adverse event is one too many

S. Swaminathan

The recent deaths of two people in Brazil during its dengue vaccination campaign, leading to the shot's suspension on June 8, is a crucial wake-up call for India. This is because the dengue vaccine in Brazil, Butantan-DV, is pretty similar, if not identical, to India's upcoming dengue vaccine, DengiAll.

Both vaccines were several years in the making. Both have live but weakened (attenuated) versions of the dengue viruses (DENVs). And both vaccines are said to be tetravalent because each vaccine is a physical mixture of four live, weakened DENVs.

DENVs come in four versions called serotypes: DENV-1, -2, -3 and -4. All four serotypes are known to be prevalent in Brazil and India. Each DENV serotype has an outer shell adorned with specialised envelope proteins, called E proteins – akin to the spike protein of coronaviruses. Even though the four DENV serotypes are very similar, their E proteins are different enough to warrant immunisation against each of the four serotypes.

When weakened DENV is used in a vaccine, it will prompt two broad types of antibodies: type-specific antibodies and cross-reactive antibodies. Type-specific antibodies are often made in small amounts and recognise only one particular serotype (based on its E proteins) and excel at blocking infections by that serotype alone.

On the other hand, the cross-reactive antibodies are made usually in large amounts and can recognise any of the four serotypes and block an infection – provided they are present at adequate levels. When their levels drop, the cross-reactive antibodies don't just fail to block a new DENV infection: they enhance it, leading to a severe and potentially fatal form of dengue. This phenomenon is called antibody-dependent enhancement (ADE).

The risk of ADE during dengue vaccination is considered a serious adverse event. If untreated, it can lead to death.

In Brazil's dengue vaccination campaign, of 42 vaccine recipients who displayed serious side-effects, two people died and one had to receive intensive care. These side-effects included severe abdominal pain, persistent vomiting, and bleeding, none of which the phase 3 clinical trials revealed. These signs are reminiscent of the symptoms of severe dengue. Medical researchers should look into whether this could be due to ADE. They should also clarify if DengiAll will manifest a similar risk when it is rolled out in India.

Butantan-DV and DengiAll are both based on a technology developed at the U.S. National Institutes of Health (NIH). Over many years, scientists weakened each DENV serotype to make monovalent vaccines, assessed each one for its capacity to induce an immune response without causing disease, and finally mixed all four monovalent vaccine viruses to generate tetravalent vaccines. Two of them, called TV003 and TV005, and the monovalent vaccine viruses were licensed to Instituto Butantan in Brazil and Panacea Biotec in India, among others, for further development.

Butantan-DV is not the first dengue vaccine to be linked to such events. A little over a decade ago, Sanofi Pasteur developed the first tetravalent dengue vaccine to be licensed. It differed from the NIH's vaccines because the four weakened serotypes were hybrid viruses, each covered on its surface with the E protein of one of the DENV serotypes (plus another protein).

This shot, called Dengvaxia, was given to more than 8 lakh children in the Phillipines, a dengue-endemic country like Brazil and India. Severe adverse events occurred three years after vaccination.

Further study revealed Dengvaxia worked like a monovalent vaccine, provoking antibodies to only DENV-4. That is, mixing four live yet weakened viruses didn't automatically ensure tetravalent immunity. There is no clear answer why.

The severe adverse events linked to Butantan-DV thus raise many questions. Is Butantan-DV really functionally tetravalent? Is there a possibility of viral interference compromising its functionality? Could ADE be responsible for the deaths?

Once DengiAll is launched, the regulator must implement a robust pharmacovigilance programme for an extended duration to check for viruses, antibodies, and other parameters

There was also a lacuna in the vaccine efficacy data collected in the phase 3 trials. Reports in January 2024, November 2024, and March 2026 indicated that Butantan-DV's efficacy against DENV-3 and DENV-4 is unknown as these serotypes were not prevalent in Brazil at the time of the trials.

Panacea Biotec's DengiAll phase 3 trials, together with the Indian Council of Medical Research, completed its enrollment target of 10,335 healthy volunteers in January this year. The trial began in August 2024; its participants will be followed for two years post-vaccination. Once all the data have been analysed, the company will approach the drug regulator for market approval.

There is no solid reason to deny that DengiAll may not face the potentially fatal issues that have come up with Butantan-DV. However, India can take some proactive actions ahead of DengiAll's rollout. First, Panacea must analyse a representative subset of sera from vaccinated volunteers for type-specific antibodies against all four serotypes. And the regulator must ensure such data are available and rules out the risk of ADE.

Next, once DengiAll is launched, the regulator must implement a robust pharmacovigilance programme for an extended duration. Vaccine recipients must be clinically monitored periodically and their blood must be collected at regular intervals to check for viruses, antibodies, and other parameters to implement remedial measures quickly. Continuous real-world monitoring is key to identifying rare or long-term adverse events.

The ADE concerns also apply to another tetravalent dengue vaccine, Qdenga, which is also a physical mix of four weakened versions of the DENV serotypes. Japan-based Takeda markets it and its India approval is imminent.

Brazilian authorities have stressed that the 42 cases of severe adverse events out of half-a-million vaccinated represent only 0.008%. There is no doubt it is a small risk at the population level. At the individual level, however, even one life lost to a severe adverse event is one too many.

(S. Swaminathan is retired professor of biology from BITS Pilani-Hyderabad and a former scientist in the area of dengue vaccinology at ICGEB, New Delhi. ssn225@gmail.com)

This photograph taken on January 29 shows chief scientific officer Syed Khalid Ali explaining the development of the DengiAll vaccine's clinical sample at Panacea Biotec, a pharmaceutical company in New Delhi. AFP

THE GIST

- The dengue vaccine in Brazil, Butantan-DV, is pretty similar, if not identical, to India's upcoming dengue vaccine, DengiAll. Both have live but weakened versions of the dengue viruses (DENVs)
- Both vaccines are said to be tetravalent because each vaccine is a physical mixture of four live, weakened DENVs
- In Brazil's dengue vaccination campaign, of 42 vaccine recipients who displayed serious side-effects, two people died and one had to receive intensive care
- Medical researchers should look into whether this could be due to antibody-dependent enhancement. They should also clarify if DengiAll will manifest a similar risk when it is rolled out in India

BIG SHOT

This aerial view shows people running through a burned forest during the so called "ash trail" in Bages, southwest France, on June 14. The trail, organised by three students from Narbonne and known as the 'Trail des Cendres', takes place to pay tribute to the area devastated by wildfires last summer. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

The giant world of fungi

Vasudevan Mukunth

A new study published in *Science* has reported the first global map of the earth's vast underground network of arbuscular mycorrhizal (AM) fungi.

These fungi have sustained plant life for millions of years but their scale and distribution has been largely invisible until now.

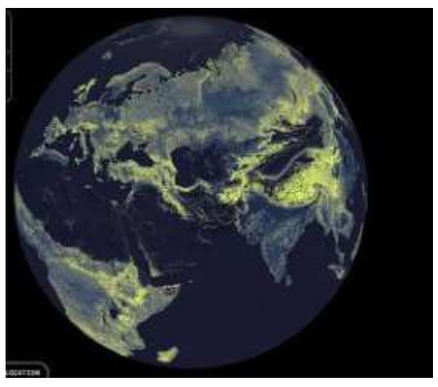
Using machine learning and data from more than 16,000 soil cores, an international research team has revealed that topsoils around the world contain some 110 quadrillion km of fungal hyphae — a distance equal to nearly a billion trips from the earth to the sun.

The AM networks also weigh around 300 million tonnes of carbon, which is four- to six-times the weight of the entire human population.

By forming symbiotic relationships with 70% of plant species, trading nutrients for carbon, the AM networks sequester an estimated 4 billion tonnes of CO_2-equivalent a year, or roughly 11% of all human-related carbon emissions.

The study also identified biodiversity hotspots and threats to them. Grassland ecosystems like those in South Sudan, the Tibetan plateau, and India's Banni grasslands house 40% of the world's AM fungal networks. However, the study warned that cropland typically has a 50% lower fungal density relative to wild ecosystems, and because grasslands are being converted to farms four-times faster than forests, these ecosystems are at extreme risk.

By quantifying the extent of this "living infrastructure", as the Society for the Protection of Underground Networks put it, the work hopes to move fungi from the periphery of environmental policy to the centre of climate action.



A global map of the density of AM fungi. TRUTH & BEAUTY/MORITZ STEFANER JUSTIN STEWART, SPUN

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

South Lebanon villages issued evacuation order

29 The Israeli military on Sunday issued evacuation warnings for residents of 29 villages in southern Lebanon ahead of planned strikes. The military's Arabic-language spokesman, Colonel Avichay Adraee, issued two successive warnings — first for 13 villages, then for 16 more, with the second targeting communities north of the Zahrani river. AFP

Number of years since last Maharashtra Road Safety Council meet

3 Maharashtra has not convened its statutory State Road Safety Council meeting in over three years, despite reporting over one lakh accidents and more than 50,000 deaths during the period, as per officials. The last meeting was held on April 4, 2023. Since then, over 38 months have passed without a single meeting, even though the rules mandate that it meet at least once in six months. PTI

Wells mobilised to aid local residents in Maharashtra

151 The Latur district administration has deployed three tankers and acquired 151 wells to supply water to residents facing scarcity during the peak summer here in Maharashtra, officials said on Sunday. A private and two government-operated tankers have been making six trips daily to supply water to the affected areas. PTI

Worth of Baghdad airport project cancelled by Iraq

764 in $ million. Iraqi PM Ali al-Zaidi has decided to cancel the Baghdad International Airport development project after corruption suspicions were raised, Iraqi state media reported. The project involves a $764 million contract awarded to a consortium of Luxembourg-based Corporacion America Airports and Iraqi real estate firm Amwaj International. REUTERS

Offenders arrested in law enforcement actions in T.N.

1,238 Addressing reporters after inspecting the preparatory work for the government exhibition here, Tamil Nadu Minister for School Education and Tamil Development Rajmohan on Sunday revealed that recent law enforcement actions have led to the arrest of 1,238 offenders in the State. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Can India protect its seafarers in Gulf?

How many Indian seafarers are working in the Gulf region? What happened to the three vessels attacked by the U.S. Navy? What sanctions were imposed on some ships? Does the foreign-flag status of the vessels limit India's options? Do international maritime laws protect civilian crews?

EXPLAINER

M. Kalyanaraman

The story so far:

On June 12, after India summoned U.S. Embassy representative Jason Meeks and lodged its "strong protest" against U.S. missile attacks on merchant vessels carrying Indian crew members, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio told External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar that violations of the American blockade and "illicit transport of Iranian oil" would not be tolerated. Recalling his discussion with Mr. Rubio, Mr. Jaishankar posted on X: "I reiterated India's strong protest at the attacks by the U.S. Navy in the Gulf that killed three Indian mariners. Such lethal actions against commercial shipping are not justified."

How many Indians are working on merchant vessels globally?

There are an estimated 3.5 lakh Indian seafarers manning ships across the world. The Indian government estimates that more than half of them are in active service, mostly in foreign-flagged ships.

This means one in every six seafarers serving on large merchant ships worldwide is Indian. The International Maritime Organization (IMO) estimates that some 20,000 seafarers of all nationalities are stranded on ships in the Persian Gulf region. The DG Shipping of India estimated at the start of the crisis that some 23,000 Indian seafarers are serving in the broader Gulf region in various capacities and facilities, with the UAE accounting for more than half.

What happened to the three vessels targeted by the U.S.?

On June 8, 10, and 11, the U.S. Navy fired precision munitions – Hellfire missiles – on merchant vessels *Marivex, Settebello,* and *Jalveer*. The three were tankers carrying Indian crew. While no one was hurt in the case of *Marivex* and *Jalveer*, three Indian seafarers – one chief engineer, one engine fitter, and one deck cadet – died onboard *Settebello*. While *Marivex* was attacked off the coast of Duqm, some 400 nautical miles from the Strait of Hormuz, the others were attacked off the coast of Shinas in Oman, which is closer to the strait.

Videos put out by the United States Central Command (Centcom) show the engine rooms of the ships being hit as well as the steering compartments. These attacks damaged the vessels above the waterline, so water didn't rush in to sink them. But their ability to move and manoeuvre on their own was lost.

In its press releases, the U.S. Centcom has said the crew of *Settebello* and *Marivex* refused to comply with instructions and all of them violated the blockade by attempting to transport Iranian oil. *Marivex* attempted to sail to an Iranian port, it claimed.

While the *Marivex* crew is reported to have informed seafarers' unions that their ship was at anchor while attacked, *Settebello*'s manager, IOS Marine FZE, a firm registered in Ajman, has flatly contradicted the U.S. The company has said *Settebello* was stationary for nearly 10 days in the region. It said the ship had no communication from the U.S. Navy and had no connection with Iranian oil or ports.

What sanctions were imposed on these ships?

Marivex was sanctioned by the U.S. in December 2025 for Iranian connections. *Settebello* had been flagged by a U.S. non-profit advocacy organisation, United Against Nuclear Iran, for alleged Iranian links. U.S. sanctions are not binding on any other country besides the U.S., although the U.S. Treasury Department's sanctions make it difficult for the companies associated with the concerned ship to access the financial system and other business transactions. Quite often, sanctioned ships lose insurance cover, without which ports will not accept calls by the ships, and charterers will refuse to handle cargo through them.

There have been reports of non-compliance of these ships with some maritime regulations. Typically, such violations, not uncommon in merchant shipping, relate to safety aspects. And ships are typically given time to remedy them before the consequences of losing insurance cover can kick in.

The Palau-flagged tanker *MT Settebello*, carrying 24 Indian seafarers, was attacked by U.S. forces off the coast of Oman near the Strait of Hormuz. Three Indian crew members were killed in the strike. ANI

Kamlawati Devi, mother of one of three Indian seafarers killed aboard the tanker *MT Settebello,* mourns at her home in Deoria, Uttar Pradesh, on June 12 . REUTERS

Does the foreign-flag status of the vessels limit India's options?

They all carried foreign flags of convenience (FOCs) but had deep Indian links, including in ownership and management. In merchant shipping, ships are often registered in little-known nations with no infrastructure to rigorously supervise and monitor ships. Popular FOCs include Panama, Marshall Islands, Liberia, and Guinea-Bissau. Such FOCs are also popular among ships transporting Russian and Iranian oil.

Yes, technically, an Indian flagged ship will provide legal sanction for possible action. The U.S., during the Iran-Iraq war, ordered many ships to change their flag to the U.S. so it could legally escort the ships in and out of the Strait of Hormuz. But the Indian Navy has acted against Houthis and Somalian pirates to help Indian seafarers onboard foreign-flagged ships.

Further, *Marivex* and *Jalveer* were often serving Indian ports, facilitating India's enormous oil needs. Soon after the ceasefire was announced in early April, *Marivex* headed out of the Strait of Hormuz to call on Mangalore. *Jalveer* is a bitumen carrier – a special type of ship that carries tar-bitumen, popular in laying Indian roads.

Were other options available for the U.S.?

In the last week of April, the U.S. Navy boarded *Tifani*, a sanctioned very large crude carrier in the Indian Ocean past Sri Lanka. The ship had an Indian crew.

This week, U.K. forces boarded *Smyrtos* on the English Channel for its alleged links to drug cartels, Russian oil, and so on.

Merchant ships are defenceless. Typically, merchant ships have wireless channels open for communication with nearby vessels and any instructions from governments and Navies and Coast Guard vessels are immediately complied with. Seafarers are trained to protect crew, cargo and the ship.

Somalian pirates coming in small craft and carrying firearms could easily board and seize massive oil tankers. The only evasive action ships have against attackers is a high-pressure water jet they can direct at them.

What can India do to protect Indian seafarers in the region?

India did launch Operation Sankalp to protect merchant ships against Houthi attacks. Indian Navy and Coast Guard intervened to protect four merchant ships in 2024. India did take action against Somalian pirates. But the belligerents in the Persian Gulf are the U.S. and Iran. Therefore, India's options are rather limited.

Does international maritime law adequately protect civilian crews?

The nodal agency for regulating global shipping is the IMO, a United Nations agency. Though the IMO has the means to regulate the technical, commercial, environmental and safety aspects of global shipping through consensus and rulemaking, it has often fallen short in protecting ships and seafarers. Quite often, national governments take unilateral action, and typical of an UN agency, the IMO has been unable to act to prevent or take remedial action.

The law governing the oceans is the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS). Its acts and mandates are extensive and are an outcome of decades of negotiations and consensus-building. UNCLOS is thorough and considers various situations, including transits across straits such as the Hormuz. But many nations have not signed on to it. The U.S. refused to sign it on the grounds that UNCLOS considers the deep seabed as the commons. Iran has signed the convention but has not ratified it. There really is no overarching body for enforcement. Things are often left to the good sense of governments.

THE GIST

- India has protested U.S. missile attacks on three merchant vessels carrying Indian crew in the Gulf, in which three Indian seafarers aboard *Settebello* were killed.
- The U.S. says the vessels violated its blockade and were involved in transporting Iranian oil, but ship operators have disputed these claims and said some of the vessels were stationary when attacked.
- With about 23,000 Indian seafarers in the Gulf region, India has limited options because the vessels were foreign-flagged, while international maritime bodies and laws have limited enforcement powers in such situations.

CACHE

The success of Amazon, the largest e-commerce retailer in the world, can be credited at least in part to drop shipping practices. REUTERS

What is drop shipping, and what are the risks for online shoppers?

Drop shipping allows online individuals or agents who do not hold any products to take customer orders and pass them on to other makers or sellers, inserting themselves into the transaction as middlemen; while legal in most jurisdictions, the practice can expose customers to several risks

Sahana Venugopal

While scrolling through Instagram Reels, you naturally pause when an attractive product catches your eye: a sleek laptop bag for travel, a cheap set of popular novels, an ultra-fast wireless charger on sale, beautifully embroidered linen shirts, or leather-bound notebooks with custom gold foil inscriptions. Before you know it, you are entering your credit card number or UPI PIN.

Caught up in your shopping spree, you may not have checked the true origin of the product or other customers' reviews of the seller. What's more, you may not even realise that the "company" you paid is just a decorated webpage created with AI and owned by a person who does not hold a single product.

This is the economy of drop shipping: the business practice that allows almost anyone with an internet connection to sell products that come from others.

Here is what you should know as a customer.

What is drop shipping?

This is a business practice where an online individual or agent – who does not hold any product – takes orders from customers and passes them on to another maker/seller who actually holds the product. The product is then delivered to the customers, either by the original maker/seller or a third-party delivery service. To put it simply, the drop shipper inserts itself into the transaction as a middleman. One or even multiple drop shippers might stand between buyers and the original makers of the product they want.

The success of Amazon, the largest e-commerce retailer in the world, can be credited at least in part to drop shipping practices. In its earliest days, Amazon did not commandeer giant international warehouses packed with products; rather, the company was a web-based middleman that fulfilled many customers' orders by sourcing the books they wanted.

Though Amazon's product delivery model has drastically evolved, the company allows drop shipping to take place via its platform. Other channels, such as Shopify, also enable drop shipping and help users manage the logistics. Alternatively, drop shipping might take place through channels such as WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, and lesser-known websites.

In essence, if you have ever bought any product online, there's a chance that you placed your order through a drop shipper rather than the original seller.

How does drop shipping work?

Drop shippers can work with both domestic and international manufacturers and customers. Some try to fill an existing gap in their local market (such as affordable school textbooks), some capitalise on market trends (such as the popularity of iPhone cases), and others build hype around rarer products (such as foreign luxury fashion). Most importantly, the drop shipper does not need to buy or store any of the products they are selling.

Drop shipping has become a popular source of income for both public-facing Instagram creators monetising their virality as well as private marketers looking for discreet revenue streams. What's more, with AI automating many customer services and harvesting business insights, drop shipping feels like something that almost anyone with an internet connection can try out.

In addition to promoting products and setting up online storefronts, drop shippers may also buy/sell courses that reveal current market trends, customer interests, trusted wholesalers, and useful AI tools, in order to generate further profits.

Drop shipping might look illogical at first, but it is in vogue for a number of reasons.

Buyers trying to independently source foreign products from a wholesaler might be forced to order more than they need, or contend with complicated customs regulations and fees. They also may not know if the original seller is legitimate, or might be unable to communicate with them due to a language barrier.

However, placing orders through a vetted drop shipper with a user-friendly web page eases some of these worries. What's more, legitimate drop shippers regularly carry out quality assurance tests of their own, and should ideally become a customer support layer of sorts in order to resolve any complaints.

Is drop shipping legal?

Drop shipping is legal in most jurisdictions, as long as the participants involved ensure transparency and comply with their region's tax laws.

Instagram's commerce eligibility requirements state that the users' Facebook Pages or Instagram professional accounts must contain product listings that are available for direct purchase from the user's website. In case buyers are being directed to another website, the user must provide the domain through which they sell, and their channels must represent the shop associated with the domain.

But now that it is possible to create entire shopfronts and e-commerce websites in minutes with just some cheap domains and a few AI coding prompts, Instagram drop shippers can easily present themselves as original sellers and offload customer orders to other sellers. Videos of workers sorting through wrapped packages, or Reels of founders happily holding up stacks of paper that they claim are customer orders, can mislead social media shoppers into thinking they are dealing directly with a trusted seller.

Ultimately, the line separating influencers, marketers, and sellers can blur quickly on social media. Some drop shippers also ask customers to contact them via WhatsApp, to take their communication off the app. Buyers may not know where their products are actually coming from or how their data privacy rights are being eroded. And as supply chain transparency is lost, drop shipping operations can quickly slide into a legal grey area or end up in criminal violations.

Some risks include scams targeting customers, as well as scams targeting drop shippers. Original sellers and drop shippers may both inflate product prices.

Drop shippers might also work with wholesalers sending out defective/rejected products. Furthermore, drop shippers may unknowingly promote pirated/counterfeit products. Hyper-realistic AI product images can mislead both customers and casual drop shippers.

Meanwhile, delivery timelines can be long – if the product even arrives at all. The drop shipper may not be required to take responsible for any safety or hygiene standards that have to be maintained while shipping the products.

Adding to this, multiple drop shipping layers in different countries can inadvertently lead to sanctions violations. In case of complaints, cancellations, or refund requests, customers may have no choice except to cut their losses and move on.

Other dangers include pyramid schemes to recruit more drop shippers, or even cyber-crimes via phishing and hacks, as the customers' payment information is shared with multiple parties without their informed consent.

So, the next time you spot a book influencer on Instagram promoting a handy new reading light, or stumble across an excited founder surrounded by sacks of customer orders, take a few minutes to do your research and find out who is really selling you the product.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Marking the birth anniversary of Mona Lisa, this quiz explores art, history, symbolism, and enduring mysteries surrounding Leonardo da Vinci's most famous portrait

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
Who is widely believed to be the woman depicted in the Mona Lisa?

QUESTION 2
Around what year is Leonardo da Vinci believed to have begun painting the Mona Lisa?

QUESTION 3
What is the approximate size of the Mona Lisa?

QUESTION 4
Which artistic technique, heavily employed in the Mona Lisa, creates the painting's characteristic soft transitions between light and shadow?

QUESTION 5
Which French king acquired the Mona Lisa for the royal collection?

QUESTION 6
What major event in 1911 dramatically increased the painting's worldwide fame?

Visual Question: Which Italian Renaissance master executed this sketch of a young woman before a landscape, believed to have been directly influenced by Leonardo's Mona Lisa? PUBLIC DOMAIN

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Which Goalkeeper holds the record for most consecutive clean sheets, as well as most consecutive minutes without conceding a goal in World Cup history? **Ans: Walter Zenga, Italy. 5 matches / 517 minutes during the 1990 edition**
2. Which Manager holds the record of having won the most tournaments in World Cup history? **Ans: Vittorio Pozzo, Italy – 1934 & 1938**
3. Who is the only player to have won 4 medals in the World Cup history? **Ans: Miroslav Klose, Germany – 4 (Silver in 2002, Bronze in 2006 & 2010 & Gold in 2014)**
4. Which player has the distinction of having scored at least one goal in all five tournaments that he played? **Ans: Cristiano Ronaldo, Portugal**
5. Which was the first World Cup to be held outside Europe and the Americas, and who hosted it? **Ans: 1970 with Mexico as host**
Visual: Identify the player and what is the unique record that he possesses in World Cup history? **Ans: Gabriel Batistuta, Argentina, the only player to have scored a hat-trick in two consecutive World Cups – 1994 & 1998 both on June 21 of that year.**

No one got all the answers correct

KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

The company is trying not to go under

Some people think he has nothing between the ears

S. Upendran

"What are you doing here? I thought you were taking two weeks off, and going to..."

"Got a call from my sister a couple of days ago. Her company isn't doing too well, and..."

"According to most newspaper reports, the company your sister works for is going under."

"Does it mean it's sinking?"

"Exactly! The company is being compared to a sinking ship."

"I read somewhere that when the Titanic hit the iceberg, the ship went under very quickly."

"When you use 'went under' with a company, it means that it's going bankrupt. It's like a sinking ship."

"In other words, it's a company that's failing."

"Yes! Here's an example. During the epidemic, several businesses went under."

"When one company goes under, there's usually a chain reaction."

"That's true. If the bank doesn't give us a loan, the project is likely to go under."

"That's the good news! The company that my sister works for is likely to get a substantial loan from the bank."

"That should keep the company afloat for a while. Is your sister worried about the downsizing that is likely to happen?"

"What are you talking about? Are you talking about people getting fired?"

"Companies don't use the term 'fire' anymore. They 'lay off' people or they talk about 'downsizing' the company. In other words, they reduce the number of people working."

"In other words, you downsize by firing some of your workers."

"That's right! People lose their jobs. But downsize sounds better, that's all! It's the politically correct term. The CEO told the Managers that they should find ways to downsize the workforce by 20%."

"I don't think there'll be any downsizing in my sister's company."

"It's bound to happen. In everyday contexts, downsize is used to mean to move into a smaller accommodation. After retirement, my aunt and uncle downsized and moved into a small flat."

"That's what my mother wants to do. But my father doesn't believe in downsizing."

"It's probably because they aren't involved in the running of the house."

"I know what you mean. The good news is the company that my sister is working for is replacing the CEO."

"Any idea who the replacement is?"

"It's your friend Ramesh's cousin - Jagdeep. Know him?"

"No. I hope he's nothing like Ramesh."

"Why not? Ramesh is a nice guy."

"I agree. The problem is, he has nothing between his ears."

"What are you talking about?"

"The expression is mostly used in informal contexts to talk about one's intelligence."

"I see. So, when you say that someone has nothing between the ears, what you mean is that he's not bright."

"No real common sense. Why would you go to someone like Jyothi for advice? The girl has nothing between the ears."

"I find it difficult to have a conversation with my neighbour. The guy has nothing between the ears."

"But he has a lot of money. That's good enough."

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Word of the day

Humdinger:
Someone or something remarkable

Synonyms: wonder, marvel, phenomenon

Usage: *The film's ending was a humdinger.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/humdinger

International Phonetic Alphabet: /hʌmdɪŋə/

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